

CHRISTOPHER ARTINIAN



MADHOUSE

Christopher Artinian

OceanofPDF.com

Madhouse © 2024 by Christopher Artinian. All Rights Reserved.

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means including information storage and retrieval systems, without permission in writing from the author. The only exception is by a reviewer, who may quote short excerpts in a review.

Cover designed by Christian Bentulan

This book is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents either are products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

Christopher Artinian
Visit my website at www.christopherartinian.com

OceanofPDF.com

Dedication
To Miss G and Mr S.

OceanofPDF.com

For exclusive content and the latest news, join my mailing list. Claim a free book too. All you need to do is click the link:

<https://dl.bookfunnel.com/1v9xdaxx77>

[OceanofPDF.com](https://oceanofpdf.com)

PROLOGUE

Ava had been looking forward to this trip for the longest time. Her parents were not fully on board with it, but they didn't possess her zest for life, her love of travel, of discovery.

Europe was a world away from Hurt, her home town in Virginia. *Why in the good Lord's name haven't they changed its name yet?* But it was where she needed to be. She'd finished her final year at Princeton, but before she took the leap into gainful employment, she wanted to make the trip she'd been dreaming of for a lifetime. She'd worked stacking shelves all summer to add to the holiday coffers and the time to reap the reward had arrived.

Eight weeks backpacking around Europe was not her parents' idea of a dream trip, especially in autumn. Hotels, swimming pools, restaurants and theatres were what they would deem necessary for something to be called a dream. Ava had purchased a one-person tent, a small camping stove, food and consumables within half an hour of getting off the plane in Edinburgh. She pretty much had everything else she needed. She even had a spare solar charger for her phone. She was going to document the whole trip and upload it to her blog whenever she could piggyback a Wi-Fi signal so as not to have to drain her data plan.

The first night, she had sprung for the luxury of a hotel. A nice hotel too. After all, this was the start of her vacation. She'd eaten out at a fine restaurant, gone to see a show at Edinburgh Playhouse, then had one of the best night's sleep she'd had in a long time.

She was up at five a.m., too excited to lie in bed any longer. She checked out of the hotel and hopped on a train. She had a rough route mapped out in her head. She'd got details of all the hostels along the way, but if her timing was off or she decided to stay somewhere else, then that was the beauty of having a tent. She could simply find a level patch of land and pitch for the night.

There was something magical about Scotland. Beyond the friendliness of the people, the beauty of the landscape, the history of the place, there was something intangible that gave her a special feeling in her stomach.

This was just the start of her journey and she was only due to spend five days here, but she could tell as soon as she saw the castle standing proudly at the heart of the city that Scotland was going to take some beating.

For the moment, though, frustration had crept up on her. Her destination for the evening was Pitlochry, but there was no phone signal where she was and she'd managed to get herself all turned around. She'd also done something that she'd promised her parents she wouldn't under any circumstances.

Idiot. Idiot. Idiot.

She'd got into a van with a stranger offering her a ride. He was an old man and seemingly friendly, but still ... *Stupid.*

It turned out she could barely understand a word he said due to his accent and she was pretty sure he didn't understand her. There was something about him that really put her on edge and, within a few minutes of getting in the vehicle, which now she came to think of it reminded her a little of the van in a horror film she'd seen once, she had wanted to get out.

She'd made an excuse that the countryside was too beautiful to view out of the window and so she wanted to continue her journey on foot. He'd protested saying it wasn't a good idea, which had unnerved Ava even more and made her more insistent on getting out, and now here she was on a long road surrounded by forest with not a house or a road sign in sight.

It was beautiful, but the whole thing with the old man had creeped her out a bit and suddenly Scotland had lost a little bit of its sheen. It was late afternoon and the sun, which had been shining for most of the day, had dropped behind thick clouds.

It's going to be getting dark soon.

She thought about the tent on her back before angling her head left and then right. The forest on both sides of the road was dense, uninviting, a little foreboding.

She had travelled by herself from the USA and this was the first time she'd experienced any inhibitions. Her skin prickled a little as her eyes continued to sweep the treescape.

Don't be a Nervous Nellie.

One of her mother's favourite sayings came back to her as she walked along. *Don't be a Nervous Nellie.*

She reached into her pocket for her phone. She'd surreptitiously taken a photo of the van before getting inside and that was still on the screen as she side-swiped. She held it up in front of her, higher and higher, in the hope that a bar might appear, but there was nothing.

I'd give anything to speak to Mom right now.

She tapped the Whatsapp icon and scrolled up. Her mother had left her a message when she'd had her phone on mute in the theatre.

"Hi there, darlin'. It's just your mom checking in on you. I'm guessing you decided to go see that show after all. I hope you're having a good time, sweetheart. You be safe now and I'll talk to you later. Love you."

A wave of emotion suddenly swept over Ava. She'd gone away to college. She'd spent plenty of time away from her mother, but she was missing her at that moment more than she had in a long time. Ava sniffed deeply, sticking out her chest and shaking her head.

"Come on, girl. Don't you start falling apart now. You're meant to be having the experience of a lifetime."

The road ahead dipped down before rising to another peak a mile or so away. There was no break in the forest.

She let out a long sigh. *I may as well take advantage of this quiet time.*

She hit the camera icon on her phone, selected video and then pressed the rotating arrows button so her face was on screen as she raised the device up in front of her. She adjusted her hair and then pressed record.

"Well, this is me in the heart of Scotland. I'm on my way to a place called Pitlochry, but I got a little bit turned around earlier and I'm not sure if I'm going to make it there before nightfall, so I might just have to find a good spot to put up my tent." She reached around into her bag as she carried on walking.

"Don't worry, though, I'm not going to go hungry." She held up a plastic carton. "They say when in Rome, and I say when in Scotland. I've bought myself a haggis to try. I can't say the description of what it is sold me on the idea, but I'm on this trip thousands of miles away from home, in this place with so much wonderful history and culture, so it would be a crime not to immerse myself in it." She put the pack back in her bag and retrieved a small tube of Pringles. "I've got extra supplies just in case too."

She smiled her special smile. The smile that lit up her face and the faces of all those who witnessed it. “I’ll upload this when I can and, hopefully, tomorrow I’ll get to show you all the beautiful little town of Pitlochry, which has everything from a castle to a fish ladder. Well, I’m going to sign off now and see if I can get a few more miles behind me before nightfall. See you all soon.”

She hit the stop button and waited for the video to render before putting the phone back in her pocket and continuing her journey. With each minute that passed by, the sky got darker, seemingly doing the same to the forest.

SNAP!

She swivelled, stopping dead in her tracks and peering into the woods only to see nothing.

Don’t be a Nervous Nellie. Her mother’s words came back to her again, but this time, it was harder to take heed. She stayed glued to the spot for a few seconds.

It’s probably a deer, idiot. Or a fox or a boar or one of a hundred different animals. I’m in the middle of nowhere, surrounded by nature. I haven’t seen a house or anything like that for miles. Don’t start getting skittish.

She hoisted her backpack a little higher and set off once more, irritated with herself but at the same time still a little nervous.

SNAP!

The noise came again, louder this time, louder than what she deemed possible to be the sound of a hoof stepping on a fallen twig or branch.

“He-llo.” She cleared her throat. “Hello. Is there anybody there?”

She was greeted by silence. She listened carefully and now it seemed even all the birds had stopped singing and squawking. Her eyes panned from side to side, scouring the woodland for any clue as to what could have made the sound.

Nothing. Nothing. Nothing. Noth—what the fuck was that?

A heavy-looking, low-hanging branch swayed wildly as her eyes shot back to it. Her heart started to beat faster. A bird taking flight could not have caused the bough to sway like that. If a stag’s antlers had collided with it at force, she would have heard it.

Something was hiding in that tree. Something was watching me.

The revelation sent a frigid shudder down her spine. That was it. That’s what she had felt ever since getting out of the old man’s van. She’d felt like

she was being watched, observed.

“Is somebody there?” she called out again.

SNAP!

This time, the sound came from behind her and she spun around to see a cropping of bushes shuddering.

“Whoever you are, this isn’t funny and when my boyfriend catches up, you’d better not be around ’cause he plays football and he’s got a temper you wouldn’t believe, so ha-ha, you’ve had your little prank; now you should just scam while you still can.”

She glanced to the road behind her, trying to give the impression that her imaginary boyfriend would be heading around the corner any minute. She shifted her gaze, looking to the horizon. At best, there was only another twenty minutes or so before the sun went down.

Shit! Shit! Shit! Shit!

A barely audible whimper left her throat. She cast her eyes to the two spots where she’d seen movement, but now she saw nothing. Without saying another word, she started walking again, faster than before. She kept glancing from left to right, searching, hoping she was wrong, but somehow, she knew she wasn’t.

Clack! Clack! Clack!

It was a sound she’d heard a thousand times before. It was a childhood memory. She and her friends, playing out back. hitting a stick against a tree trunk.

Clack! Clack! Clack!

She sniffed and another whimper left her lips, louder this time. Fear-fuelled tears started to stream from her eyes.

Clack! Clack! Clack!

Whoever was doing this had the sole intention of putting the fear of hell and damnation into her. They were deaf to her earlier questions and she still hadn’t seen them, but they’d obviously seen her.

She started running. It wasn’t easy with a thirty-five-pound backpack, but it was her only option. Her feet slapped heavily against the tarmac. She’d tried to break in her new walking boots a little before setting off from the States, but she could feel them chafing her feet as she put as much distance between her and those sounds as she could.

Clack! Clack! Clack!

They were further back. She was leaving them behind. Whoever was making those sounds wasn't coming after her. She started running faster, the tiniest scintilla of relief washing over her as the sounds came again, even more distant this time.

Clack! Clack! Clack!

Still, she carried on running. She was already sweating. It was hard work, her coat was thick and she was wearing substantial woolly socks, but she had no intention of losing the advantage she'd already gained.

Stride after stride after stride. One foot in front of the other, then again, then again, then again, then again, then—"AAGHH!"

Ava became airborne for just a second, crashing down onto the road face first. Her frame flattened against the tarmac, all air escaping her lungs, the rough surface scraping against her cheek.

My ribs. My hands.

She remained there for a second before painfully rising to her knees. She looked at her palms to see the heels of her hands torn and bleeding. She raised her fingers to her face, pulling them away to see still more blood.

"Shit!"

She gently pressed against her rib cage, trying hard not to get blood on her jacket.

"OW!"

She looked down to see that she shouldn't have worried about the blood. Her three-hundred-dollar jacket was torn and one of the pockets was hanging off.

"Oh no." More tears rolled down her cheeks. This had been a present from her grandmother, celebrating her trip.

CLACK! CLACK! CLACK!

A terrified breath caught in her throat. The sound was closer than ever. She started to climb to her feet but let out another stifled scream as a hand covered her face and something sharp pierced her neck.

Darkness.



When Ava woke, it took a few moments for her to realise just how much trouble she was in. Her head was heavy, fuzzy, as if she was coming around from an anaesthetic.

She tried to move her body only to discover she couldn't. Her wrists were strapped to what she assumed was a bed. She lifted her head to see that her ankles were secured too. She was naked and her ribs were dark purple from the fall.

The room seemed to be some kind of operating theatre. She could hear music from somewhere outside.

What the hell's going on?

"HELP! SOMEONE HELP ME!"

"Shouting won't do any good, I'm afraid."

She turned suddenly to see an older man strapped to an identical bed. He was naked too, but his eyes didn't share the fear she was obviously feeling.

"Who are you? Where am I? What's happening?" Her voice was croaky and strained as she heard herself. The words were those of a panicky, frightened child. And a flood of warning memories from her mother and father about taking a solo trip to Europe suddenly rushed to batter her.

"You're American?"

"Please," she said, starting to cry. "Please tell me what's going on."

"I'm afraid, my dear, that this is all my fault."

"I don't understand."

"Well, you and me both." The man, in his fifties with white hair, spoke with an accent that suggested he had not struggled in life.

"Please tell me what's happening."

"Well, I suppose the inevitable is happening. I mean doesn't it always?"

Another rush of tears streamed down Ava's face. "You're not making any sense. I don't understand what's going on."

"Ohhh, my dear, my dear. Where do I begin?"

"P-please, begin by telling me what this is. Where are we? What's happening?"

"What's happening? Well, I think we're finding proof that there is a God Almighty and he has a truly wicked sense of humour."

She sobbed again. "What do you mean?"

"I mean, my dear, imagine you had almost everything you ever wanted. Imagine you had a fortune earned through designing drugs that would help millions of people with life-shortening diseases. Imagine working alongside

the woman you loved more than anybody else on the planet every single day. Imagine having the freedom to decide what you were going to do, what project you were going to undertake next for the betterment of humankind. Imagine being revered by peers and politicians alike because your mind was truly a once-in-a-generation phenomenon. Imagine having all of that but not the thing you longed for, not the thing you and your wife longed for, a child.”

“What are you talking about? Why are you telling me this?”

“You asked a question and I’m giving you the answer. Being deprived of such a joy as that of children could easily make one question the existence of God and, indeed, it did. Unable to conceive, we went to doctor after doctor, took part in trial after trial, and then, when we were sure the hope of us ever having children was gone for good, we found out we were pregnant. Not just pregnant but pregnant with quintuplets.” He let out a fond laugh as Ava just remained there, trapped and bewildered.

“Quintuplets,” he repeated. “God didn’t do that. Science did that. But God’s role in our story was not over as I had believed. Imagine discovering your newly born quintuplets all possessed a fatal recessive gene that resulted in a drawn-out, humiliating, degrading, agonising death. You see, God didn’t want us to have children. That’s why he wouldn’t let us get pregnant. And then, when we did, he wanted to make sure that they didn’t last long enough to become our legacy.” The man laughed once more, a little more maniacally this time.

“I’m sorry,” Ava said shakily. “That’s horrible. But what does it have to do with why I’m here?”

“Oh, I’ve still to come to the best part, my dear. My wife and I had worked on cures for many diseases. So, when we found out our children would develop Huntington’s, we put all other projects on hold. I sold my stake in Graaf Pharmaceuticals and we moved out here. I built a cutting-edge lab and medical facility on the property, and while my darling wife raised five children, I went about the task of finding the answer to our problem.

“Months became years. The children went to school and had normal lives just like any other kids. That’s the thing with Huntington’s, you see. The symptoms don’t manifest until much later in life. They were sweet, loving, showed exceptional intelligence, and while they were at school, my wife came back to work in the lab with me. We ran model after model after

model, day in day out for several more years until one day, we found it. We found a way to mutate the gene so our children wouldn't develop Huntington's.

"Unfortunately, it would be of no use to those already suffering from the condition, and ninety-nine-point-nine percent of people don't know they've got it until it's too late. My wife and I have never tested on animals, not just because of the abject cruelty but also because it doesn't work. Do you know the failure rates vary from fifty to ninety-nine percent? I mean, what's the point? No. We ran the simulations over and over and over again until we were sure. As sure as we've been with any of our work. So, we took our children out of school and initiated what was to be a fairly long course of gene therapy on them. It takes some time to mutate a gene. During their treatment, my wife and I decided to attempt to repair the faulty genes in each of us that caused their fatal genes, thereby providing a pre-emptive measure for this disease so others wouldn't have to go through what we went through."

He paused and a sad smile crept onto his face. "We were incredibly proud of ourselves. We'd saved our offspring from what would have been a truly torturous illness and we had the prospect of removing the risk for prospective parents who were in the same position as us. Of course, there was no way we could have anticipated what happened next."

Ava let out another stifled sob and turned her head away from the man, instead looking up at the ceiling. *He's mad or senile or something. I'm stuck in here with this guy and he's telling me his life story.*

"One by one, they went completely and utterly insane."

Her head shot back towards him. "What?"

"Yes. It was something that there was no way for us to predict and it is the ultimate proof that there is a God."

"What are you talking about?"

"Think about it. He didn't want us to have children. But we found a way around it. When the children were born, he gave them an illness to make sure they wouldn't live full lives. We found a way around that too. So, he sent them all completely mad. And trust me, I've tried my hardest to find a way back, but he's finally won."

Goosebumps rippled over Ava's naked skin. "So, it's your children. Your children are the ones who brought me here?"

"Yes. I'm afraid so. Two of them anyway."

“Two of them?”

“Yes. Given their IQs, I suppose it was inevitable that their madness wouldn’t be your garden-variety madness. And....”

“And what?”

He let out a long sigh. “And I dropped the ball. I was trying so hard to find a solution to the problem that I didn’t realise my own wife was following them into lunacy. She was nurturing them, nurturing their talents and interests. Y’see psychosis is something that isn’t that uncommon in geniuses. My wife, and indeed I, had instances of it in our families, and although there are certain gene traits that can point to it, there’s no way of identifying it in the same way you can identify the Huntington’s gene for example. So, you wanted to know how you got here, my dear? Well, that’s your answer.”

“What are they going to do to me?”

“It’s hard to say.” A sinister smile crept onto his face and Ava’s skin prickled once more. The man suddenly sat up, relinquishing the unfastened straps from his wrists and ankles, swivelling and letting his legs dangle over the side of the bed. “Very hard to say.” The smile became a wide-toothed grin.

It took Ava a moment to understand what was happening and then it hit her like a speed train. “Oh my God, no. NOOO! NOOO! NOOO!” Floods of tears streamed down her face as she screamed at the top of her voice.

“NOOO! NOOO! NOOO!” The man mimicked before bursting out laughing and clapping his hands.

“NOOO! NOOO! NOOO!” A chorus of echoed cries came from behind the long mirror on the wall. It, too, was followed by maniacal laughter.

Ava strained against the straps holding her down. She pulled and heaved and twisted, but she knew no amount of struggling would save her. She knew that this trip she had planned and longed for would be the last one she ever took.

CHAPTER 1

It wasn't so much a downpour as a deluge. Claire Trent, or Miss T as she was known to her pupils, almost had her head pressed against the windscreen of the minibus as she tried her hardest to negotiate the road ahead.

The journey from Chester had been hampered by roadworks, rush hour traffic and even an escaped cow. The diversion they'd taken a good half hour back had been on the advice of two of her students who were monitoring traffic reports and, by using Google Maps, had come up with a solution to the stationary traffic that would hamper their journey.

However, no one had any bars now, and the traffic reports and all other contact with the outside world was lost. The dark, the sheet rain, and the relentless wind created a mix of conditions that meant they'd had to reduce speed to a snail's pace and the odd gust kept smashing against the side of the vehicle making Claire's hands wrap ever tighter around the steering wheel.

"What do you reckon?" asked Millie, the other supervising adult on the trip. She was twenty-three but often got mistaken for one of the sixth-form pupils she taught. She'd been subbing at the school to cover illness and that's how she'd got involved with the drama class and met Claire. In a short time, they'd become good friends and she'd done plenty of unpaid work in the last few months to ensure the group's production of *Look Back in Anger* had been a roaring success. With just six pupils, the drama programme was teetering on the edge of being shut down. However, the production hadn't just won plaudits from the community, but a clip on TikTok, which went viral, meant the single three-night run was extended to four three-night runs at the school theatre across as many weeks. This had helped to swell the John Douglas High School's finances and resulted in a record number of pupils wanting to sign up for the following year's course, subsequently ensuring the safety of the programme. This trip was a reward of sorts.

“I reckon this just about sums my week up pretty well,” Claire replied as another wall of rain crashed against the windscreen.

“Do you think we should turn back?”

Claire let out a long sigh. Her pupils were all engaged in their own conversations in the back of the bus, so she felt confident their chat would not be overheard. “In all honesty, I don’t want to risk it.”

“What do you mean?”

“When did you last see a petrol station?”

“Before we turned off.”

“Exactly. About half an hour ago. We’ve got to come to another one soon.”

Millie arched her neck to look at the fuel gauge. “Shit!” she whispered just as another blast of rain hit the windscreen. They both looked out at the road. Even though their visibility was limited, all they could see were trees lining both sides and there was nothing ahead but stormy darkness.

“Miss T, are we lost?” called a voice from the back. The barrage of wind and rain meant everyone had to speak in elevated tones just to be heard.

“For your sake, I hope not, Zack,” Claire replied.

“Why for my sake?”

“Who was it who came up with this alternate route for us?”

“Me and Kayla.”

“Uh-huh. So how much of a beating do you think your classmates are going to dish out if we end up lost in the Scottish countryside with no phone signal and in the middle of a raging storm?”

“Have you seen this lot, Miss? I’ll take my chances.”

Everyone laughed. Even Claire for the briefest of moments. “No. We’re not lost, Zack. We haven’t veered since we started down this route and I have faith in Kayla that if she says this will lead to a road that gets us back on track without getting stuck in traffic again then it will.”

“I helped come up with this too.”

“Yeah. Like I said, I have faith in Kayla that she wouldn’t send us on a wild goose chase.” Again, they all laughed. “Has anybody got a signal yet?”

“I don’t think we’re going to get a signal out here, Miss T,” Javed replied, holding his phone up a little higher.

“What are you doing?” Zack asked.

“Sometimes, if you move your phone around a bit, you can catch a bar.”

“Seriously? We’re in the middle of a fucking forest and—”

“Language, Zack,” Claire scolded.

“We’re not in school.”

“No, we’re not. But we should still show respect for one another, don’t you think?”

Zack let out a long sigh. “Dunno.”

“Zack!”

“Ugh. Yeah, I suppose.”

“I’m starving,” came another voice from the back and Claire’s shoulders sagged a little further.

“Hopefully, we’ll be at the hotel in another hour or so and then I’ll treat us all to a takeaway for supper. There’s meant to be a really nice Indian restaurant in Pitlochry.” Even though Claire had eaten what would have once felt like a lot, the tablets she was on gave her a voracious appetite.

“Do they do vegan food?” Natalie, another of the pupils, asked.

“Um. Y’know what, I didn’t actually check, but I bet you anything they do. I mean, most places have vegan options now, don’t they?”

“It doesn’t matter if they don’t, Miss. We can just nip into someone’s garden and steal a bit of grass for her. Problem solved,” Zack quipped.

They all laughed apart from Natalie and Claire immediately felt guilty for the small chuckle that left her lips. “Fuck you, micro dick. Just ’cause I’ve got a conscience and you—”

“Language!” Claire cried. “What did I just say about respect?” Another violent gust hit the minibus and she gripped the wheel like a vice once more. “Natalie, apologise.”

“He started it.”

“I was only joking,” Zack replied.

Claire exhaled a long, tired breath and pulled over to the side of the road. They hadn’t seen any other traffic for twenty minutes, so she wasn’t worried that she’d be blocking the carriageway. She turned around in her seat and flicked on the internal light. The minibus had little in the way of facilities. It was fifteen years old and had been looked after well, but it was hardly luxury travel. There was no GPS, no mini fridge, and three of the arm rests were missing, but it served its purpose. “Don’t make me regret bringing you all on this trip,” she began. “I wanted this to be special.

Something you'd remember for the rest of your lives." Her eyes sought out each of them as she spoke. "We're going to see one of the last performances by arguably one of the finest actors of his generation and it's in a spectacular part of the country."

"No offence, Miss T," called out one of the pupils as they wiped the window and stared into the blackness beyond, "but it doesn't look that beautiful from where I'm sitting."

"Yes. Thank you for that, Amanda. This isn't the start I wanted for this trip. I thought we'd be there by now, having a nice meal and enjoying each other's company. I'm sorry, okay?"

"It's not your fault, Miss T. You couldn't help the traffic and shit," Zack replied.

"Well, I'm not sure Mr Moggs will see it that way when he finds out we got lost in the Scottish countryside."

"I thought you said we weren't lost," Ethan said.

"Well, not lost but diverted. Anyway, I just wanted this trip to be—"

"You don't have to worry, Miss," Javed said. "None of us will say a word to Moggs."

"Yeah," Amanda replied.

"Yeah," the others agreed in unison.

"Yeah," Zack said again. "You're one of us, Miss T. Nobody would ever say anything that'd get you in trouble or nothing."

Claire gulped. "That's ... that's really sweet." A tear appeared in the corner of her eye, but she quickly wiped it away. "You know I love you guys, don't you?"

"Yeah. We know, Miss T," Kayla said. "We love you too."

Claire nodded and sniffed as she turned back around in her seat and switched the light off. "Right then," she said, releasing the handbrake and setting off. "Let's get to Pitlochry."

A small cheer went up in the back and Millie reached across, giving Claire's arm a little squeeze. "Are you okay?" she asked as the others returned to their conversations in the back.

Claire wiped another tear from her eye and nodded. "Yeah. The tiniest things can set me off these days."

"No real surprise, considering."

"I suppose," she replied, sniffing again. "I'm a bit of a wreck, truth be told."

“You know I’m here. Anything you need, I’m here.”

It was Claire’s turn to reach out and squeeze Millie’s arm now. “Thank you. I just—WAAHH!” She jammed on the brakes. Hers was not the only scream to go up.

The windscreen wipers continued to move at high speed, but the vehicle remained static for a moment. They’d just driven onto a short bridge and everyone had felt the road dip dramatically, hence the screams and the speedy application of the brakes.

“What was that, Miss?” Zack asked.

Despite the lashing rain, Claire could just make out the high, fast-flowing river passing not that far beneath them.

“I don’t know,” she replied.

“It felt like SHIII—” Millie’s words were cut off as a section of tarmac in front of them vanished. There was a deafening crash as the underside of the minibus crunched against the crumbling bridge and the front end of the vehicle plummeted a few feet.

“JESUS CHRIST!” Claire cried out above the other fear-filled screams as the river came into clearer view for them all. The vehicle remained at a near forty-five-degree angle, the front end pointing down at the fast-moving water as the bridge ahead crumbled further. The rear was mashed against the road surface for the moment, but no one was under any illusions about that lasting. Claire jammed the gear stick into reverse and eased off the clutch while pressing down on the accelerator. The engine whirred, then roared, but there was no movement. *The wheels aren’t in contact with the road. THE WHEELS AREN’T IN CONTACT WITH THE ROAD.*

There was another deafening crunch followed by a chorus of petrified screams as the front end dipped further. The headlights did nothing but amplify the horror as the violent torrent surged.

“MISS!” A single voice cried and Claire pulled on the handbrake and disengaged the gear.

“EVERYBODY OUT! EVERYBODY OUT OF THE BACK DOORS, NOW!”

Ethan, who had been gripping onto his seat like the others, trying his hardest not to fall forward as the vehicle’s front end dipped, levered himself up and shoulder-barged the back doors. The wind howled as he grasped one of the rear grab rails while offering his hand to Kayla, who took it gratefully. Further screams and fear-filled shouts continued to echo within

the compartment as the storm raged outside. One after another, the pupils climbed, using the seats as anchors so they would not fall forward.

Claire and Millie clambered over their seats before starting the ascent to the open doors at the back. Then Millie stopped suddenly and turned.

“What are you doing?” Claire demanded.

“Keep going,” Millie ordered as she carefully retraced her steps, praying she would have time before the bus plunged further.

She stretched, reaching into the footwell for Claire’s bag. It would be too cumbersome to take her own too and it was her friend’s that was the important one. She turned to resume her climb to the rear doors when there was a whoosh followed by screeching metal and the minibus dropped further. Terrified cries erupted once more, but four of the pupils were outside now. Ethan and Zack were holding on at the rear, helping Claire, and all three of them let out loud, panicked shouts as the water started to hammer against the front end of the minibus.

Millie cast a fleeting glimpse over her shoulder to see the level was almost up to the headlights and the force of the current was starting to drag the front end.

“MILLIE! QUICKLY!” Zack yelled as he and Ethan hoisted Claire up and out then stretched their arms as far as they could while holding on to the grab rails. “QUICKLY!” he cried again, fearful for himself as much as her.

She flung the strap of the bag over her shoulder and gripped onto headrest after headrest as she battled towards the rear doors. The storm continued to rumble outside punctuated by the occasional exclamation of horror courtesy of the others.

The bus shifted again. “AAGGGHHH!” She wrapped both her arms around one of the seats as a little more of the front end disappeared.

“MILLIE!” Zack shouted, risking his own safety and reaching further.

She lunged, grabbing hold of his hand. He pulled and then Ethan’s fingers gripped her other wrist, and they all heaved, practically falling out of the back. They scrambled away, crab-crawling at first, then running, until they were off the bridge. The rain battered against them, but it didn’t matter. All they could do was look on in wonder and terror. They had come so close to catastrophe but escaped.

SCREEE! CRUNCH!

The bus and the rest of the bridge finally crumbled. The vehicle bobbed then listed in the frantic, bubbling flow before disappearing out of sight.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 2

The group remained speechless and motionless for a moment longer, just standing there in the middle of the road, in the middle of the storm, the rain and wind whipping their faces.

“Is-is everybody alright?” Claire asked, remembering herself and her duties.

Kayla began to sob and Amanda put an arm around her. None of the responses were verbal, but nods of the head told her that people were in one piece at least.

“What are we going to do?” Zack asked.

“Let’s get off the road for a minute and into the trees. We’ll be a bit more protected there while we figure this out.”

Under other circumstances, few of them would have been willing to step into the darkness of the forest, but, as Claire had suggested, it provided some small modicum of protection from the elements.

“Here,” Millie said, pushing the bag into Claire’s hands as they walked.

“Thank you. You shouldn’t have though. It was too dangerous.”

“I’d say the reward was worth the risk.”

“Thank you again.”

“You’re welcome.”

“Alright, everybody. This is far enough.” They were about fifteen metres back from the road and even though it was easy to feel, see and hear some of the effects of the storm, it was far more sheltered and the trees that towered all around them offered protection from the rain for the time being at least. “Okay. Bit of a longshot, but does anyone have a phone signal?” The torches on the phones had lit their path and she was pretty certain someone would have said if they had seen a bar, but without hope, they had little else.

“No, Miss,” the answers came back one by one.

“Right. I told you it was a long shot. Okay. Everybody stay here for a minute. Millie and I are going to figure out what we should—”

“No offence, Miss T,” Zack began, “but don’t you think we should all be in on that conversation? I mean, unless you’ve got another minibus hidden around here or you’ve got some survival skills or something that you’ve not told us about, I think we should all be in on the decision-making. We’re seventeen.”

She studied his face in the glow of the torch lights. “You’re right. I’m sorry. I’ve still got pictures of you in my head as thirteen-year-olds, but that’s just wishful thinking on my part, I suppose. So, has anyone got any thoughts?” she asked, looking around the circle. Kayla was sobbing and Amanda’s voice was shaky. In fairness, all Claire wanted to do was curl up and cry, but these kids were her life and she was determined to keep them safe regardless.

“I say we start walking back the way we came,” Javed said.

“Yeah,” Ethan agreed.

“In this?” Natalie asked. “I’m already freezing and soaked to the skin. We could get hypothermia.”

“I doubt that. Plus, if we’re moving, that’ll warm us up a bit.”

“Look,” Claire said, taking over. “I don’t fancy traipsing around in this weather either. But there’s another factor that we need to take into account. That river has already washed a bridge away. It’s not a stretch to think it might burst its banks and then we’ve got an even bigger problem on our hands.”

“Shiiit! I didn’t even think about that.”

“I’m not saying it will. I’m just saying it could.”

“Oh, God,” Amanda whimpered.

“Yeah,” Zack added. “Miss T’s right. We should get out of here asap.”

“Listen,” Millie said, joining the discussion. “We’ll stay in the trees. It’s drier and less windy here. We’ll stay close together and just use a couple of the phones at a time so we don’t have to worry about the batteries running out before we get a signal and are able to call someone.”

“That’s alright, but it was miles back that we got a signal. We could be walking for hours.”

“There’s nothing to say that another car won’t come this way. If we hear one or see some lights, we can run out to the road and flag them down. What does everybody say?”

None of them were enamoured by the idea of a long hike in wet, freezing clothes, but in the absence of any better suggestions, they agreed,

and within less than a minute, they were on the march with Millie and Javed lighting the way.

“Zack, Ethan,” Claire said. “Walk with me a minute.”

“What is it, Miss T?” Zack asked as both students fell back to walk with their teacher.

“I didn’t get the chance to thank you for what you did. It was incredibly brave of both of you.”

“Like I said, Miss. You’re like one of us.”

“I’m very grateful, but I never want either of you putting yourselves in such danger again.”

“No offence, Miss T, but screw that. Who was it who helped me with my English coursework to get my grades up? Who was it who helped my sister with her application for that job? Who was it who donated fifty quid to my Go Fund Me for our cat’s op?”

“Yeah, Miss T,” Ethan agreed. “Everyone here has stories like that. You’ve helped us all out so many times. There was no way we weren’t going to help you out of that bus.”

She reached out both her hands and squeezed their arms. “You’re both good boys. I’m proud to have known you.”

There was a pause before Ethan spoke again. “What do you mean to have known us?”

She shook her head. “I mean to know you.” She let out a short, nervous laugh. “The adrenaline’s still shooting through me, I’m not thinking straight.”

They carried on walking for a few minutes, following the dancing torch beams in front. The wind and rain continued, but the forest was a good shield. The overhanging foliage and density of the trees fended off the worst of it.

“I think we’re on a slight gradient,” Millie called back over her shoulder.

“What does that mean?” Zack asked.

“It means we’re going uphill. If the river does burst its banks, we should be safe.”

“That’s one less thing to worry about, anyway,” Claire replied.

They carried on through the forest for several more minutes. “Um, is it just me,” Zack began, “or does it sound like it’s stopped raining?”

The group had stayed as parallel as they could to the road, occasionally losing sight of it, but now they all halted.

"I think you're right," Claire replied. "And the wind seems to have died down a bit."

Javed and Millie switched direction, leading the small group back out onto the road. The rain had stopped and a full moon shone down brightly lighting the way ahead. There were many high, fast-moving clouds, but for the time being, none of them threatened to encumber the white glow.

"At least we can save our batteries a bit," Mille said, switching her torch off. "Anybody got a signal yet?"

They all looked at their phones. "Too much to ask," said Claire. "Let's just be grateful for small mercies. At least we're not walking through a pitch-black forest anymore."

"What's wrong, Miss T, scared of the dark?" Ethan asked, trying to lighten the mood.

"I'm scared of one of you tripping up and breaking your ankles."

"I'm guessing the trip's off now, isn't it?" said Zack. "Shame. It would have been good to see Jacobs in *King Lear*."

Claire let out a long sigh. "Yeah. I'm sorry. This was meant to be one last great road trip together before ... um ... before things got too crazy with your course work."

"Doesn't matter. I heard Manchester Opera House was getting a touring production of *Mamma Mia* in October. Maybe we could all go see that instead," Natalie said.

"So, what you're saying is rather than seeing Sir Iain Jacobs, one of the greatest actors of our time, playing King Lear in his final run we should go see a musical full of Abba songs? Well, it's good to see that my years of teaching you kids drama have given you a true appreciation of the theatrical arts."

They all laughed before Natalie spoke again. "I didn't mean it like that. I mean, we've been on loads of trips together, and I know this one was meant to be special, and I know going to see *Mamma Mia* in Manchester is nothing like going to see Sir Iain performing King Lear in his hometown, but—" She broke off and suddenly started crying. The whole group stopped, more than a little concerned.

"What is it, Natalie?" Millie asked, placing an arm around her.

In the few seconds they stood there, the wind seemed to die down further, making the sound of the teenager's sobs more audible. "Miss T, I know."

"You know what?" Claire asked.

"I overheard you."

"I don't understand. You overheard me saying what?"

"I know you're not going to be teaching us next term."

Consternation rippled around the small group. "Is this true, Miss?" Ethan asked.

"What's going on, Miss T?" Javed asked.

Claire looked uncomfortable, glancing towards Millie for strength before speaking. "I really didn't want this to be the way you all found out. I was going to sit you down when we got back from the trip."

"Find out what, Miss T?"

She cleared her throat. "Millie's going to be taking over as the drama teacher."

"Why? What's happened? You're not getting fired or something, are you?"

A small, sad laugh left Claire's lips. "Well, after tonight, that's a possibility, but it's not why Millie's taking over. Ugh ... I really didn't want this to be the way I told you. Um..." Millie let go of Natalie and walked over to Claire, putting her arm around her friend.

"It's alright," she said, squeezing her gently.

"Kids," Claire continued, trying her hardest not to cry. She'd barely come to terms with the truth of the situation herself and she didn't want to burden them with the knowledge. Millie knew. Mr Moggs knew. Her mum and her sister knew, but that was it. That was how she'd intended to keep it until she was ready. "Kids, I've only got a few months to live."

It seemed like the wind stopped completely as silence shrouded them. It lingered, hanging in the air like a thick fog of sadness. Finally, it broke as four of the six pupils started to cry. To everyone's surprise, Zack was one of them. Zack was tall, well-built and athletic. He played in the rugby team, and most teachers were a little wary of him, given his chequered past. But Claire knew how sensitive he really was, what he was truly like inside, and now it bubbled to the surface as streams of tears ran down his cheeks. "What is it, Miss? What's wrong with you?" he asked.

She had done so much for him and his family. She'd been a kind of surrogate mother almost. His father had died many years before and his own mother was a nurse, always working long hours to keep enough food on the table for him and his sister. Miss T had always been there though. She'd been there after school and during the holidays to provide support if ever he needed it. He was not prone to tears, but he cried them now. He cried them as he held on to her with the rest of his surrogate family sharing his sadness.

One by one, the others crowded around too, inadvertently forming a group hug, desperate to feel close to one another. Claire sniffed deeply, finally answering Zack's question. "It's called a glioblastoma. It's a brain tumour."

A shuddering breath left his mouth as he pulled back. He was a few inches taller than her, but at that moment, he looked like a frightened little boy as the moonlight got caught in his tears. "Can't they operate or something? Can't they give you radiotherapy or chemotherapy or something?"

The others let go too now, wanting to hear the words that came out of her mouth, silently praying that there was some hope at least. "It's something that's very difficult to treat at the best of times and my diagnosis was pretty late in the day. I decided I didn't want to spend my last few months as sick as a dog, pumping myself full of all kinds of poisons in the hope it might give me a tiny little bit longer. I want to spend it doing fun things with the people I care about. Bringing you all up here to see Sir Iain was something I hoped you'd all remember for the rest of your lives."

"I don't think we're going to forget it, Miss T," Javed said through his sobs.

Despite the direness of the situation, she let out a laugh. "Yeah. I suppose you're right. This just wasn't the memory I wanted to give you, that's all."

"So, how long do you have, Miss T?"

She wiped away her tears. "They gave me six months a couple of months back."

"And are you in loads of pain and stuff?"

"I get headaches. Really bad headaches."

"And can they give you something for them?"

"I'm on tablets called corticosteroids. They help a little."

“I can’t believe this. I really can’t believe this,” Natalie said, still crying.

“Look. I’m still here for the moment and we can discuss this properly when we’re somewhere safe and warm. But we need to get moving before that storm stirs up again.”

Sad looks passed between all of them before the group set off once more. They were silent, barring the odd sniff or sob, as they walked along the road. The wind reduced to a breeze and the clouds slowed too, occasionally flitting in front of the moon for a moment but not resulting in prolonged darkness.

“They should name the school theatre after you,” Zack blurted. “That’s what they should do. So nobody will ever forget you.”

“Nobody’s ever going to forget Miss T,” Kayla replied.

“I don’t mean us. I don’t mean the pupils who are there now. I mean in the future and stuff. I mean, y’know, for how much she’s done for the school and all of us.”

“Yeah. I like that idea,” Ethan said.

“Me too,” Amanda agreed. One by one, the others did as well.

“That’s very sweet of you all,” Claire said, “But—”

“But nothing. I’m going to start a Change.Org petition or something,” Zack interrupted.

“Yeah. We’ll start a petition,” Kayla said, immediately getting on board with the idea. “Moggs and the governors won’t have a choice. You built that theatre.”

“Um ... that’s a little bit of an exaggeration,” Claire said, laughing.

“Well, not physically, but you’re the one who made it a success. You’re the one who’s actually made it pay for the school.”

“You’re all very sweet.”

“Sweet nothing. It’s what’s right.”

“Yeah,” several of the others agreed in unison.

“Look. I’ve got more to say on this matter, but one of the side effects of these tablets is I need to pee more than usual and I’m afraid I’m going to have to nip to the ladies,” she said, heading swiftly towards the trees.

“Actually, I might join you,” Millie added, setting off after her.

“Okay,” Zack said. “This is officially a pee break. Everyone, find their own tree.” Muted laughter rang around the others before he, Natalie, Ethan

and Kayla walked to the opposite side of the road and disappeared into the woodland.

“Stay nearby, everyone,” Claire called over her shoulder, desperately trying to unbuckle her belt at the same time. She crouched down behind a towering oak just a few feet back from the road. “Oh, Jesus.” She let out a huge, relieved sigh as a powerful flow began. “Jesus, Millie. What’s happening to me? I’m not even in control of my own bladder anymore.”

“I’m sorry. I’m sorry you’re having to deal with this. I wish I could say something to make it better. How’s your head?”

Millie had been one of the first she’d confided in. She’d described how agonising the headaches could get and sometimes the tablets couldn’t even touch them. “Well, considering a little while ago I drove our minibus into a river, nearly killing us all, and now we’re stuck in the middle of nowhere, surprisingly good.”

Millie laughed. “Well, that’s something, anyway.”

“Yeah. Maybe they should prescribe it as a new treatment regimen.”

“At least everybody’s safe. That’s the most important thing. It could have been so much worse.”

“Well, after tonight, I’m pretty certain I’m going to have plenty of free time on my hands.”

“Don’t be stupid. This wasn’t your fault. The bridge crumbled, for God’s sake. If it’s anyone’s fault, it’s the council’s or whoever’s in charge of the roads in this area. We could sue them.”

“That’s just what I want to tie the last few months of my life up with; litigation.”

“You know what I mean. This wasn’t on you, Claire. This was an act of God.”

“Yeah. Something else I’ll have to thank him for when I see him.”

The two women finished up, rising to their feet and buckling their jeans before stepping back out onto the road to join Javed and Amanda. Seconds later, Zack, Natalie and Ethan joined them from the trees opposite.

“God, I needed that slash,” Zack said.

“Nice,” replied Claire. “Poetic almost.”

“Sorry, Miss.”

Claire shook her head. “I’ll let you off this once. Who are we still waiting for?” she asked, looking around the moonlit faces.

“Just Kayla.”

They remained there for a full minute. “Poor kid must have been more desperate than I was.”

“Oi, Kayla, are you taking a dump in there?” Zack asked, causing a couple of the others to chuckle.

“Zack!”

“Sorry, Miss.”

“Kayla! Is everything okay, sweetheart?” Claire called.

Silence.

“Kayla?” Millie shouted out this time.

Silence.

“Kayla. This isn’t the time for jokes. We need to get on our way.”

Several more seconds dragged on as the whole group stared towards the trees.

“Kayla. This isn’t funny. Come on,” Natalie, her closest friend, shouted. “My mum is going to be having kittens if I don’t message her in the next half hour.”

Silence.

Even in the moonlight, the two adults could see the concern on the others’ faces.

“Kayla!” Claire shouted with slightly more panic in her voice this time. “Kayla!” She turned to Zack and the others. “Show me exactly where she went.”

The whole group headed into the forest, with Javed and Natalie using their torches as Zack led the way. “This is where I thought she went.” He turned to Natalie. “You were with her, weren’t you?”

“We weren’t holding hands or anything. And she was more over there,” she said, pointing to a tree a little further back.

Claire turned on the torch on her own phone as she and Millie walked across to where Natalie had indicated. There was a yellow trickle on a bulging root but no sign of Kayla. Claire panned the torch around, and when she spoke, it was in a hushed tone. “There’s no way she could have lost her bearings and gone in the wrong direction, is there?”

“We’re about twenty feet away from the road. And anyway, she’d have called out. KAYLA! KAYLA!”

“KAYLA!”

They waited with bated breath, hoping to hear a reply.

“KAYLA!”

“What’s happening, Miss T?” Natalie asked. “Where is she?”

“I don’t know,” Claire replied, peering into the thick, dark forest.

“Me and Ethan’ll go look for her,” Zack said.

“You will not. We’re not splitting up.”

“Has somebody taken her, Miss T?” Amanda asked this time. The sadness from a few minutes before was not forgotten, but anxiety was fast taking over.

“KAYLA!” It was Javed yelling this time.

“KAYLA!” The others joined in in a chorus, spreading a little, turning in all directions barring that of the road, so their voices could be heard.

“KAYLA!”

“What are we going to do, Miss T?” Javed asked.

She panned her torch around, but the light soon dissipated into the seemingly eternal blackness of the forest. “This is like some kind of nightmare,” she replied more to herself than anyone else. “Um.... Well, we need to look for her.”

“Yeah, but where do we start?”

She glanced around again. “I think we need to form a line. Everybody get your phones out and switch your torches on. We’re going to form a line and stay in sight and sound of one another at all times, but—”

“Ethan? ETHAN?” Natalie’s alarmed voice stopped Claire in mid-sentence. “ETHAN?”

“What is it? What’s wrong with Ethan?”

“He was here. He was literally just here.” All the torches pointed towards Natalie then angled in the direction she was indicating.

“What the hell is happening?” Claire asked, turning to look at Millie, who mirrored her shock and fear.

“ETHAN?”

“ETHAN?”

“ETHAN?”

They all started shouting his name instead of Kayla’s but achieved exactly the same response.

“ETHAN?”



Ethan could hear the shouts ... just. It was as if his head was underwater and people were calling his name from the shore. He wanted to respond. He tried to respond. But when he opened his mouth, nothing came out. Now he thought about it, he wasn't even sure his mouth was open. He didn't really feel in charge of himself like he was asleep and stuck in a dream.

He felt the sensation of moving. His body felt cramped up, juddering occasionally as if travelling on a road full of potholes. He could feel the fresh night air on his face, though, so he knew he wasn't in a vehicle. He wasn't sure if his eyes were open or not. It was dark, very dark. The only thing he could see was blackness.

"Oh, you're going to be the best ever. Best ever." It was a whispered voice, a woman's voice, but there was something strange, something off about it. "I'll have to assist in Doctor R's procedure first, but then he'll just have to stand back and see what I can do."

"Wh-u-u-u?" Ethan tried to ask what was going on. It took everything he had for just a few barely audible, mumbled letters to dribble from his mouth. Then he felt a prick in his neck. A memory flashed back. He'd received one not a minute before; then he'd—

Blackness.

"Hush little baby. Don't say a word."

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 3

The seconds passed, then the minutes, as the diminished group continued to cry out for their lost friends.

“This is crazy,” Claire said as Millie stood with her shoulder to shoulder. “What’s going on?”

“I don’t know. But I think we need to get back to the road.”

“What do you mean? We need to find Ethan and Kayla.”

“Claire, two of our kids have just vanished. One of them while we were no more than a few feet away from him. There is nothing about this that’s good or rational. We need to get out of this forest as fast as we can, try to get a phone signal or wave down a passing car and get the police involved in this, fast.”

“The police?”

“Claire. This is already totally out of hand. Ethan and Kayla have gone missing. We can’t afford to lose any of the other—”

“OwHOOOOOO!”

“What the fuck is that?” Zack cried out as the echo of the animalistic howl continued.

“That didn’t sound far away, Miss T,” Amanda said, her voice shaking again.

Claire panned her torch around as fear seized her. “Oh, shit, oh shit, oh shit, oh shit, oh shit,” she said under her breath as she desperately wracked her brain for a solution.

“Claire,” Millie carried on. “We need to get back to the road, now.”

Claire looked at the other woman in the periphery of the phone’s torch. “Everybody stay together. We’re going back to the road.”

“What about Ethan and Kayla?” Javed asked.

“We’re going to figure that out. We’re going to figure everything out. We just need to get back to the r—”

“OwHOOOOOO!” The chilling sound erupted once more.

“Fuck, Miss. Fuck!” Zack cried, taking hold of Amanda’s arm as they ran the few metres back to the glistening tarmac reflecting the moon’s icy stare. “What is that? What the hell is that? I mean, are there wolves in Scotland? Do they have wolves up here?”

“No,” Claire replied as she and the other three joined them. “It’s probably a dog.”

“That’s some big fucking dog, Miss.” He started walking away.

“Where are you going?”

“Just here,” he replied, stooping down and picking up a fallen tree branch that looked a little like a crooked, nobbly baseball bat.

“What are you going to do with that, Zack?”

“Just in case.”

“In case what?”

“Two of us are missing and there’s something out there that’s making the Hound of the Baskervilles sound like a French poodle. I feel happier knowing I’ve got something to swing.”

“It’s probably just a sheepdog or something.”

“Miss T, I know you’re trying to make us feel better, but that ain’t no sheepdog.”

“I think he’s right, Claire,” Millie replied. “I don’t think it would be a bad idea if we all found a weapon, just in case.”

“OwHOOOOOO!”

“Oh God. It sounded closer this time,” Natalie said. “Did it sound closer to you?”

“Yeah,” Zack replied. “That was definitely closer.”

“Okay, everybody,” Claire said. “Find a branch or something.”

“Do you think that dog or whatever it is had something to do with Kayla and Ethan disappearing?” Javed asked as he picked up a small tree limb a little broader than a rolling pin but roughly the same length. He swung it from side to side a few times, getting used to the feel of it.

“I don’t know. I don’t think so. Ethan was just a few feet away from us when he vanished. If it had been an animal attack, we’d have heard something. We’d have seen some sign of a struggle, of blood.”

“Then what happened to them?”

There was an electricity in the air. Everyone was waiting for the next bad thing to happen and Claire was trying her hardest to keep it together. “I

don't know. I honestly don't. But Millie's right. I think we need to carry on until we get a signal then—"

"We can't leave them behind. We can't."

Claire reached out, grabbing Zack by the shoulders. "Listen to me. We're surrounded by forest. It could go on for miles for all we know and we don't know what direction Ethan and Kayla have been taken. The chances of us finding them are tiny, and that's to say nothing of the danger. I can't risk letting anyone else go missing. We need to alert the police and they can get a helicopter up, they can get in touch with search and rescue, they can co-ordinate an organised resp—OH FUCK!" She released her grip, immediately bringing her right hand up to her head.

"Miss T, are you okay?"

She bent over, her left hand massaging the other side of her skull. Millie unzipped the bag around her friend's shoulder, emptied two tablets from a blister pack, and handed them and a bottle of water to Claire. "Take these," she said.

Claire swallowed them and washed them down with a swig of water. She remained bent over until a familiar sound made her straighten up.

"OwHOOOOOO!"

"Are you okay?" Millie asked.

Claire's eyes remained clenched shut for a moment. Her breathing was laboured as she tried to acclimatise herself to the pain. "Yeah. I will be when the tablets kick in."

"Did I cause that? Did I cause that, Miss T?" Zack asked, almost in tears, the chilling howl forgotten for the moment as his favourite teacher suffered.

Claire straightened up and reached out, gently touching his cheek. "No, sweetheart. You didn't cause that. But we really do need to go." She looked across to the forest once more.

"Okay, Miss T. How about you put your arm through mine for a little while until those tablets kick in?"

She nodded, looping her arm through his, hoping the drilling agony in her skull wouldn't slow their progress too much.



Discomfort couldn't even begin to describe what Kayla was feeling. Her buttocks felt as if they were pressed against cold metal. She was pretty certain her jeans and knickers were at half mast, and she couldn't swear to it, but it felt like she might have peed herself too.

She blinked several times, trying hard to make out where she was or what was happening. She tried to angle her head but couldn't. It was as if she'd been drugged.

Wait. Drugged.

The memory was slow in returning, fuzzy and dark like her head, like everything that was going on around her. *I was taking a pee; then someone covered my mouth and pricked my neck. I was drugged. Oh shit! I was drugged.*

Despite the revelation, she was unable to do anything. A sudden drop made her whole body shake.

"Oops a daisy. Daisy. Hehehehehe. Daisy. I've only just got it. Oops a daisy. Hehehehehe." The voice was strange, manic, unnatural in its peaks and troughs. It was a man's voice, but the laugh sounded unnervingly like that of a child. "Oops a daisy," he said again as another drop made Kayla's bones rattle.

I'm in a wheelbarrow. I'm in a wheelbarrow. She tried to shift, tried to roll, tried to turn, but couldn't. When she screamed, the only thing that came out of her mouth was a shallow, rasping breath. But in her head, she was screaming louder than she ever had in her life, louder than anyone she'd ever heard scream. *HELP! HELP! HELLLPPP!*



They'd only been walking a few minutes, but Claire removed her arm from around Zack's. "I'm starting to feel a little better now, thank you."

"Well, if your head starts to get bad again, tell me."

"I will."

She'd dropped her makeshift weapon when the agonising attack had struck, but now she hunted the side of the road for something else to use. She found a snapped branch a little shorter than her arm and picked it up, not losing step with the others.

The occasional sob still left Amanda's mouth and, in truth, the others all felt like crying too. They had nearly died when the minibus had plunged

into the river, they had lost two of their friends, there was something that sounded menacing, if not terrifying, in the forest, and they were stuck in the middle of nowhere with no phone signal and no hope of rescue.

“I haven’t heard that thing, whatever it is, in a while. Do you think maybe it’s gone?” Millie asked quietly as the others walked a little in front, continuing their own hushed conversations.

“I don’t know,” Claire admitted.

“What do you suppose it is?”

“I don’t know.”

“It’s a werewolf is what it is,” Natalie called over her shoulder.

They hadn’t thought they were talking loud enough to be heard, but obviously they were wrong. “You’re seventeen, Natalie. That’s too old to be believing in werewolves.”

“It’s a full moon. And something big in the forest was howling a few minutes ago like nothing I’ve ever heard. Ethan and Kayla are missing. And I’ve got a weird feeling. I can’t be the only one.” She turned to the others she was walking with. “You must be feeling it too.”

“All our nerves are in tatters after what’s happened. I dare say everyone feels weird.”

“Claire’s right,” Millie replied. “And maybe we should pick up the pace a little bit. The sooner we get a signal the sooner we can get help.”

“I could run ahead,” Zack said.

“Absolutely not,” Claire replied. “We stick together—what the hell?”

They all stopped dead as a figure walked out of the forest thirty or so metres ahead. He was dressed completely in black and one of his gloved hands held something by his side. A strange looking mask covered his head and he stood in the middle of the road, feet straddling the centre.

“What the fuck?”

“OwHOOOOOO!”

“That sounded nearby,” Javed cried, his voice shaking a little.

“Miss, I’m scared,” Amanda said.

Claire walked forward putting herself between her pupils and the figure who remained statuesque ahead of them. There was nothing about him that suggested he was friendly or willing to help. The overall vibe was that he actually meant them harm. She had suspicions about what he was holding by his side and she had no intention of letting her students go any nearer.

Javed was right. That thing sounded close. “Our minibus went into the river,” she said. “We’re trying to get help.”

The figure remained unmoved.

“Oi! Are you listening?” Zack shouted, striding forward, resting his club on his shoulder.

“I’m handling this, thanks, Zack. Go stand with the others.”

“Miss T, I don’t think this guy’s going to budge from the road.”

“Please. I’ll handle it.” *Handle it? What the fuck am I going to do? This might be the psycho who had something to do with Ethan’s and Kayla’s disappearance.* “Look,” she called to the figure once more. “We’re having a really, really bad night. Two of my pupils have gone missing and we need to call the police.”

“OwHOOOOOO!”

“What the fuck is that?” Zack asked, turning to the forest now as the sound seemed to come from a place that was almost in touching distance.

“I saw something. I saw something move in there,” Natalie said, the fear evident in her shaking voice.

Millie placed a hand around her arm. “It’s okay. If we all stick together and keep our heads, we’ll be okay.”

“I can’t promise that last thing. My head is well and truly fucked up right this minute.”

“Natal—”

“And don’t try to tell me off for swearing, Miss T, because if ever there was a time to fucking swear, it’s now.”

“I wasn’t going to. I was just going to ask what you think you saw.” Despite talking to Natalie, Claire’s eyes were still staring dead ahead at the figure blocking the road.

“I didn’t think I saw something. I saw something.”

“What exactly?”

“I ... I’m not sure. But whatever it was made those bushes move.” She pointed to a close cropping of shrubs a little back from the road, but still Claire did not break her gaze from the figure ahead.

“Shit!” Zack cried. “She’s right, Miss. There’s something behind those bushes.”

Claire broke her vigil of the man on the road just as a tall silhouette rose up from behind the shrubbery her two students were talking about.

“What the hell is that?” Millie asked in a whisper as they all stared at it now.

“It must be like seven feet tall or something.”

“Ye-ah,” Amanda said. “*It* being the operative word. Wh-what the hell is it?”

It suddenly leapfrogged the cropping of shrubs but still remained in the dark shadows of the forest.

“I told you,” Natalie replied, barely believing her own eyes as her mind processed the shape of the thing. “It’s a fucking werewolf. It’s a fucking werewolf.”

“There’s....” Claire struggled to finish what she was saying; then she took a deep breath and continued. “There’s no such thing as werewolves.” Even though the words came out of her mouth; even though that was what she’d believed all her life and was still desperate to believe, the outline of the shape she was staring at looked terrifyingly like a thing from myths and legends.

The creature’s head angled up and another marrow-chilling howl ripped through the night air.

“Oh ... my ... God,” Millie said, her voice quaking.

Fear froze them all in position. Claire finally remembered the threatening man who had stepped into the road moments before and turned to look only to see he was no longer there.

“Shiiit!” she hissed.

“What? What is it?”

“The guy’s gone.”

Millie dragged her eyes away from the mesmerising creature to survey the road. “Oh craaap!” She and Claire were adults. They were the people who the students would be looking to for answers, but they had none. The fear was like a living thing pulsing around them, real enough to reach out and touch.

Finally, inevitability came knocking. The creature took a long stride towards them and fell into the periphery of the phone torches pointing towards it.

It was Javed who was the first to break the spell. “RUUUN!”

CHAPTER 4

Kayla's senses were slow in coming back to her. She still couldn't move, but she could see a lot clearer. *Am I in a hospital?* The white walls, lighting panels and smell all suggested it was some kind of medical facility. A rhythmical squeak from a wheel accompanied her thoughts as she was transported, but then another sound began to bleed through the foggyiness.

Music? Is that music?

It gradually got louder until the barrow or whatever Kayla was being transported in burst through a pair of double doors and into what seemed to be an operating room. The music was much louder in here.

"Teddy Bears' Picnic." Is that "Teddy Bears' Picnic"?

She suddenly felt herself being hoisted onto a gurney or table of some kind. She briefly caught sight of a man. It was hard to tell how old he was. He had a young-looking face, but his hair was white and wild. His eyes were bright blue, staring holes through her as an unhinged smile painted his face.

"Just relax," he said before starting to hum along to the music. He grabbed a pair of scissors and cut the remainder of her clothes off then secured her wrists and ankles.

If the drugs hadn't temporarily paralysed Kayla, the fear would have done. Tears welled in her eyes as she tried her hardest to scream but to no avail.

"Ahh, Doctor Razzle Dazzle. You're back." The voice was that of a well-spoken older man.

"You've returned to us, good doctor," a woman's voice added.

Finally, Kayla regained some small amount of control over her body as the drug's effect slowly dissipated. She turned her head to see a figure on the table next to her. It was covered in a green sheet. She angled her eyes towards the door and could now see the older man and woman who had

entered a few seconds before. They were in light blue scrubs and the man who had fastened her to the table walked up to them.

“Yes. Yes. A most successful expedition,” her abductor, the one whom the older man had called Dr Razzle Dazzle, replied. His voice continued to sound strange, peaking and troughing unnaturally.

“Excellent. Excellent,” the woman said, glancing across at Kayla. She possessed the same wild blue eyes and white hair. There was a crazed smile on her face too. “It’s always so exciting to see you at work.”

“Why, thank you,” he replied.

The double doors suddenly burst open and Kayla’s tear-filled eyes were immediately drawn to the body heaped in the wheelbarrow. It’s Ethan.

“Ah, Nurse Mitzy. Delighted you could join us,” the older man said.

She let go of the handles of the barrow and the curved, tubular legs clattered on the hard floor. “That’s not fair,” she cried. “You always call him by his full name. Always. Why do you think less of me? Why do you treat me this way?”

“I apologise. I’m sorry,” the older man said, putting his hands up placatingly. “I meant it as a term of endearment, I wished you no offence.”

“It’s not fair, I tell you, and it’s something I’m going to be raising at the next multidisciplinary team meeting. I deserve exactly the same amount of respect.”

“You’re right. I’m sorry. I’m sorry.”

Tears were streaming down the woman’s face. She had the same blue eyes, heavily underscored by liner, and lashes overly accentuated by mascara, which was now running down her cheeks. “It’s not good enough. It’s not good enough. I’ve told you,” she said, pulling a small handkerchief out of her shirt sleeve. “When we’re in this facility, we should be professional. The house is the house, but this is something else.”

The man reached out grasping his daughter’s hand. “Please accept my apology. Please.”

She pulled her hand away and dabbed her eyes. “Okay,” she said as a shuddering breath left her lips.

“I think I’ve got a way to make it up to you.”

“How?” she asked, pouting a little.

“Your mother, sorry, Doctor Lavender and I have been talking. Considering it’s so rare for us to have two patients at the same time, we thought we could have a contest.”

“A contest?”

“A contest?” Dr Razzle Dazzle echoed, clearly a little irked.

“Yes,” Doctor Lavender replied, taking over. “It’s only fair. Nurse Mitzy Glitzy has assisted you with every procedure you’ve carried out and the only surgical practice she ever gets by herself is with what’s left, which sometimes isn’t much at all. What Doctor Rupert and I propose is that we have a contest. I will assist you. Doctor Rupert will assist Nurse Mitzy Glitzy and Kevin will decide the winner.”

“Kevin? What does he know about surgery?”

“Kevin observes all things. That’s what he does. He observes and processes. Would you have known there were potential patients out there this evening if it wasn’t for Kevin?”

Doctor Razzle Dazzle’s head drooped. “No,” he admitted, begrudgingly.

“And how did you find out?”

“Because Kevin observes all things.”

“That’s right.”

She looked up towards a small camera above the door. “Are you game, Kevin?” The camera moved up and down as if nodding.

“Hahahaha. I love it when he does that,” Nurse Mitzy Glitzy said, clapping her hands like an excited schoolgirl, the upset from before now forgotten.

“There,” Dr Rupert said. “It’s settled. Am I forgiven now?”

“Oh, Daddy. Thank you,” the nurse replied, throwing her arms around him and giving him a big hug.

“It’s alright. I’m sorry I upset you. Now, chop, chop. Get your patient onto the table and get scrubbed up. We’ve got a long night ahead.”

The older man and woman disappeared back out of the doors with the seemingly peeved younger man following. The nurse seized the handles of the barrow and wheeled it across to the other table, her head nodding merrily to the music, which continued to play in a loop.

“Well, this is no good. We’re going to have to get you moved, aren’t we?” She peeled back the green sheet, revealing the corpse of a young woman. It was only now that Kayla understood the cause of the sickly vileness she had been breathing in. Her mouth dropped open in horror as she stared at the mutilated body.

The head was angled towards Kayla, and it was clear the woman was young and had once probably been beautiful, but now she was a thing of pure horror. Fingers extended from her eye sockets, stitched in place, giving the impression they had burst through her skull. Her nose had been transplanted to her forehead, leaving a gaping bloody hole in the gap it had once covered.

Her mouth was open wide to the extent that the only way it was possible was for her jaw to be broken. Erupting from the gaping chasm was what Kayla guessed was the young woman's heart. What looked like patchwork daisies had been sewn to her cheeks and, as Kayla's eyes travelled down the body, it was as if her torso had been scooped out, leaving a gory hollow cavity behind.

The nurse suddenly noticed Kayla looking. "Beautiful, isn't she?"

Kayla tried to scream. She tried with everything she had, but all that came out was a quiet, unintelligible. "Euueee."

The nurse continued, unfastening the straps holding the wrists and ankles in place. She walked up to the head and pointed to the daisies sewn to the cheeks. "Do you like these? I did these," she said proudly.

Finally, from somewhere within, Kayla found enough power to control her voice. At first, it was muted, building slowly from her depths. Then it achieved its full force. "AAARRRGGGHHH!" It was a scream that went on and on and on, drowning out the music, drowning out everything.

The nurse walked up to Kayla, looking down at her with a gleeful expression lighting her face. "Yes. Yes. Yes," she said, clapping her hands. "You get it. AAARRRGGGHHH!" she joined in. "AAARRRGGGHHH!"

Suddenly, more screams echoed from behind the one-way mirror and they carried on, even when Kayla's had ended. The nurse continued clapping, continued screaming, all with the same excited expression on her face.

They're all mad. They're totally insane. Her eyes drifted towards the mangled body of the woman on the other table and she started to cry what would probably be some of her last tears.



There were no good options, but running into a thick forest at night was a pretty lousy idea. In fairness, staying on a road with something that bore a

terrifying similarity to a lycanthrope was a pretty lousy idea, too, so Claire couldn't help but forgive Javed's impulsiveness.

She had screamed "NO" immediately after he had yelled run. But it was already too late. The others, including Millie, tore into the trees on the opposite side of the road. The other man who'd disappeared had not been forgotten but was clearly human and, at that moment, less mind-bendingly terrifying.



Millie and Javed lit the path as the others followed, one by one switching on their phone torches too. It was the lesser of two evils. Without light, they would not be able to see where they were going. With it, they were clear moving targets for whatever that thing was and whoever that threatening figure was who had first halted their progress.

"This way," Millie called out, veering down a hill on what almost looked like a trail.

Javed saw it, too, running side by side with her. She could see dancing lights from behind as the rest of the group cottoned on. She threw a glance over her shoulder.

One, two, three, four, and Javed makes five. That's good. That's good. We're all still together. That's good. She repeated the words over and over in her head, hoping that if she said it enough times, it would come true, but good was a small beacon light years away from where they were now.



"You alright, Miss?" Zack asked. He still held on to his makeshift weapon. He was pretty sure most of the others had dropped theirs as they had fled, preferring unencumbered pace to attempting to fight, but Zack's childhood was very different to the rest of the group and he preferred the idea of having something he could use to bludgeon when the final standoff arrived.

"I'm okay," Claire replied through laboured breaths as she cast a glance back. Like Millie, she didn't like the idea of lighting up their paths for all to see, but one trip, one slip, could be the difference between life and death. Is

that really what this is, life and death? Yes. That's exactly what this is. "I don't see anything."

Zack threw a look over his shoulder as well. "Yeah, well, I'm not going to stop running."

"That other man. The one who was blocking the road. Did you see where he went, Zack?" She turned her head in the other direction, searching out the darkness, looking for any shapes that did not belong.

"I'm pretty certain that thing he was holding was a machete. A fucking big machete too."

It had been held so closely that it was impossible to tell with any certainty, but Claire was of the same mind. "Yeah."

"I can handle some prick with a machete. It's whatever the hell that other thing is that worries me."



Natalie and Amanda were the piggies in the middle, allowing Javed and Millie to lead the way while their teacher and Zack brought up the rear. Despite these layers of protection, the fear they were both feeling was unparalleled by anything they'd experienced before.

Another whimper in a long line of whimpers left Amanda's mouth. "It really was what it looked like."

Part of Natalie wanted to argue, but she couldn't. "Let's just keep going. Hopefully, we won't have to find out."

"OwHOOO!"

It was obviously in pursuit, but the howl sounded a little further back in the trees. For the time being, at least, they were managing to keep some distance between themselves and the impending threat.

"And what about that other guy? The one who was standing in the road?" Amanda asked, seeing Millie leap over an exposed tree root before doing the same.

"I don't know. But it seems like a night where anything could happen."

"Yeah," Amanda replied as another shivering breath left her lips. "That's what scares me."

CHAPTER 5

Kayla had been able to do nothing but watch, cry and scream as the body of the mutilated woman was replaced with the semi-conscious one of her classmate. Whatever drug had been administered to her, it was obvious the same thing had been given to him as well.

Nurse Crazy, or whatever her name was, had moved the bodies with what seemed to be unnatural ease, suggesting a level of strength completely disproportionate to her slight frame. While working, she had occasionally laughed and spoken to herself, all the time bobbing her head to the beat of “Teddy Bears’ Picnic”, which was still playing through the speakers.

When she had finished, she’d disappeared through the double doors, leaving the two students on the operating tables that would undoubtedly become the surfaces that carried them into the most gruesome, horrific deaths imaginable.

Even though she had remained groggy, more feeling, more control, and more fear had returned to Kayla with each passing moment. Her earlier screams had kickstarted the adrenaline in her system, helping it clear some of the soporific effects of the drug.

“Ethan.” As she spoke, her voice grated a little. Her screams had been so loud, so powerful that she had rendered herself hoarse. “Ethan,” she said again, and this time, her companion’s eyes opened a little more fully, focusing on her properly for the first time.

It was a greater effort for him to speak and he tried a few times before a whispered, “Kayla,” left his lips.

“We’re in a lot of trouble, Ethan,” she managed to say before starting to cry again. *I can’t believe any of this is happening. I just can’t believe it.*

Ethan breathed in deeply, then again, desperately trying to regain control of his faculties. He’d been given a second dose of whatever it was they’d injected, but he was quite big for his age. He loved football, occasionally did weights. He was strong, fit and healthy, and he now marshalled these attributes. “The others?” he finally managed to say.

"I've ... I've not seen them. Only the psychos who are here."

"Psychos?"

"They're mad ... they're totally, totally mad."

"What do you mean?"

"I can't say it any clearer. I mean, this fucking music has been playing non-stop since I woke up. Over and over."

Ethan clenched his eyes shut tight and opened them again. "It was only now that his friend had mentioned it that he noticed the music. "Teddy Bears' Picnic?" he asked, more than a little confused.

"Yeah. These people. They're off the charts crazy, Ethan. They're going to kill us."

It was these words that acted as the fire he needed to actually try to move. He forced his head up, taking in the room for the first time. It was only then that he realised he'd been stripped naked. His eyes slowly took everything in. He'd broken his arm a few years back and so the inside of this room looked familiar. "An operating theatre?"

"Yeah."

He angled his head towards the long one-way mirror on the wall. "I don't understand."

"There was someone on that table before she put you on there."

"Who?"

"A girl. Well ... a woman. It was hard to tell. They'd-they'd—" She started crying again.

"They'd what, Kayla?"

"I ... can't. It's too horrible."

"They'd killed her?"

"They'd done more than that. They'd mutilated her. They'd sewn fingers into her eye sockets. They'd cut off her nose and attached it to her forehead. Th-They'd—" She broke down crying once more.

"Okay. Okay. I get the picture," he replied, his eyes widening as fear pulsed through him. "We've got to try to get out of here."

"Get out? How the hell do you expect us to get out? We're buckled to these tables. There's a huge one-way mirror on the wall, and even if we got out of this room, we've got no idea where we are. I mean ... I think I saw a house, a really, really big house, but I can't be sure. And I was half-unconscious when I was brought here. I don't know which direction we were heading or anything."

Ethan looked around the room again, finally resting his head back on the table. *She's right. This is it. This is the end.*



Millie and Javed skidded to a stop, fallen leaves flying up around their feet as they did. They'd heard something up ahead and were aiming their phone torches in the direction of the noise, trying their hardest to identify it before leading themselves and the others into more danger. Two by two, their companions came to a halt as well.

"What is it?" Claire asked, out of breath.

"I heard something," Javed responded.

"Like what?"

"Like—"

Clack! Clack! Clack!

"Shit!" They all stared dead ahead. Whoever had made the sound wasn't visible for the moment; in fact, they didn't sound that close, but it was obvious the noise was being made to scare them.

"What do we do?" Millie asked.

"OwHOOO!"

All six of them spun around. The howl sounded closer than at any time since they had been on the road.

"Come on," Zack said, grabbing Claire's arm and setting off at a sprint in another direction. The others quickly followed, but they knew they were doing exactly what their pursuers wanted them to do, getting more and more lost in the forest.

They were running for less than thirty seconds before they all came to a stop again. It wasn't a noise this time. They all pointed their torches in the direction of the tall figure who had blocked their way on the road. For the moment, he was too far away to illuminate properly, but it was clearly his silhouette.

"How did he get in front of us?" Zack asked. "We changed direction."

"You're assuming it was him who made that sound," Javed replied.

"What do you mean?"

"I mean, for all we know, there could be an army in this forest, stalking us."

“That talk isn’t going to help anyone, Javed,” Claire said, her eyes remaining fixed on the figure as they had been when she was on the road.

“That other thing that’s hunting us. The last time it howled it was much closer. We need to—”

“Where the hell’s Amanda?” Millie demanded.

“She was right here,” replied Natalie. “She was with me.”

“Oh, shit!” Claire hissed, taking her eyes off the threatening figure ahead for a moment. “Oh shit, oh shit, oh shit.”

“How can they have taken her without us hearing or seeing anything?” Natalie asked, on the verge of tears once again.

“Move your torches around. She’s got to be around here somewhere. She can’t have just vanished into thin air.” Claire waved her beam from side to side. Despite saying it, thin air seemed to be exactly where Amanda had vanished to. She threw a look back over to the man in black who remained still, like a marble sculpture of malevolence. He hadn’t said anything, he hadn’t done anything other than stand, but it was clear to anyone that he possessed ill intent.

“She’s not here, Miss,” Zack said, wandering away from the others a little, retracing their steps, beating the nearest bushes with his makeshift weapon.

“Stay close, Zack!”

“OwHOOO!”

“Fuck, Miss, it’s almost on us. We’ve got to get out of here.” Claire looked towards the man again to see nothing but an empty space. She moved the light on her phone around, searching for some sign, for movement, for anything that would give her a clue as to where he’d gone, but there were none. She flinched as she felt a hand on her arm and turned to see Millie standing next to her, wide eyed, on the verge of tears herself.

“I don’t know what’s happening. None of this makes sense, but we need to keep moving.”

“She was with us. She was right here.”

“I know. But she’s not now and we’ve got the other three to think about. We’ve got to get a signal or get help or—”

“OwHOOO!”

“Fuck! Zack’s right. It sounds like that thing’s almost on us.”

Claire raised her hand to her head, massaging her temple. “W-We can’t just carry on running. We’re already lost.”

“Better to be lost than dead.”

“Come on, Miss,” Natalie said. “We need to get out of here. I’m scared.”

Claire’s head dropped. They were meant to be having a nice time. This was meant to be a lovely memory she could take with her into her last months. Instead, it had descended into some kind of hell. She had no idea if Ethan, Kayla, and now Amanda were alive or dead, but she knew the others were right. If they didn’t start moving again, they’d probably all find out the hard way.



Amanda’s breath shook in her throat as she carried along on all fours. She wasn’t proud of what she’d done. She’d always been a scaredy cat. Fear seemed to live alongside her like a twin, and tonight, she was more afraid than she had ever been in her life.

When the others were looking towards the road man, she had flicked off her torch and ducked behind some bushes then started crawling. She was already several metres away by the time she heard Millie ask where she was. Then, by the time they started searching, she was almost out of earshot.

They’ll be okay. They’ll be okay if they all stick together.

If she really believed that, she’d have stayed with them.

I’ll get a signal. I’ll get help. And the police will light up the whole forest. They’ll get helicopters, drones, the lot. That’s the only thing that’s going to help.

She finally climbed to her feet, ducking behind a tree. When the wolf thing had howled, it had been to her right, and she looked in that direction now. She could barely see anything in the shadowy forest. For the moment, she didn’t want to turn her torch on. She knew she’d probably have to at some stage, but the longer she could go without attracting attention to herself the better were her chances of making it back to the road, of survival, of raising the alarm to help the others. Yes, the others. *I’m doing this for the others.*

A blanket of shame and guilt wrapped around her, clutching her tightly, making it impossible to move. She was doing this for herself. She was doing this because she was scared and whatever that creature was, whoever

that man was, they would keep following the five dancing torch beams. *Wouldn't they?*

She pressed her back firmly against the tree as her friends began to run once more. The pounding feet and snapping twigs quickly faded to nothing, leaving her alone.

Alone.

This is what I wanted. I wanted to be alone so I stood a better chance of making it back to the road, of getting a signal, of getting help.

Alone.

The consequences of her actions raced towards her like a juggernaut.

Alone.

I need to get moving. I need to head back to the road.

She tried. She tried to put one foot in front of the other, but they seemed glued to the spot. She was scared before with the others, but now she was absolutely terrified. She couldn't see her hand in front of her face, but she could feel it shaking. A thin sheen of terror sweat coated her entire body as her golf ball eyes swept the surrounding treescape.

She took a breath, then another and another, trying her hardest not to hyperventilate. That happened sometimes. It wouldn't be good now. Loud, squeaking, rasping breaths would not be good when she was trying her hardest to avoid detection.

You can do this. You can do this.

"OwHOOO!"

The smile only flashed on her face, immediately wiped away by shame once more. The howl was further away. It was in the direction her friends had gone.

Please let that man have followed them too. Please.

God, Amanda. You're horrible. They're your friends. How can you want such a thing?

It was horrible, but it was also true. She wanted them to be the decoys for her. With the prospect of the danger moving away, a few more of her senses returned. She crouched down, feeling around on the wet ground. She'd almost forgotten the storm, but the wet earth was a reminder.

There. That's something.

She found a long, thin branch. She followed it with her hand and then stood, holding it next to her. It came up to just over her waist.

Perfect.

She didn't want this as a weapon. No. She was going to use it in the way the visually impaired used a white stick, for a little while at least. She would feel out her path, carefully, quietly, until she thought she was far enough away from danger to use her torch.

She looked over her shoulder in the direction her friends had gone. All she saw was darkness and it was that darkness that lit a small fire of hope inside her as she started her journey back to the road.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 6

The double doors opened and both captives looked towards them. The older man, Doctor Rupert, entered. There was a smile on his face and his head bobbed a little to the music, just as his daughter's had.

"Ah! You're both awake. Excellent."

"Please let us go," Kayla begged. "We won't tell anyone. Please."

"Yeah," Ethan replied. "We won't say a word if you let us out of here. It will be like it never happened."

The doctor came to a halt between the two tables. "Really? In truth, I wasn't a hundred percent on board with this idea."

"Yes. Really," Kayla said, shuffling a little beneath the restraints and angling around towards him. "Not a word. We just want to get out of here. Please."

"So, you're saying if I let you go, you won't go to the authorities and we'll all just put this whole night behind us?"

"Yeah. All we want is out of here. Please."

"Hmm." He moved his thumb and fingers up to his chin and gently massaged it. He looked back to the door then turned, stooping and talking in more of a whisper. "It's my wife who's the instigator. She says we have to be supportive, nurturing, but, frankly, the whole situation has seemed off to me for quite some time."

"Well, w-we won't say anything. We won't say anything about your wife, about this place, about the drugs or anything." Fresh tears started streaming from Kayla's eyes. "I promise."

He turned to Ethan. "And do you promise?"

"Y-yes. Yes, I swear. I swear. We just want to get out of here, please."

"Hmm. Well, now you've given me something to think about."

At that moment, neither of the prisoners could tell if the doctor was playing a cruel game or if they'd managed to tap into some thin vein of humanity beneath the clear and utter craziness.

“Please. Your wife wouldn’t even need to know. Just undo my wrists and I could free us both and get out of here and you could just say we’d escaped.”

The older man folded his arms and thought for a moment. “Yes. Yes, that could work. They’re all in the back, scrubbing up, at the moment. You’d have a few minutes to get out of the house and into the forest.” He stepped back, turning his head to each of them in turn.

“We’re actually very close to the main road,” he said, pointing. “It’s to the east of us, but it’s impossible to see this place from it. If you don’t know where the track is that leads up here, that’s easy to miss too, but that’s not important. If you head out of the front door, turn right, cross the lawn and just keep going. Keep going, keep going, keep going and you’ll hit the main road and then just run. Run, run, and run. They’ll tear this place apart looking for you, but if you do as I say, you’ll be fine.”

“So you’ll free us?” Kayla asked, the excitement building in her voice.

The doctor looked at her and then towards Ethan. He reached out, placing his fingers on the young man’s wrist strap while “Teddy Bears’ Picnic” continued to play through the speakers. “Yes. Yes, I think I will.”

“Thank you.” An expression combining disbelief and excitement swept over Ethan’s face as the older man took hold of the strap. His hand recoiled just as quickly and the doctor started to laugh, clapping and looking towards the one-way mirror.

Howls of laughter suddenly erupted from behind it as well as applause for a part well played. Dr Rupert took a bow. “Thank you. I thank you,” he said. “I’m appearing here all week. Don’t forget to book your tickets for the matinee performance tomorrow.” Another wave of laughter and frantic clapping erupted from behind the mirror.

“Bravo. BRAVO!” came a shout.

Kayla started to cry again. “Why? Why are you doing this?” she asked between frantic sobs. “Why are you doing this to us?”

“Oh, my dear,” the older man said when he finally finished laughing. He walked up to her and gently touched her cheek. She flinched away and then he ran his hand down the top half of her body, letting it rest on her stomach as she tried to writhe. “I’m not going to do anything to you. It’s Dr Razzle Dazzle and Nurse Mitzy Glitzy who’ll be carrying out the procedures. I’ll just be assisting. But don’t worry; you couldn’t be in better hands.” He patted her twice on the belly before starting to walk away.

“Please. Please!” Ethan cried out, this time as the opening bars of “Teddy Bears’ Picnic” started again.

The doctor stopped and bowed his head then turned and walked back. He stood equidistant between the two tables and there seemed to be a look of genuine regret on his face. “I’m afraid I have a confession to make.” He let out a long sigh. “Dr Razzle Dazzle,” he began, shaking his head sadly. “He’s not a real doctor. And Mitzy Glitzy hasn’t spent a day at nursing college in her life. And when I said you couldn’t be in better hands, that isn’t true either. If I’m being honest, their work is quite shoddy. The stitching is always uneven. They have a tendency to make their patients bleed excessively due to rushing and a general lack of care.” He shook his head again. “But they have shown some signs of improvement over the last few months and it’s true what they say. Practice makes perfect.”

“You’re insane,” Kayla blurted through her tears. “You’re totally fucking insane.”

“I realise you’re upset, but that’s not a very nice thing to say, now, is it?”

“FUCK YOU! FUCK YOU, YOU FUCKING PRICK!” Ethan yelled. “FUCK YOU AND YOUR ENTIRE FUCKED-UP FAMILY!”

The doctor looked down towards Ethan’s groin. “You won’t be doing any of that after tonight, I’m afraid. It’s a while since we’ve had a male patient here and Dr Razzle Dazzle has a penchant for John Thomas transplants. Indeed, I’m afraid your chopper might very well be the first thing to get chopped.”

“Fuck you,” Ethan said in a more pitiful tone this time as fear and resignation replaced the anger.

“Well, I’d better go scrub up. Toodle pip.” He turned and walked away, disappearing through the double swing doors.

“Oh, God, Ethan. Oh, God,” Kayla wept as she looked across at him.

He was crying, too, while fighting against the restraints, flexing his arm and leg muscles as hard as he could, trying to find a weakness, but to no avail.



“I need to stop. I need to stop,” Claire said, bending over and clutching her head. The pain had faded a little, only for it to come back with a

vengeance now. This happened sometimes. The best thing for it until the meds kicked in properly was to lie down in a dark room. That wasn't possible at this moment in time, but she couldn't continue. "You need to go on without me. You need to try to get out of here and get help."

"Screw that, Miss T," Zack immediately fired back. "No way we're going anywhere without you."

"Yeah," Millie added. "You can get that thought out of your head right now."

"I can't go on. I just can't go on." Claire held her head even tighter, crouching down against a tree for support.

"Are you allowed to take another pill?"

"No. You can only take two every four hours. Look, you really need to go. I mean, Jesus, it's not like I've got long left anyway. You need to get these kids out of here and raise the alarm."

"No, Miss," Natalie said, joining in the conversation. "Millie and Zack are right. We all stick together."

"Oh, crap!" Javed cried. "He's back."

They all looked up to see the man from the road. The object he was carrying now glinted proudly in the torchlight. As Claire and Zack had surmised, it was indeed a machete. A big one.

The man was tall and wide, an imposing figure, and for the first time, they could see the mask he wore in more detail. It was made from a real face, or real faces, sewn together and painted ghostly white.

"Th-that's got to be from a costume shop or something, right?" Natalie asked. "I mean, i-it's just a mask, right? Plastic or something. It can't be real."

The figure stared back at them, piercing blue marbles occasionally catching the light behind the hollow black holes where the original owner's eyes would have resided. Nobody answered Natalie as they continued to stare in horror, trying their hardest to make sense of what they were seeing, hoping that the image was not as macabre as it really appeared.

The figure's wild dark brown tufty hair suggested it was exactly what it seemed as his own white, shoulder-length locks splayed out beneath it.

"He's like something from a horror movie," Millie said to no one in particular as they all just stared on in open-mouthed terror.



Amanda continued to feel out her way, carefully sweeping the stick from side to side, reaching out with one of her hands at the same time, negotiating low-hanging branches or any other obstacles. She reached a clearing and allowed herself to bathe in the cold blue light of the moon for a moment. She had always possessed a decent sense of direction and she was pretty certain that she was heading towards the road.

Her heart was still racing, but the more distance she put between herself and her fleeing friends the more optimistic she felt about her chances. She was still struggling a little with the guilt of what she'd done, running out on them like that, but she was making progress. She would get to the road and then either get a signal or flag down a passing motorist or something, and that was the best chance she could give any of her friends.

She carried on, heading back into the darkness of the thick forest, but a sound made her stop dead once more.

"What the fuck was that?" She whispered the words. Her skin bristled with goose pimples. Amanda feared many things. To her, threats lay everywhere, but there were some fears worse than others.

Eeeeeee!

Eeeeeee!

Eeeeeee!

God no. God no, no, no.

She reached for her phone. She believed she was far enough away from the others not to be spotted by their pursuers, and if this was what she thought it was then she would need to run. She would need to run as fast as she had ever run.

Eeeeeee!

She flicked on the torch, immediately scouring the forest floor, looking for the source of the sound, expecting to see rats staring back at her. She was terrified of rats. Terrified. She was terrified of lots of things, but rats in particular.

I'm going to wake up in a minute and all of this will have been a really, really bad nightmare.

Eeeeeee!

That was in the trees. They're in the fucking trees. The horror ratcheted up another notch as she started pointing her torch towards the branches above, mentally visualising a row of rats staring down at her, waiting to pounce.

She moved the beam around. One tree, then the next, and the next, but she saw nothing.

Eeeeeee!

Suddenly, the source of the noise swooped down in front of her, letting out another loud Eeeeeee!

“NAAARRRRGGGHHH!” Amanda started running as fast as she could, wetting herself at the same time as the bat, another of her big fears, branded a fresh image of terror in her head.

There’s never just one. There’s never just one.

She sprinted and sobbed at the same time. The beam of her torch continued to dance as she used her arms to pump, to help her move faster. The bat circled with terrifying speed and agility and she let out a second scream, more muffled this time, but a scream nonetheless.

It was getting harder to breathe as she sucked in one frightened breath after another and then she stopped as suddenly as she had begun. She was back out on the road, and the Eeeeeee! that came next was shallower, quieter, as if she’d left it behind. The fear pulsing through her was alleviated in an instant as the moon shone down on the tarmac.

She let out a long, relieved breath and looked both ways, up and down the carriageway.

The seconds dragged on. She wanted to bathe in this feeling for just a moment. It was the first time anything had gone right since the minibus disappeared into the river.

“Okay. Okay, okay, okay. Don’t fuck this up. People are counting on you.” She put her phone back in her pocket, cast one last look into the forest, and then started running. *I’ll get help. I promise. I’ll get help.*

CHAPTER 7

Kayla looked across to Ethan. He had been silent for the last couple of minutes, the sound of his sobs finally fading away to nothing. His teary eyes were staring up at the ceiling. She liked Ethan a lot. He was compassionate, sweet, an all-round nice guy. He was a great actor, too, but this wasn't acting. Those were real tears. That was real fear and real resignation in his eyes. The doctor's threat had grasped on to the last shred of hope he'd had and thrown it into an industrial mincer.

"Ethan," she said quietly. "Ethan."

He sniffed and turned towards her. "Yeah."

"Do you think there's anything after this?" Her voice trembled more than ever as she spoke.

"I'd like to think so." He was fighting hard to make sure he didn't break, but it was tough considering what was ahead for them. "I'd like to think that we get reunited with all the people we've lost. Only, they're not how they were when we last saw them. They're not old and decrepit and fighting for every breath. They're how they were in their prime. Their best selves. They've lived the full lives that they have, but they're reborn as how they remembered themselves."

"That's nice," she said, letting out another sob. "That's beautiful. I hope you're right. I'd give anything to see...." She started crying and couldn't stop for a moment.

"It's alright, Kayla. It's alright. I'm here with you. I'm not going anywhere. Whatever happens, we're going to face it together."

"Sorry. I ... I was just thinking about my mum. I really hope you're right about seeing people again, 'cause I'd give anything to see her again. Even if it's just for a few minutes to tell her how much I love her." Kayla's mother had died in a car accident three years before.

"I'm pretty certain she already knew. But I bet you'll see her again. I bet you anything." He started crying again too.

But their shared sadness was quickly replaced by a fresh injection of fear as the doors burst open once more. Then, like something straight out of a bizarre childhood daydream, four figures dressed in comical bear outfits tiptoed in one by one. They lined up at the foot of the two operating tables and just stood there, staring at their captives through the eyeholes disguised at the back of their open laughing mouths.

“What’s wrong with you people?” Ethan cried.

The four bears continued watching and then their heads began to move to the rhythm of the music, which was still being piped through the speakers.

Ethan and Kayla watched through blurry eyes as the bears sidestepped, separating into pairs that turned to face each other. The one to the right of each pair bowed down low and raised a hand, which the other bear took. Each pair then moved towards each other, linking arms and starting to dance in circles to the rhythm of the tune.

It was bizarre, and crazy, and terrifying all at the same time.

“Ethan, what’s happening? What is this?” Kayla sobbed, more confused than ever by the display of abject lunacy.

“Well, they’re mad, aren’t they? All of them. They’re totally out of their fucking heads.”

The bears continued dancing, gradually moving closer and closer to the door. The music faded as it had done countless times since Kayla and Ethan had become conscious of it and the four bears disappeared out of the room before the song started up again.

“Are they trying to send us mad too? Is that what they’re trying to do?”

Ethan looked across at his friend. Tears continued to blur both their eyes, but just seeing the other one gave them some small modicum of comfort. “They’re not going to manage that,” he replied. “And remember what I said. We’re here together. Whatever happens, we’re not going to have to face it alone.”



“Miss T. We need to move. We need to move now,” Zack said as the wolf creature emerged from between two trees. Its tall and threatening figure stood there like the man on the opposite side of the small clearing,

long arms seemingly just hanging by its side, elongated digits curling into razor-sharp claws.

“I can’t,” Claire whispered. “But you need to go. Maybe if I stay and you go, I’ll be their main focus for a while. It might give you the chance to get away.”

“Nah, fuck that, Miss.” As had happened so many times in his life, Zack’s fear was starting to be replaced by anger. It was this trait that guaranteed that if he’d stayed in London, if he’d have been dragged further into the gang culture than he already was like his older brother, he would have ended up in prison or dead. It was his brother who had scrambled to get the money together for Zack, his sister and his mum to uproot and head north to Chester, where their mum’s cousins had settled. It was his brother who had spurred him on to find something he enjoyed doing in school and stick with it despite not living by that same doctrine himself. His brother had been shot less than two months after the rest of the family had moved and that had been a massive wake-up call. Zack had come a long way from the boy he once was, but he was being threatened. People he regarded almost as family were being threatened. And if they couldn’t flee together, then he would do the only thing he could—fight.

The anger continued to simmer. The werewolf, if that’s what it really was, scared the hell out of him. He wasn’t oblivious to the fact that things like that shouldn’t exist and part of him still believed they couldn’t exist despite what his eyes were seeing.

He stepped forward, holding the makeshift club in both hands as the machete-wielding figure and the beast of legend continued their vigil. He felt a presence by his side and turned to see Javed standing there with a slightly shorter club in one hand and his phone in the other, shining the torch directly at the wolf thing as if it was some kind of protective ray that would repel it.

The beam wobbled a little as did the teenager’s hand. “It’s like something straight out of a film.”

“What?” Zack said, his head flicking from one predator to the next and back again.

“I said it’s like something straight out of a film.”

“I wish it was, buddy. If this was a film, we could hit rewind and turn that pissing minibus around before we reached the bridge; then at least we’d end up in Pitlochry at some time tonight rather than being stuck in the

middle of a fucking huge forest with some psycho and a fucking werewolf after us.”



“Claire. You’re going to have to try to move, girl,” Millie said, crouching down by her friend’s side, taking a tight hold of her arm.

Claire’s eyes remained closed as she tried her hardest to manage the pain. “I can’t. I can’t do anything right this minute. It’ll probably clear soon, but it doesn’t matter. You need to take the kids and get out of here.” She finally looked towards her friend in the dim glow of the torchlight. “Please.”



Amanda never liked running much in PE. When they played football, she always hovered back, talking to the goalie. She’d faked injuries, she’d done pretty much everything she could to get out of it, and now she wished she hadn’t. She was already starting to get a stitch, but that didn’t matter. Nothing was going to stop her.

She wasn’t sure how far they had travelled since taking that turnoff, but she wouldn’t stop until she found help. Finding help would make it look like she had a reason for fleeing and leaving her friends beyond cowardice.

She heard a sound to her right and her eyes flicked towards the woodland. Fear bristled through her once more and she wondered if it was the man or the wolf creature. *Could they have already killed the others and now be after me?*

The thought made her run faster still. The stitch was gone again, replaced by the sensation of a timpani drum pounding in her chest.

Bu-boom, bu-boom, bu-boom.

CHAPTER 8

Kayla and Ethan remained in a state of shocked and bewildered disbelief as the music continued to pipe through the speakers.

“None of this makes sense,” Ethan said.

“What?”

“It’s just ... crazy.”

“That’s exactly what it is. That’s exactly what these people are.”

“Do you think this is an abandoned loony bin or something and this lot were just left behind? I mean, this looks like a proper operating theatre. It’s not like someone could just knock one of these up and put it in their cellar, is it?”

“I don’t think it matters that much where we are—” she sucked in another sob “—as much as what happens to us.”

“No, but I mean, if the others got away, if they got away and raised the alarm, then the local police would surely know about this place. They’d know it was in the area and it would probably be one of the first places they’d look. I mean a big building in the middle of nowhere, miles away from houses or any other civilisation. Surely that’s the first place they’d check out, right?”

“I suppose. But like you said, Ethan, we’re miles away from anywhere, just like Miss T and the others are miles away from anywhere. By the time they get help, it will probably be too late. And if you’re right, if this is an abandoned madhouse and somehow these people are still living here, then how do we know there aren’t more psychos out there looking for them?”

There was another pause in the conversation before Ethan spoke again. “It’s not impossible that they flag down a car or something. I mean, until that turn-off, the roads were pretty busy. It’s not out of the realms of possibility that another car heads down that road and gives them a lift back to somewhere they can get a signal and—”

“I know you’re trying to make me feel better. But I think we should spend our last few minutes thinking about nice things, good things, the

good things that have happened in our lives, rather than focusing on a rescue that isn't going to happen." She tilted her head towards him.

"I'm not ready to go."

Kayla sniffed back another tear, but as she became more resigned to what was going on, she understood that she'd have to show some strength for Ethan now. "Me neither, but—"

The doors opened again and their conversation came to a halt as they lifted their heads and stared towards them. There was a loud clatter and then a second as two instrument trolleys were wheeled in. The comical bear outfits were gone now, replaced by medical scrubs, all apart from the younger woman who was wearing what looked like a stripper's nurse costume. It was open down to her chest. She wore a nurse's cap, short skirt, black stockings and high heels. Even more black liner underscored her eyes than before and both Ethan and Kayla would have given anything for them all to be back in the teddy bear outfits.

"Well, now. How are our patients?" asked Dr Lavender.

"At least we're not fucking mental," Ethan said, staring her directly in the eyes.

"You know, that's not very polite."

"Oh, I'm sorry. I never studied up on what etiquette to use when you get kidnapped by a bunch of fucking psychos."

She gave him another glare. "I think the sooner we put you under the better. Oh, and by the way, in the spirit of impulsivity, we decided to switch things up a bit tonight. We had a coin toss to see who would get to work on whom. I'm happy to announce that Dr Razzle Dazzle and I will be working on you," she announced, turning to Kayla, "while Nurse Mitzy Glitzy and my husband—"

"Mummy!" the nurse protested.

"Sorry. Force of habit. Nurse Mitzy Glitzy and Dr Rupert will be working on you." She placed a hand on Ethan's shoulder and kept it there despite his attempts to shake it free.

Kayla's head turned back towards the ceiling as memories of their last victim flooded her mind. Killing someone was one thing, but desecrating their body in such a way was *twisted, evil, sick*. She didn't quite have the words to do it justice.

"So, Dr Razzle Dazzle," the older woman continued. "Have you got any thoughts on what procedure we should carry out first?"

Razzle Dazzle looked towards the one-way mirror nervously.

“Your work has always been exquisite, Doctor,” the older man said. “Just because you’re being scored on this one, don’t let that put you off. I have little doubt that it will be another triumph.”

There was a pause before Razzle Dazzle spoke. “I think ... I think...”

“Yes? We’re all waiting in eager anticipation.”

“I think I need a few more moments to think.”

“I see. Very well,” Dr Rupert said, turning to the nurse. “Have you any ideas what procedure you’re going to plump for first?”

Another pause. “Yes. Yes, I have.”

“Oh. Well, please do tell.”

The eyes of the others were fixed firmly on her now as well. “I think ... I think a nosadictomy.”

Razzle Dazzle and Lavender immediately let out gasps. “Are you sure?” Rupert asked. “That’s a very bold decision.”

She looked to her father with considered sincerity in her eyes. “Yes. I believe I’m ready.”

The music stopped momentarily and the sound of a cheering football crowd blared through the speakers.

“Not fair. NOT FAIR!” shouted Razzle Dazzle. “I never get cheering. Not fair.”

“Come now,” Rupert replied. “You must be supportive. Nurse Mitzy Glitzy has always supported you.”

“You’re all fucking mad. Out of your fucking minds, the lot of you,” Ethan said.

The cheering stopped and the music began once more. The nurse picked up a syringe from the trolley and was about to place the needle in Ethan’s neck when Rupert spoke. “I realise you’re keen to get going, but what are we forgetting? Patient care, Nurse. Bedside manner. All these things are important, so what must we do?”

She placed the syringe back down on the trolley and a momentary sadness crept over her. “I’m sorry. I’m forgetting myself. I should explain to the patient in clear terms exactly what’s going to happen.”

“Very good.”

“I never forget that,” Razzle Dazzle said.

“What were you just told about being supportive?”

The younger man shook his head irritably and folded his arms before Mitzy Glitzy continued. "I've diagnosed you with a rare condition called Uglifaciosis."

"Fuck you," Ethan spat.

She continued unperturbed. "I believe that by performing a nosadictomy you will be permanently cured of this condition."

"Fuck you, bitch!"

"It's a relatively simple procedure where we remove your oinker and your John Thomas and we swap them over. This will not only give your face a new and far more interesting focal point, thus taking the attention away from the overall blandness of it, but the added bonus is when you make peepee, you will have two holes, which will result in much faster relief on the bladder."

Rupert and Lavender started clapping, but Razzle Dazzle's arms remained folded. "Very well done. Very well done, indeed, Nurse," Lavender said.

"Let me out of here. LET ME FUCKING OUT OF HERE!"

"The patient is obviously showing signs of distress. I believe we should administer the magic potion," Mitzy Glitzy said.

"You mean the anaesthetic?" Rupert replied.

"Yes."

"Very well, Nurse. I'm at your service."

"Very well." The younger woman picked up the syringe again and gone were the brave words Ethan had spouted earlier. He started to cry again and Kayla matched him sob for sob. The medical team all looked towards one another and began to mimic the cries, Razzle Dazzle joining in now too, his sulking forgotten for the time being.

They carried on for almost a minute, crying and pleading louder than their victims before all bursting out laughing, leaving the two patients to cry alone.

"I'm sorry I wasn't supportive earlier," Razzle Dazzle said, extending a hand towards the young nurse.

A sudden wave of emotion brought a tear to Mitzy Glitzy's eye and mascara rode the back of it down her cheek. "That means a lot to me, Doctor. Thank you."

"I hope the operation goes well."

"I hope yours does."

“We’re very, very proud of you both,” Lavender admitted as she and Rupert stood shoulder to shoulder, looking quite emotional too.

“Thank you,” Mitzy Glitzy replied. “Well, I think it’s time we got started.”



The figures had stayed put, almost glued to the spot just watching them while, in turn, they were watched too.

“Please, go,” Claire begged again, but it was clear nobody had any intention of leaving her.

“Javed’s right,” said Natalie, who had remained largely silent up until now.

“What do you mean?” Millie asked, still by Claire’s side.

“It’s exactly like a film.”

“What do you mean, Natalie?”

“*Moor Dogs*.”

“What?”

“What?” Zack echoed, his eyes still flitting between the two terrifying figures.

“That movie that came out a couple of years back. Y’know, *Moor Dogs*. The one about that family that rents a holiday cottage and a pack of werewolves descends on them. That thing looks exactly like it just came off the set.”

“So what? So maybe they struck lucky; maybe someone had actually got up close and personal with one of these things before and that’s where the whole idea came from. Maybe—” Before he could finish his thought, a fist-sized rock flew towards the wolf creature, launched from Natalie’s hand with the force of a major league pitcher.

It whistled through the air, a fast-moving black missile disguised by the darkness of the forest. It thudded against the chest of the creature who exclaimed a very human, “Oofff!” as its statuesque pose crumbled and it staggered back, doubling over a little and bringing its claws up to where the rock had struck it.

“That look or sound like a werewolf to you?” Natalie asked.

“Holy shit!” Javed cried. “She’s right.”

“You’re dressing up in costumes to fucking scare us?” Zack asked, his rage notching up a level now, in part humiliated by believing this thing to be a real monster. He took a step towards the figure with the machete. “Come on then. You want to play games. Let’s fucking play.”

The tall man looked across at the one dressed in the werewolf outfit before returning his gaze to Zack. He pivoted a little from foot to foot as if he wasn’t quite sure what to do. Zack continued to advance slowly.

Natalie launched another rock, roughly the same size but more jagged this time. It smashed the costumed figure against his clavicle. “OW! STOP THAT. STOP THAT NOW. THAT’S NOT WHAT’S MEANT TO HAPPEN!” The voice was that of a man, but it sounded as if he was on the verge of tears.

“YOU STOP IT!” the machete-wielding figure cried. “YOU ALWAYS SPOIL THINGS.”

Zack halted, his brow furrowing a little, confused as to what the hell was going on.

“You have no right to say that. You take that back,” the costumed man said, finally pulling off the werewolf head and looking towards his cohort.

“I won’t take it back. I told you there was no way you’d be able to do this and I was right. Again. And what’s more, you’ve slowed us down. We promised we’d be back in time. We’re not going to be back in time now and we promised. I told you that costume wasn’t practical.”

“It is too practical. I just have to get used to it.”

“Some werewolf. You couldn’t even keep up with them. Werewolves are meant to be lithe and powerful. You were lumbering around like an overweight bulldog.”

“What the hell’s going on?” Claire asked, wondering if her head was about to explode.

“I’ve got no idea,” Millie replied, finally leaving her side and walking forward to join Zack.

“Who are you people and what have you done with our friends?”

“NAARRGGH!” The man in the wolf costume screamed as Natalie launched another rock, this time smashing him against the side of his head. He raised his werewolf hand up to his temple and withdrew it to see blood matting the grey hair. “NOOO!” He turned and started running away as quickly as he could, but as they all watched, there was nothing frightening about him now. He lumbered more than ran, eventually disappearing from

view, all the time screaming, “THIS WASN’T MEANT TO HAPPEN. THIS WASN’T HOW IT WAS MEANT TO BE!” like some spoilt child on the verge of tears.

“Come on then, freak,” Zack said, raising the club up like a baseball bat, ready to swing at the man with the machete if he made a move. Javed and Millie both shone their torches towards the figure and he flinched away from the light a little. Even though the werewolf costume was obviously fake there was something about this other man that told them the human mask he wore was real. He continued to pivot from foot to foot and none of them were sure if it was a prelude to a charge.

“Please,” Claire said, stepping forward to join the others. “Please tell us where our friends are. Tell us what you’ve done with them.”

The figure turned to the spot where the wannabe wolfman had disappeared moments before then turned back to the assembled quintet. He began to speak quietly to himself rather than anyone else.

“I told him. I told him and now I’m left alone to deal with this. It’s all left to me now. Father’s going to be so disappointed. No. Angry. Father’s going to be angry and that’s not good. That’s not good for anyone. He’ll be angry that we didn’t claim a prize, but he’ll be even angrier that we’re late. We’re never meant to be late, never. He showed us trust and we betrayed it and now he’s going to be so, so angry. Bad things. Only bad things will happen now.”

“I can’t hear what you’re saying,” Claire called out, taking another step forward.

“Careful, Miss,” Zack said, taking hold of her arm, stopping her from moving any closer to the figure who still held the machete by his side.

“And Mother. She’ll be ashamed. It reflects badly on the whole family something like this. It doesn’t matter that it’s his fault. She insisted that I let him play, and I did, and now look where I am. We’re late and everything’s turning bad. Very, very bad. He always spoils everything. Him and his stupid costumes. He never thinks about the practicalities. It’s just play, play, play. Life’s like one big game to him.” He shook his head irritably as he spoke.

“This guy is seven cans short of a six pack, Miss,” Zack said with the club still resting on his shoulder and his other hand still grasped around his teacher’s arm.

“What shall we do?” Millie asked.

“Well, we can’t just carry on running through the woods with a machete-wielding maniac and whatever that thing was still milling about in the shadows.”

There was a loud whistle, followed by a thud as Natalie launched a fourth rock. It struck the threatening figure square in the forehead and he fell silent, staggering back and bringing his hand up to his masked face.

“Zack, no!” Claire cried weakly as her brash pupil suddenly bolted.

He ran and swung at the same time, covering the few metres in what seemed like just a couple of seconds. It was as if the machete-wielding man hadn’t even seen him. WHUMPH! WHUMPH! WHUMPH!

The violence of the display took Claire, Millie and the others aback. They knew about Zack’s past. They knew he had rubbed shoulders with some unsavoury characters when he’d been down in London, but they’d never witnessed firsthand the brutality he was capable of.

The torch beams stayed on him as he stood over the downed figure. He stooped, picking up the machete, still a little out of breath. The others finally joined him, the torches dancing around the forest a little to see if the wolf man had made a return.

“Jesus, Zack. He could have killed you,” Millie said.

“Nah,” Zack replied. “Nat got him good.” He turned to look at her. “Nice throw, girl. That was four on the bounce. Where the hell did you learn to do that?”

“In my garden. Granted, they were a bit bigger than wickets, and the rocks weren’t exactly corky balls, but they took care of business.”

“Is he dead?” Javed asked as they all stood around the motionless man on the ground.

“Dunno,” Zack replied, crouching and peeling the mask off.

The man was young, but his head of white hair made him look older than he was. Nataile’s throw had pierced the stitching on the mask and split his eyebrow and forehead creating a bloody gash.

Millie crouched down on the man’s other side and placed her fingers on his neck. “There’s a pulse.”

“Oh, thank God,” Claire replied.

“Thank God?” Zack said. “We should finish the fucker off.”

“We’re not finishing anybody off, Zack.”

“They might have killed our friends for all we know.”

“We don’t know what’s going on right now. He’s incapacitated. We don’t need to kill him.”

“We should tie him up, though, Miss,” Javed said.

“With what exactly?”

“Hold these,” Zack said, handing the machete and club to Millie before starting to unbuckle the man’s belt and unloop his bootlaces.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 9

Mitzy Glitzy was about to administer the anaesthetic when the music stopped and everyone turned to look at the speakers before their heads angled to the one-way mirror.

“Daddy. You’d better come in here, quick,” announced the voice.

“It’s Dr Rupert,” Mitzy Glitzy shouted angrily, taking several paces towards the mirror. “And he can’t go anywhere; we’re about to operate, Kevin no title, and no job and no friends.”

“Nurse!” Lavender snapped.

Mitzy Glitzy hung her head. “I knew this would happen. I knew someone would try to spoil—”

“You called her Mummy a few minutes ago,” Kevin responded through the speakers.

“I did not.”

“You did too.”

“I—”

“You did, I’m afraid,” Lavender interrupted. “I didn’t want to say anything because you seemed so upset, but you did.”

A recording of the conversation suddenly started to play through the speakers and the young nurse started to cry. “I don’t remember that. Why don’t I remember?”

“Because you’re a fucking whack job,” Ethan said.

Mitzy Glitzy turned, grabbing a scalpel from the trolley, and lunged towards the teenager, leaping onto the table and straddling him. She pinned his neck with one hand while bringing the razor-sharp knife up to his right eye. “YOU DON’T THINK I’LL DO IT? YOU DON’T THINK I’LL DO IT?” Her voice was unrecognisable from a few seconds before. It was like a lion’s roar. Her eyes bored holes through Ethan’s and all the bravado was gone now as he lay trapped, seconds away from death. “YOU SHOW ME MORE RESPECT, BOY!”

She's insane. She's completely insane. He'd heard the term "a mad look in their eye" on a number of occasions, but he'd never witnessed such a literal example of it. She was totally detached from reality, from consequence.

Rupert cleared his throat. "Nurse. Nurse!"

She spun around. Her terrifying glare even made her father pause for a second before he stepped forward, putting his hand out. "Come. Give me the scalpel, Nurse. You were doing so well."

"He has no right to disrespect me."

"You're absolutely right. But once you've carried out the procedure, he won't be able to, will he?"

She pulled back a little, still keeping her hand around his neck for the moment but loosening her grip. "The procedure. I'm forgetting myself. I took an oath and my responsibility should always be to my patient first and foremost."

"You didn't take an oath," Razzle Dazzle replied. "Only doctors take oaths."

She jumped down off the bed and ran towards her brother. "WELL, I TOOK ONE!"

"She's quite right, Dr Razzle Dazzle. Don't you remember? You were there," Rupert said.

Razzle Dazzle put his hand up to his head. "Yes. Yes, I do now. I'm sorry."

Some of the bluster left Mitzy Glitzy. "Well. Alright then."

"I think you really need to get in here now." Kevin's voice came over the speaker once more.

Rupert let out a long sigh. "Do you think, just for once, we could do something as a family without it being so stressful? Is that really too much to ask?" He marched towards the double doors.



"What is it, my boy?" Rupert asked, entering the room behind the one-way mirror. He glanced towards his wife and children, who were congregated between the two tables awaiting his return, before turning his gaze to his son.

Kevin weighed close to twenty-four stones. His head was shaved and this room was where he spent most of his life. He had practically built it from scratch. He had two laptop computers open in front of him and there was a wall of split-screen monitors featuring dozens of live camera feeds. He had hooked up every single camera himself. Kevin liked to watch. He liked to watch everything. There were camera feeds from the forest, the road, and the house. Plus there were other feeds that no one, not even his parents or his siblings, knew about. If his parents found out about those feeds, he'd be in a lot of trouble. A lot.

"One of them seems to have got back to the road," Kevin replied, tapping a button and getting a camera shot of a young woman running away from view.

"Where is that?"

"It's on the perimeter."

"And you're only just telling me?"

Kevin hung his head. "I'm sorry. I was too busy trying to find Ben and Oli."

"What do you mean trying to find them?"

Kevin hung his head. "Um...."

"What aren't you telling me?"

"Ben went out in the wolf costume."

Rupert slumped into the chair next to his son. "I blame myself. I tell you all it's important to express yourselves, that you can be anything you want to be, and...." He shook his head despairingly. "Where did you last see them?"

"They were about three hundred metres from the boneyard."

"So close? When was this?"

"About ten minutes ago."

"And you can't see them?" he asked, squinting and glancing from image to image on the display screens.

"I-I'm sure I'll pick them up again in a minute, but I thought we should deal with her first."

"I have to say this is very disappointing, Kevin. You're the glue that holds everything together here. You're the one we rely on more than anyone and for you to let this happen, well ... I just don't know. Like I say, disappointing."

"I'm sorry, Daddy."

“Yes. Yes. I suppose you are.” Rupert picked up an old LCD monitor the younger man had been trying to repair and smashed it against the side of Kevin’s face.

His son let out a pained cry, sliding from his swivel chair and onto the floor. “I’m sorry, Daddy. I’m sorry,” he repeated, holding up his left arm in defence as the older man brought the monitor down again, this time hitting him on top of his head. There was a loud echoing crack as the plastic casing splintered. “DADDY! NO! PLEASE!” the younger man cried. Tears erupted from his eyes as he crab crawled backwards as fast as he could towards the wall.

“We’ve given you everything. EVERYTHING!” He flung what remained of the device at his son. “You make me sick. All you do is sit there and eat and eat and sit there like some fat, fat, fat hippo boy. If your mother and I wanted a hippo we’d have gone to the zoo and got one, but no. We had you. We had you and we gave you everything. EVERYTHING! Useless fat Hippo Boy. Get back to your hippo chair and find Ben and Oli. Do you think you can do that, Hippo Boy?”

Kevin just sat there on the floor, sobbing. His father only called him Hippo Boy when he was really, really angry. “Y-yes, Daddy.”

“What’s going on in here?” Lavender asked, barging into what was essentially a control room of sorts.

“One of them’s made it back to the road and Kevin can’t find Ben or Oli.”

Lavender let out a sigh of frustration then walked across to her son, who was still cowering on the floor. “Are you alright, darling?” She crouched down and put a hand on his shoulder.

Kevin let out a sob before answering. “Y-yes, Mummy.”

She nodded before unleashing a powerful back-handed strike. Kevin let out another cry, immediately curling into a ball as Lavender jumped to her feet and began to kick him. “We let you spend all this money on cameras and screens.” KICK. “We let you find yourself.” KICK. “We let you do what you want.” KICK. “Be the person you want to be.” KICK. “And you can’t even perform one simple task. You’re meant to protect this family.” KICK. “That’s your purpose. You’re meant to see all and know all, Kevin.” She stood back with her hands on her hips, a thin sheen of sweat already visible on her forehead.

“I’m sorry, Mummy. I’m sorry.”

She looked towards Rupert. "Well, that's the evening totally ruined."

"No, no, no," her husband replied, walking across to her and grasping her hands. "I'll take care of this. Everything will be back on track before you know it." He brought up his wife's hands to his lips and kissed them gently.

"Have you seen the time?"

Rupert turned to the clock and all the colour drained from his face. "Oh, no. Oh, no, no, no. They're going to be late. They're going to be late and that won't be good. It won't be good for anyone."



"How are you feeling?" Millie asked with a guiding hand on Claire's back as the five of them trekked through the forest.

"My head's eased a bit. I just wish I knew what the hell was going on."

"Look, the sooner we get a signal or get help the sooner we'll be able to figure that out, but right now, we just need to get back to the road."

"Are we sure this is the way?"

"I think so," Javed replied. The three students were walking together in front, their torches panning around looking for the man in the wolf costume or any other potential threats.

"This is the most mental thing I've ever heard of," said Natalie. "One guy in a werewolf costume, another psycho wearing what looked like a pretty realistic mask made of human skin, us lost in the forest, our friends getting abducted. I mean, what the hell is this? Are we on some new reality TV game show or something?"

"I wish we were," Zack replied. "But if it was a game show, they wouldn't be using real machetes." He plucked the weapon from his belt and shone it in the torch beam. "Actors don't carry things like this." He glanced over his shoulder. "You should have let me finish him. I can't guarantee those laces and that belt will keep him secure. He could be after us again before too long."

"You've got his machete now. I doubt if he'd come after us unarmed," Claire replied.

"I suppose."

"At least the storm's stopped," Natalie said.

“Yeah. Three of our friends are missing, but at least the weather’s shaped up.”

“You know what I mean,” she replied, play-punching him.

“Yeah.”

“Do you think the others are okay?”

“I don’t know,” Claire replied. “I really hope so. But the sooner we can get help the better it’s going to be for everyone.”



Amanda had slowed down from a run to a brisk walk. She felt like she’d already covered miles, but she couldn’t be sure. There’d been no markers on the road and one stretch looked exactly the same as another.

She had not used her phone torch since leaving the forest. The moon provided enough light for her to see where she was going and she most certainly did not want to attract any unwanted attention from anything or anyone lurking in the woods.

God, I hope they’re all okay.

The guilt still lay heavy on her despite everything she’d done to convince herself that these actions were going to save her friends. She raised her phone up and said a silent prayer.

“Come on. One bar. That’s all I need. One bar. Is that too much to—” Her words were cut off by a sound. “Is that?”

There was a curve in the road up ahead, but she was certain she wasn’t imagining this. “It’s a car. It’s only a bloody car.” She started running in the direction of the noise and as she approached the bend, her excitement and relief ratcheted up a level as the diffused illumination of distant headlights reflected on the trees.

She veered into the middle of the carriageway, deciding it was worth the risk of getting knocked down in order to gain their attention, in order to get help for her friends.

“HELP! HELP ME! PLEASE!” she cried as the vehicle finally came into view.

For a moment, it showed no signs of slowing down and Amanda thought she was going to have to dive at the last second in order to avoid getting run over, but then, eventually, the brakes were applied and it came to a stop.

She wasn't great at identifying cars, but she could tell from the symbol on the front it was a Mercedes and it looked big and old-fashioned like it was from the seventies. It was a dark colour, maybe blue or black, and everything about it said vintage.

The window rolled down and a man popped his head out. "Car trouble?" he asked.

"Yeah. And more besides," Amanda replied. "I need the police."

"Police? Why? What's happened?"

Don't say werewolf. Make it sound like you're not a crazy person.

"Two of my friends have been abducted."

"Abducted?"

"Yeah. My other friends are still in the forest and I'm scared that—"

"Say no more. Get in. Mobiles are useless out here, but you can use our house phone. We're only five minutes away."

She'd been warned a thousand times about getting into cars with people she didn't know, but these were extreme circumstances and what was the alternative?

She ran around to the passenger side and opened the door, only then seeing a woman in the back seat.

"Um."

"Oh, that's my wife. She can't travel in the front seat without getting car sick. Fine in the back though. Go figure," the man said.

"Err ... okay. Thank you for this."

"Not at all," the woman replied. "It sounds like you've had quite a night."

No sooner was she in the car than the driver performed a three-point turn. Within seconds, they were heading in the opposite direction. "You wouldn't believe me if I told you. I just hope my friends are all still okay."

"I'm sure they are, my dear," the woman replied. "As long as Mitzi hasn't got impatient."

"What?" Amanda replied, confused.

The driver turned towards her. "When we left, your friends were in perfect health, but I'd be lying if I told you our children weren't a dash impulsive now and again. Sometimes, they can just start something on a whim with no regard for anyone but themselves."

Amanda unfastened her seatbelt and opened the door, leaping out of the still-moving vehicle and falling onto the road.

“AAGGHH!” Her knees and arms banged heavily on the tarmac as she rolled. She cast split-second glances towards her hands to see blood, seemingly black in the glow of the moon, painting each of them where the flesh had been ripped from her palms. The screech of brakes sent a wave of terror rushing through her and the vehicle started to reverse.

Got to get up. Got to get up now, she ordered herself, but pain spasmed and her body flopped down for a moment. “Get up, Amanda. Get up now.” This time, her fear beat the agony and she climbed to her feet. Another tortured flare stabbed her right ankle, making her stumble a little, and before she could even reach the roadside—CRUNCH!

She was airborne, flying through the night like an owl. Her arms flailed before she smashed down on the tarmac, flesh tearing from her cheeks as she skidded across the surface.

“NOAAGGHH!” It was a new level of pain and, in addition to the cuts, bruises and sprains from before, she was certain her leg was broken too. She breathed in fits like a pregnant woman trying to manage contractions as she angled her head around and down.

The brake lights of the Mercedes, stationary a few metres away, gave a hellish view to the scene as she surveyed the damage in the red glow.

Oh God.

Her leg below the knee jutted at an impossible angle. She started to cry tears of pain, torment and fear as the doors to the car opened and the occupants got out.

“Well, that was rather silly, wasn’t it?” the woman said. “Didn’t your mother ever tell you that it was dangerous to get out of a moving vehicle?”

Amanda looked up to see the pair looming over her. “Pretty thing though,” the man said. “You can forgive a pretty thing all sorts of misdemeanours.”

“True.”

“Never mind, my dear. You’re in luck. It just so happens we have a first-class medical facility where we’re going and it’s staffed by people who’ll be virtually falling over themselves to treat you.”

“No. Please, no.”

“Come, come. Let’s get you in the car, shall we?” Rupert and Lavender crouched down, grabbing hold of the teenager’s two arms and one good leg before lifting her.

“NOO-OO, PLE-EASE!” Amanda howled in pain as her broken limb flopped against the ground. They lifted her a little higher, carrying her across to the open rear door before manoeuvring her in.

“Heavier than you look,” Lavender said as she placed her down. “Maybe we should do a little lipo while you’re under.”

Rupert laughed. “Oh, you are so wicked,” he said, stepping towards her and taking hold of her hand. The moonlight made her eyes sparkle and he leaned in and kissed her. “You’re just as beautiful as the day we met.”

“You always say the sweetest things,” she replied, tiptoeing up to kiss him.

Their soon-to-be patient let out another cry of agony as she writhed on the back seat.

“Just telling the truth, my dear. Just telling the truth.”

“I’d better sit in the back with her. We don’t want her jumping out again. There might be nothing left by the time we get home.”

“You make a good point. We’ll have to make sure that Oli and Ben are back before we go to the theatre. Time’s running out and you know what will happen if everybody doesn’t get their treatment on time.” He shook his head nervously. “Can you believe he went out in that wolf outfit? I mean, how irresponsible.”

She squeezed his hand a little tighter. “You can’t blame Ben or Oli for that. We enthused about it. Maybe too much so.”

“Well, he made it to perfection, but I never thought he was going to wear it outside. I mean, how impractical. And on a night like tonight. Can you imagine what it’s going to smell like?”

“Nevertheless, we praised him when he made it and this was obviously his way of seeking our approval once more.”

“Honestly, I’ve never known children with such a thirst for praise. They’re all so competitive.”

“Ple-ease,” Amanda begged. “Ple-ase let me go.”

“I’d almost forgotten she was there,” Lavender replied, finally turning back to the open door. “As doctors, we swore the Hippocratic oath. We wouldn’t be able to live with ourselves knowing that we left you suffering out here.”

The sound of a distant engine suddenly cut through the otherwise quiet night and the two doctors shared a concerned glance. “Come on. We’d better get out of here,” Rupert said.

Lavender lifted Amanda's shoulders and squeezed in, closing the door behind her while Rupert ran back around to the driver's side. Within a few seconds, they were moving, and after a few more seconds, the shining beams of headlights coming towards them lit up the interior of the car.

"HELP! HELP Meee!" Amanda's words became muffled as Lavender placed a hand over her mouth and pushed down.

"Nobody's going to hear you. Nobody's ever going to hear you again." She sounded like the Wicked Witch of the West from *The Wizard of Oz* as she spoke and a chill ran through Amanda despite her pain.

Tears continued to sting her eyes as the two vehicles drew level and then went their separate ways. She tried to struggle, to lean up, but the woman was stronger, much stronger, than her frame suggested.

As the inside of the vehicle became dark again, the fight left Amanda. Her body went limp and Lavender began to stroke her head like a beloved pet.

"Don't worry," Rupert said. "We'll be there soon. We'll get you fixed up good and proper."

CHAPTER 10

They couldn't feel any trace of wind now in the forest or hear it for that matter. The clouds seemed to have stopped moving just as quickly when they caught sight of them through the canopy of the trees, and the moon shone brightly, illuminating a large clearing up ahead.

They came to a stop as they entered and Claire sat down on a tree stump. "Are you okay, Miss T?" Natalie asked.

"Yeah. Actually, my head's feeling a lot better now, thanks. You three are special, y'know that?"

"I've been telling you that about Javed for the longest time."

They all managed a small laugh. "I'm serious. All three of you saved us back there."

"Do you think that man dressed as the werewolf is coming back?"

Claire shook her head. "I've got absolutely no idea. I've got no idea what's going on at all. I can't even be sure that we're heading back to the road. We got all turned around in there and—"

"I could climb a tree," Zack said.

"What are you talking about?"

"I could climb a tree and see if I can see lights or something."

"You're going to climb a tree in the pitch darkness? I don't think so somehow. Plus, it would have to be taller than the other trees; otherwise, you'd just be looking at treetops. It's pretty hard to tell in the dark when all we've got are phone torches."

"So, what are we going to do?"

"We just keep on walking. This forest can't go on forever."

"It can if we walk in circles," Javed replied.

"Yeah, thanks for that."

"Sorry, Miss."

"What do you think's happened to the others?" Natalie asked. "Do you suppose those freaks have got them?"

"We should go back," Zack said.

“What are you on about?”

“We should go back to where we left the nutty death mask dude. We should interrogate him when he wakes up.”

“There are multiple problems with that.” It was Millie who spoke now.

“Like what?”

“We don’t know when he’ll wake up. That was a hell of a battering you gave him. He could be out for hours. He might not know where the others are. We saw two of them, but who’s to say there aren’t more? Everything I gathered from that conversation said that werewolf outfit was too cumbersome for the other guy even to keep up, so it’s not out of the realms of possibility that there are more people in the woods, or at least there were more in the woods when Ethan and the others were taken. And even if we did go back, if he woke up and told us where the others were, it doesn’t leave us any closer to getting them. Our priority is getting a phone signal and getting help.”

“Do you think they’re still alive?” Javed asked.

Silence hung in the air for a moment. “We’ve been through this,” Claire said, taking over. “There was no sign of a struggle. There was—”

“I know all that, Miss. But we’ve been out here a while now and—”

“We’ve got to remain positive,” she replied, climbing to her feet once more. “We’ve got to remain positive and stay strong. It’s our only way out of this.”



“Movement!” Kevin’s words came through the speaker and Mitzy Glitzy looked towards the doors. She had been left alone in the operating room. She wasn’t interested in where her brother was. She had hovered between the two tables, contemplating having fun with each of the bound victims without the others present.

If I operated on both of them, there’s not a lot they could do about it, is there? Razzle Dazzle has had all the fun for the longest time and I’ve just been allowed to play with the leftovers. Well, this would be payback.

Her better angels, if there were such things in Mitzi, talked her out of it, not for Razzle Dazzle’s sake but for hers. As fun as it would be to have her way with them both, the punishment that would ensue would be legendary. *Razzle Dazzle’s always been their favourite.*

She finally pulled her eyes away from the crying teenagers and headed to the double doors, barging them open and stepping out into the corridor. She let out a frustrated breath and stamped her foot. She was angry with herself that she wasn't giving in to her inner voice. There were always a lot of voices in her head, but sometimes she just wanted to be herself, be free to do what she really wanted to do. She'd had thoughts about killing her brother. In fact, no, that wasn't quite true. She'd had thoughts about killing all of them and her parents too. She loved them, but she was of the belief that she could love them just as much if they were dead, and she'd be free. *FREE!*

But then there was the practical side of things. Food, the running of the house. More and more had been left to Kevin. Kevin was the one who dealt with the delivery people. He was the one who took the car for its MOT. He was the main contact with the outside. *When he's dressed and has his wig on, he looks like any other ugly, fat loser. Fat. Fat. Fat. Fat. FAT! FAT!*

I hate him. I hate his fat cheeks and his fat chin and his fat belly, the way it hangs over the top of his trousers, sometimes busting out of his T-shirt. I hate him, hate him, hate him.

"What movement?" she demanded as she walked into the control room.

"I think ... I think it might be Ben."

"What do you mean you think?" *God, I hate you so much.* She walked up to the control desk and stood beside him while he brought the image up on the screen. The smashed monitor sat on the surface next to him and Mitzi turned to look at her brother in the glow of the monitors. A streak of blood ran down the side of his face from beneath a hastily patched bandage and she could see he'd been crying. Mother and Father had the power to do that. They had the power to unleash hurt in many ways.

Mitzi turned, hugging her brother and kissing him on the top of his head. "It's alright, Kev-Kev. It's alright. Mitzi still loves you." She pulled him into her bosom and he started to cry again. Kev-Kev was the term of endearment she used for him all through growing up. When he was sad, she used to hold him and kiss him as if she were his mother and not Lavender, despite them being the same age. "It's alright, Kev-Kev."

"Does Mitzi love Kev-Kev?"

"Yes," she replied, pulling him closer. "Mitzi loves her little fat lump. She loves every saturated cell in his body." *It's true. I do love him. But I hate him too. I love him. And I hate him. I love him and I hate him. Love.*

Hate. LOVE. HATE. HATE. HATE. HATE. HATE. She let go of him, pulling back with something close to a snarl on her face. It was only fleeting, but Kevin caught sight of it.

“Um. See,” he said, pointing to the screen. Mitzi had a tendency to behave even more erratically, thanks to their father. Especially when it got close to medicine time. Two a day, every day. Nine in the morning and nine at night. “I hope Mummy and Daddy will be back soon.”

Mitzi’s eyes flared for a second then she stroked the back of her brother’s bald, fat head. *FAT! FAT! FAT!*

She moved in closer to the screen. “What’s he doing?”

“It looks like he’s circling the house.”

“But why?”

“I don’t know.”

“And why is he carrying his wolf’s head?”

“I don’t know.”

“He’s going to be in a lot of trouble when he gets back. Mummy and Daddy told him under no circumstances must he go out in that.”

“He’s coming,” Kevin said as Ben finally broke into a run, leaving the concealment of the bushes behind and dashing across the expansive courtyard. “Should we—” Before he could finish his thought, Mitzi was out of the door. He switched cameras and now the focus was on the grand entrance foyer.

Twenty seconds later, Ben entered the main doors. It was obvious he was trying to be as quiet as possible, like a teenager sneaking in after curfew. He walked across the chess-tiled floor to the staircase, all the time holding his werewolf head.

Kevin closed in to see a bloody patch beneath his splayed fingers. “You’re in big trouble.” It was Mitzi’s voice and Kevin panned the camera out, revealing her standing at the bottom of the staircase.

“Don’t tell. Please don’t tell.”

“It’s too late for that, Ben. Mummy and Daddy know everything.”

“No. No. Say it’s a fib. Say they don’t.”

“It’s not a fib. They know. They’ve had to go out. We were just about to operate and you’ve spoiled everything. You’ve spoiled the evening, the day, the entire week. You’ve spoiled the year. **YOU’VE SPOILED EVERYTHING!**”

He flopped down onto the step, dropping the wolf's head he'd been cradling under his left arm. Like a bouncing ball, it plopped onto each stair before it came to rest at Mitzi's feet.

"I wanted to make them proud. I was going to bring them all back. I was going to—"

"You need to grow up. That's your problem," she said, putting her hands on her hips. And where's Oli?"

"I don't know."

"What do you mean you don't know? You were told to stay together. You were told you had to stay together and make sure you were both back in time."

He sat there for a moment cradling his head; then he slowly rose to his feet. "You're not my mother. You're not in charge of me. You don't tell me what to do."

A smile lit Mitzi's face. This was the confrontation she'd been hoping to provoke. She hated Ben. He was the youngest, the last one out of their mother, and he got an unfair amount of leeway as a result. It made Mitzi angry. There was a part of her that loved him too, but there was so much hate. *Hate, hate, hate.*

"I'm older than you. That means I'm in charge when Mummy and Daddy aren't here."

"Why aren't they here?" The aggression rising in him dissipated and the second mention of his parents being absent finally made him question why.

"They've had to go out and clean up your mess. They were so angry. So, so angry. I don't think I've ever seen them so angry. I think they might put you in the cellar when they get back."

Ben started crying. "Take it back."

"I can't. I think they will. I think they'll put you in the cellar. I've never seen them angrier. They called you a hideous disappointment and said you were unlucky number five. They said life would be so much better with just four children."

Ben started crying even louder. "Stop it. Stop saying things." He put his hands up over his ears.

"DISAPPOINTMENT. DISAPPOINTMENT. DISAPPOINTMENT!" Mitzi screamed from the foot of the stairs. "DISAPPOINTMENT!"

Ben rushed down the stairs, grabbed the werewolf head, then turned and ran up the staircase. "I don't believe you. I don't believe you," he repeated between hopeless sobs. "I'll prove to them I'm not a disappointment. I'll prove it. Maybe I wasn't ready to become a werewolf yet, but I can do other things. I can do other things."

A snarling grin darkened Mitzi's expression further as she watched her brother disappear from the long landing and down the hallway.

Hate him!



"What do you suppose is going on?" Kayla asked, lifting her head ever so slightly to look towards the mirror. "Do you think it's some kind of trick and they're all just behind there watching us?" When Ethan didn't answer, she turned her head towards him.

Tears were streaming from his eyes again. "I thought I'd got my hand free, but they're double strapped. I thought I was going to get us out of here."

"Ethan. Ethan, look at me." He turned towards her, his eyes full of sadness and regret. "It's okay. Whatever happens happens. We just have to accept it."

A huff of a laugh left his lips. "How can you be so casual about it?"

"I'm not. I'm scared to death. I'm more scared than I've ever been, but I'd be more scared if I was alone. We have to accept we've lost this one. There's no way out. Somehow, we've wound up in Psycho Central and that's the end of it."

He shook his head. "I'm not prepared to give up. I can't give up."

"Ethan, we're strapped down to operating tables. There's no escape. This is it. This is how we're going to die."

CHAPTER 11

Zack and Javed stayed a few paces ahead of the others, searching out as many dark corners as they could with their torches.

“What is it with boys and the need to be in the lead?” Natalie asked.

Claire and Millie laughed. “If you come up with the answer to that, sweetheart, you’ll earn a million,” Claire replied.

“I heard that,” Javed said, calling over his shoulder.

“Wait a minute,” Zack ordered, coming to an immediate stop.

“What is it?” Claire asked, trying to see what he was seeing in the beam of torchlight.

“Just stay here a second,” he said, continuing forward alone.

“Zack. We all need to stay together.”

“Just a minute, Miss T,” he replied, walking up to a tree and starting to scale it.

“I told you that won’t do any good and I don’t want you climbing in the dark. It’s crazy.”

Despite her warnings, he continued, finally coming to rest on a bough about fifteen feet up. He straddled the sturdy limb, retrieving his phone and angling the beam along. *It is. It fucking is.* He’d caught sight of it in a flash of LED light, not believing it was what he thought it was, but now it was just a couple of feet away from him and he was sure.

“It’s a trail cam,” he called down.

“What?” the others replied in chorus.

“It’s a fucking trail cam.” He undid the straps, releasing the device from the tree limb and dropping it to the ground. Javed immediately retrieved it while Zack climbed down from the tree.

The five of them crowded around, examining it for a moment.

“Holy shit!” Millie hissed.

“Why would there be a trail cam out here in the middle of nowhere?” Claire asked.

“Well, Miss T,” Natalie began, “maybe we’re not in the middle of nowhere.”



Kevin’s eyes widened as the five faces crowded around the camera. “Oh no. Oh no, no, no, no, no.” The black teenager in shot grabbed the device and, suddenly, the image blurred as the camera somersaulted through the air before the screen turned blue. “Oh no, no, no, no, no.” He cradled his head for another reason now. “This isn’t meant to happen. This isn’t meant to happen. No, no, no, no, no.”

“What’s not meant to happen?”

He turned towards the doorway to see Razzle Dazzle standing there, still in his custom smock, with his hands behind his back.

“Where’ve you been?”

“I said what’s not meant to happen.”

“Nothing. Nothing. Nothing.” *Can’t trust him. Can’t trust him. He’ll make things worse. He always makes things worse. Tries to get me into trouble even when there’s no trouble to get into.* “Where’ve you been? I was looking for you.”

“Yes. You’re always looking, aren’t you, Kevin?” Razzle Dazzle replied.

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

“You know what I mean.”

“It’s my job. It’s my job to keep the place secure. Keep up with surveillance. Make sure the family’s safe.”

“Hmmm. I think you and I have different ideas about what is deemed a threat.”

“I don’t understand.”

Razzle Dazzle revealed one of his hands. Between his thumb and index finger he held a device about the size of a toothpaste tube cap. “Understand now?”

Kevin shook his head nervously. “I-I don’t know what that is.”

“You know exactly what this is.”

Kevin shook his head. “I was put in charge of surveillance. I was told I had to keep the family safe.”

“You put a camera in your sister’s bathroom. I bet there are cameras like this all over the house. Are you keeping us safe from an enemy within, Kevin?”

“You’re not meant to go snooping. You shouldn’t be in there.”

“Well, if I shouldn’t be in there, neither should you.”

“I was ... I was just doing it to—”

“Oh, I know what you were doing it for.” Razzle Dazzle’s voice was calm for the moment. Gone were the unnatural peaks and troughs as he confronted his brother and exposed his shameful secret.

“What are you going to do?”

“That depends on you.”

“Wh-What do you m-mean?”

“Wh-What do you m-mean?” Razzle Dazzle mimicked and now the strange timbre crept back into his speech a little. “Have you any idea how pathetic you sound?”

“I’m not pathetic and Daddy says you shouldn’t say things like that to me.”

“Daddy says? What do you think Daddy’s going to say when he hears about this?”

Kevin reached up to the wound on his head. “You can’t. You can’t tell him.” He suddenly lunged towards his brother and Razzle Dazzle sidestepped, starting to laugh uncontrollably as Kevin’s mighty bulk collapsed onto the floor. He struggled on the ground, trying to get up, and his brother unleashed a heavy kick, making Kevin scream loudly with pain.

“There’s a way out of this for you, Brother.”

Kevin sniffed and sobbed as he remained on his stomach, struggling to lift his heavy mass enough to climb to his knees. “It’s not fair. It shouldn’t be like this. We should all be equal.”

“Life’s not fair, Brother.”

“What do I have to do? What do I have to do to stop you telling Daddy?”

“Simple. Tell me where the pills are.”

“What?”

“The pills, Kevin. Mitzi and I may appear to be at each other’s throats constantly, but there are some areas on which we agree. One of those is that we want freedom. We want freedom from those infernal tablets. I doubt if someone like you even cares. You won’t care about the dullness that sweeps

over you when you take them. You won't care about the dimming of the fire inside. Can you even feel it? Does it register with you that the nearer we get to medication time the more we start to feel alive? Can you imagine what it would be like to live unbridled by a pharmacological fog? Can you imagine what it would be like to live life fully?"

"We have to take the tablets. We have to take them. Daddy said it would be really bad if we stopped. He said it would be really, really bad. Things would go wrong. Very, very wrong."

"No. I love Mother and Father." *I hate them too. I hate them. I really love them. And I HATE THEM.* "But they're stopping us from being who we can be. They're stopping us from fulfilling our true potential, Kevin. Even you. You're my brother and I know sometimes we haven't got on, but I love you." *HATE!* "Wouldn't you like to be everything you can be? Wouldn't you like to become truly free? All of your dreams could come true. You wouldn't just be the glorified security guard anymore."

"That's not fair. I do more than that. I do an important job."

"Yes. You do. I'm the first to admit it. You do an important job. But a job is a job is a job. They've got you working for the family rather than being a part of it. Wouldn't you like to join me and Mitzi once in a while? Wouldn't you like to go out with Ben and Oli on the hunt? Wouldn't you like to get out of this room and be more than an all-seeing eye for the family?"

"I'm good at it."

"Yes. Yes, you are. But I'm saying you should be able to spread your wings. You shouldn't have to live under the constraints that have been brought down upon you."

Kevin turned to look at all the screens. *These are my friends. The screens are my friends. They don't talk back. They don't criticise. They just let me watch.* "I'm happy here."

"Well, good for you. How about that? You're living the life you were made for, stuffing your face with pies and ice cream and milkshakes, getting fatter and fatter day by day until the point where you become useless to Mummy and Daddy. What happens when you're too fat to head into the forest and swap the cameras over when they go down? What happens when you're too fat to do anything but sit in this chair? Do you think Mummy and Daddy will look after you when you can't do what they depend on you for?"

“Th-They will.”

“You know it’s comfort eating. That’s what you do. Inside you’re sad, Kevin. You might not admit it to yourself, but you’re sad – very, very sad – and that’s why you eat. And the fatter you get the more people make fun of you; the sadder you get the more you eat for comfort. It’s a downward spiral that will only end when we come in here one day and find you’ve died of a massive heart attack, no doubt the result of exertion that came when you reached for one pie too many.”

Kevin started crying again. “Why are you so cruel? Why are you so horrible to me?”

“I’m doing this for you. I’m doing this because I love you. We’re honest with the people we love. Mummy and Daddy aren’t bothered that you’re sad. They know why you comfort eat. They know that if they gave you the chance to be truly free your life would take on an entirely new dimension and food wouldn’t be your obsession anymore, but living would. Truly living.” He held up the small camera again and Kevin finally struggled up to his knees, still with tears streaming down his face. “It’s your choice. You tell me where they keep the tablets or our parents find out your dirty little secret.”



“Oh, good grief. Oh, good grief, no,” Rupert said, looking at his watch in the glow of the dashboard light. “Have you seen the time? Have you seen the time, Lavender?”

She glanced at her own watch. “Oh, dear. Oh, dear. We’ve been remiss. Most remiss. We got carried away in the moment. There’s still time. There’s still time. We’ll assemble them all when we get back and—”

“Ben and Oli. What about Ben and Oli?”

Waves of pain still washed over Amanda, but as a seeming flood of self-doubt and insecurity washed over her captors, she didn’t know if this could be turned to her advantage. Lavender leaned forward and Amanda’s entire body shifted as she did. She let out a howl of pain, but it went unnoticed. “We’ll sedate them. Get them on a drip for twenty-four hours while we get their levels back up.”

“That worked before, but there’s no guarantee it will work again, and who’s to say the chemical imbalance won’t—WAAGGHH!”

Amanda let out a cry of pain to equal the driver's as she hoisted herself up using the headrest and swung her fist as hard as she could. The speed and force of the action took Lavender by surprise too. She was unable to act until it was too late and the old Mercedes veered, leaving the road and crashing into a stout-looking sycamore. There was an almighty bang followed by a loud hiss as a plume of steam erupted from the front grille.

Lavender hadn't had her seatbelt on and her face had mashed against the headrest of the passenger seat. Amanda had fallen into the footwells, wedging between the front and rear seats, screaming in agony as her leg jarred. Rupert just sat there, shaken, disbelieving as he watched the steam rise. He finally turned to look at his wife, whose face looked shiny and black in the glow of the dashboard lights.

"Oh, my dear," he said as Amanda continued to howl. "Oh, my dear, we must get you looked at."

Lavender held her hand up to her nose as blood poured. "We have to get home. We have to get home now."



Mitzi walked the long hallway, pausing outside her parents' room. She tried the door, knowing it would be locked, but shrugged and carried on. Tonight would be the night when everything changed. She and Ralph, or Dr Razzle Dazzle to give him his professional title, had discussed it at length. They had a plan. It was time they spread their wings. Thirty years was too long. It had been fifteen years since they'd been taken out of school, giving up contact with anyone outside of the family, other than the odd patient of course.

But it was no way to live. It was no way to live taking tablet after tablet. Dulling their senses, their true sense of being. They only started feeling alive when it got near to tablet time. They only started feeling like their true selves. Then one pill and the sensations, the tingling electricity that sent every pleasure impulse in their bodies into overdrive, would dim again. But not anymore. Not after tonight. They were waiting for a distraction and this was it. Not one patient but a whole gaggle of patients trapped and with nowhere to go. That was enough of a diversion to escape the chemical prison their parents insisted on keeping them in.

She and Ralph were the oldest. They came out several minutes before the others. It was their responsibility to fix this. A smile lit her face as she thought of her brother for a moment before it turned to a grimace.

After tonight, there would be no going back. After tonight, there would need to be realignment as well. “Mitzi’s not going to play second fiddle anymore.”

She barged through the door of the end room to find Ben standing naked by the window, just looking out. There were no lights on, but the blue moonlight made the tears streaking his face glisten.

“You should knock,” he snapped. “I’m a person too. I deserve respect. You should knock.” He dragged the fingers of his left hand across his cheek in the hope he could disguise his upset, but the tell-tale sniff gave it away.

Mitzi loved her little brother. But she hated him too. *Hate. Hate. Hate.* “I think your room is my absolute favourite in the whole house,” she said, stepping inside and closing the door behind her.

“What are you doing? You shouldn’t be in here. This is my personal space and Mummy and Daddy said that nobody should invade my personal space.”

“I’m here to help. I’m here to help you.”

“Help me? Help me how?”

“I really love this room.” It was a shrine to horror films new and old. Ben and Oli shared it. It was bigger even than the master bedroom and their bunks were at opposite ends. There was a long rail down the centre where a curtain could be drawn across if they so wished, but neither of them wished. The room was like a museum. There were collector’s pieces from fifties B-movies, posters as well as costumes and props they made themselves. They were more than a little obsessed. Consumed, one could say.

“You’re not here to make fun?” he asked, looking at the discarded werewolf costume on his bed.

“I’m not here to make fun.”

“Why are you here?”

“I told you. To help you.” *Hate him. But I love him too. But Hate. He’s weak. Weak and easy to manipulate, and.... Ooh, I hate him so much. But I love him.* “Come and sit with me,” she said, walking over to his bed.

He sat down beside her. His breath was still shaking with upset. “The costume was ill-judged.”

“You have no right to—”

“I don’t mean to upset you, Benny. But it was. It was and it threw Mummy and Daddy into a rage like I’ve never seen.”

He started crying again. “No. Please say that isn’t so. Please, Mitzi. Please say that isn’t so.”

She reached out and took his hand. “Don’t worry. I told you I was here to help.”

“Help? Help how?”

“We become free tonight. We escape the prison we’ve been in for so long. We get to reach our full potential and there’ll be no going back.”

“What do you mean?”

She pointed to the bedside clock. “See what time it is.”

“It’s nearly pill time.”

Mitzi nodded. “It’s nearly pill time. But there won’t be any pills tonight. There won’t be any pills ever again. You, me, Ralph, Oli, Kevin and even Mummy and Daddy are going to become butterflies. We’ve been in our little cocoons too long and now we get to spread our wings. No constraints. Nobody telling us what to do anymore.”

“But—”

She put a finger up to his mouth. “No buts, Benny.” She looked around the room. “I really love what you and Oli have done. It’s my favourite room in the house.”

“Is it really?”

She nodded. “You deserve to be happy,” she said, looking towards a replica of an outfit he’d made inspired by one of his favourite films. His parents had forbidden him from wearing it for several reasons, but occasionally, when there was no one else around, he’d try it on and stand in front of the mirror admiring himself. “Put it on. Put it on for me, Benny.”

“Seriously?”

Mitzi nodded. “I’d like to see it.”

He didn’t need asking twice. He almost ran to the mannequin and proceeded to slip on the costume one piece at a time. “I didn’t think you liked it.”

“I love it. Just like I love you, Little Brother.”

“I have to be careful with the head. The fangs sometimes flip inwards and—” He didn’t need to go on. This was one of the reasons his parents didn’t let him wear the costume. The first time he’d put it on, the row of razor-sharp fangs had almost stapled his upper lip to his gums. That had

been a long time since, but the wounds were still visible. Now he always took extra care when putting that part of the costume on. He placed it over his head and moved his jaw around a little, getting it into position. Then, finally, he attached his wings.

"You look fantastic," Mitzi said as he stood there in the complete get-up.

"You know, *Curse of the Man Bat* was considered a B-movie, but it helped shape vampires in modern cinema. Sure, there were some old stereotypes used, but there were so many more original ideas too."

"You'd know more about that than me, Benny."

He looked at the clock again. "I'd better take it off before Mummy and —"

"Keep it on. I told you. No more pills, Benny. We get to be the people we want to be from now on. Show me the wings."

The creepy, bald vampire face with its row of fangs turned towards her. She couldn't see her brother's eyes, but she could tell he was staring at her from behind the mask, weighing her up, trying to figure out if he could trust her or whether this was one of her cruel jokes. "I shouldn't really."

"You are the Man Bat, Benny. You are him and he is you. Mummy and Daddy didn't want you to wear that costume because they wanted to stop your becoming. They knew they'd lose their little Benny and he'd become the realisation he was always meant to be."

He retreated a couple of paces, brought up his arms, and tipped his neck back. There was a barely audible click followed by a much louder one as two giant bat wings flicked out from underneath his cloak. "There," he said excitedly.

Mitzi clapped loudly and laughed. "You're so clever. You're so clever, Benny. I love you so much." *HATE!*

"Can you help me put them back in?"

You fucking imbecile. You're like some kind of brain-damaged child. Fucking idiot. Cretin. "What do I need to do again?" she asked, walking behind him then angling him around to the window so she could see what she was doing.

"See the handle? Push it up."

This was another reason her parents didn't want him wearing this costume. The wings were spring loaded and Oli had nearly lost a finger

helping him retract them before now. Mitzi cranked the handle and there was a loud clatter as the wings shot back into their packed position.

“There,” she said, jumping away in fear the contraption might eject again. “It looks great on you.”

“Thank you, Mitzi,” he said, turning around.

She reached out, touching the cheek of the vampire head he wore. “Things are going to be very different from now on.”

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 12

Kevin watched as his brother poured another bottle of tablets down the toilet. “Where are the rest?” he asked.

“That’s it. That’s all there are,” Kevin replied.

Razzle pulled out the long drawer, checked underneath it, and then smashed it over Kevin’s head.

“OWWW!” he cried, falling back onto the floor. “Why? Why did you do that?” he sobbed, placing his hand on his scalp as a fresh bloody wound appeared. “Why do you treat me this way?”

“Where are the rest?” Razzle demanded once more.

Kevin had two cameras in his parents’ bedroom. If they ever found out, he’d be in more trouble than he would be for having a camera in Mitzi’s bathroom. Watching people when they didn’t know they were being watched gave Kevin power. Becoming all seeing, all knowing was what he was destined for. He was like God in many ways. Always watching, always seeing, always knowing more than those he looked upon.

It had been difficult getting the cameras in position. One of them was built into a lamp. It was an antique and his father had asked him to rewire it. Kevin was good with electrics and electronics. He was good with lots of things. He’d learnt most of it from the internet, teaching himself how to install spurs, new sockets, and even rewire whole rooms. When his father had asked him to do the lamp, he had fitted a tiny camera into the mosaic base. It was virtually undetectable. Someone would have to examine it very closely to see it, and he knew his parents were far too busy, far too consumed by their own work to waste time looking for something that shouldn’t even be there.

It was perfect. It fed off the mains and worked even when the lamp was off. The other was in the air duct above the door. This was a little trickier. He fitted it from the corresponding duct in the hallway. It ran on a battery pack that needed changing every two weeks or so, but there were plenty of occasions when this part of the house was unoccupied, and as he was

responsible for a number of maintenance jobs, he was sure he could come up with a relevant excuse if he was ever caught.

He sobbed again as he withdrew his hand to see even more blood. They were in a room adjacent to the main bedroom. There was a small keypad on the wall next to the door and it had taken Kevin the best part of a week, studying his parents entering the code once in the morning and once in the evening, to figure out exactly what it was. He didn't ever expect or want to use it, but he had to know. Kevin had to know everything. He felt like he was becoming so much more than he was, than what others expected him to be.

He knew people's secrets, their habits. He knew them by watching them, watching them when they thought no eyes were on them. "It's not fair," he sobbed once more. "You shouldn't treat me this way."

"The toothpaste's already out of the tube, Kevin. We broke in here," Razzle said, gesturing to the outer door, which he had literally stoved in with an axe. "You think by saving their last little stash of pills, that's somehow going to keep you in their good books? I know about all the cameras in this house. All of them."

"Y-you can't. You can't know."

Razzle's eyes sparkled and an unhinged grin swept across his face. "The other week, when the man from the power company came to the door and you had to waddle your way to the main entrance in double quick time, you minimised one of your screens, but you didn't exit. I really would have expected you to be more careful."

Kevin's bottom lip began to quiver and more tears ran down his face. *How could I have been so careless?* "But—"

"But we were occupied? Yes. We were operating on the Lithuanian hiker, but we paused when the bell rang. I went into the control room to check the monitors to see who it was and I was about to head back into the theatre when I saw your hastily discarded jam doughnut threatening to ooze all over the console. I moved it out of the way and that's when I saw a shrunk screen on the toolbar at the bottom. I'll give you this, Kevin. I've searched the computer fifty times since and haven't been able to find it, but I found it that day. There were more than a dozen live feeds up and one playing back of Mitzi in the shower. Your own sister, Kevin. What would Mummy and Daddy make of that? Well, I think—"

“There’s a false back,” Kevin admitted as he let out a shuddering breath.

“What?”

“The chest. I saw Mummy take the drawer out once and put her hand in. It was when the supplier had mixed up our order. She reached in, pressed something and brought out a bag.”

Razzle raised his left eyebrow and bent over, looking into the empty space where the drawer that was now lying in pieces on the floor had been. He reached in and pressed the white panel at the back of the chest of drawers and a narrow door clicked open, revealing several more bags of pills. He grabbed them all and straightened up with a self-satisfied expression painting his face. “There. That wasn’t too hard, was it?”

He left Kevin quietly sobbing as he went into the bathroom and poured them into the toilet.



“This is bad. This is bad. This is bad. This is bad,” Rupert said, pacing up and down outside the car.

“W-we just need to think. Logic is our friend,” Lavender replied. “Logic has always been our friend.”

Despite her pain, despite everything else that was happening, Amanda had noticed a shift in the erraticism of her pair of abductors in the last few moments. It was as if a switch had been flicked inside them.

“We’re going to have to set off on foot.”

“It’s nearly four miles.”

“By road, maybe. But if we cut through the forest, it’s barely half a mile.”

“And what about her?”

They both looked towards the open rear door of the car as a loud hiss of steam continued to spurt from the engine. “We ... we can’t carry her.”

“No.”

“It’s such a shame. Such a waste.”

“Yes, but what are the alternatives?”

“I suppose we could hide her and come back in the Bedford.”

“That old thing? Rupert, it’s a classic, but—”

“Kevin’s kept up with it. He replaced the spark plugs just the other week.”

“It’s too much of a risk. What if someone discovered her?”

“We could tie her and gag her.”

“It’s still too much of a risk, I say.”

“She’s got a broken leg and who knows what other injuries. It’s not like she’s going to run away.”

“I’m aware she’s got a broken leg. Are you suggesting I can’t see that she has a broken leg?” she asked angrily.

“I was just—” He broke off and the simmering tension between them dissipated in an instant as the headlights of a car appeared on the horizon. It was travelling in the direction they had been travelling, coming ever closer as they stood there by the side of the road.

“What are we going to do? What are we going to do, Rupert?”

“This is getting messy. Very, very messy. Mess, mess, mess. Mess, mess, mess, mess, mess. I don’t like mess.”

“It’s true,” Lavender said, looking into the back of the car. “He really doesn’t like mess. It irritates him. Angers him. Throws him off his game. In truth,” she continued, “I don’t like mess either. Order. That’s how a lab should be run. Order, order, order, order, order.”

They’re out of their fucking minds. Amanda was in agony but somehow transfixed by the surreal saga playing out by the roadside.

They both stood there looking towards the approaching vehicle as the engine gradually got louder and louder.

“Mess, mess, mess, mess, mess, mess.”

“Order, order, order, order, order, order.”

It was as if not just their words were like needles stuck on vinyl repeating the same thought over and over, but their entire bodies were too. Rupert’s head nodded a little each time he spoke and a shudder ran down Amanda’s spine in spite of the heat of pain she was feeling in her leg.

“Need to take control,” Rupert said. “Need to take control of the situation.”

“Yes. Yes, Rupert. You need to take control,” Lavender agreed.

Rupert finally jolted into action, opening the boot and starting to rummage around. “This is bad. This is very, very bad,” he kept repeating as he lifted the carpet that covered the spare tyre.

The car slowed down as it approached the site of the collision and Amanda immediately started screaming at the top of her voice. Lavender, realising she had a part to play in this too, piled into the back and covered Amanda's mouth with one hand while pinning her neck with the other.

"You could have flashed us or something to tell us that the bridge was out," the driver said as he came to a stop and lowered his window.

"I beg your pardon," Rupert replied, walking up to the other car with his hands behind his back.

"The bridge. You could have tried to warn us it was out."

"The bridge is out?"

"You didn't know?" The man looked towards his passenger a little confused. "How could you not know? You were coming from that direction."

"Um. Um. We didn't get that far. I left my wallet at h-home and ... and I turned around to head b-back for it."

"Ah. Well. I suppose you had a good reason not to warn us then." He unbuckled his belt. "You've had a bit of prang." He started opening the door.

"Yes. A fox ran out and—"

"NAAAGGGHHH!" It had been a long time since Lavender had experienced such a level of pain. Her captive had shifted her head violently and then bit down with everything she had. Even in the subdued light, she could see a bloody, pitted semicircle on her hand as she withdrew it.

"HELLLPPP! HELP! HELLP!" Amanda managed to scream before being hammered by Lavender's tightly clenched fist.

The man paused, his door half open as he looked towards the skewed Mercedes.

Mess. Mess. Mess. Mess. Mess. Rupert felt like crying. He hated things unravelling. He hated it when his plans didn't work out. He hated having to think on the hop, on the spur of the moment. *Order. That's all I want. Order. Is that too much to ask?*

He reached in, grabbing the man by the shoulder of his jacket as he desperately tried to shut the door. It was Rupert's turn to let out a scream of pain now as his arm got caught. But still, he didn't let go. He yanked hard and the driver fell out onto the road, smashing against the tarmac.

He was tall and well-built. *If he gets up, it's all over.* In Rupert's other hand, the hand which had remained behind his back up until this second, he

held a tyre iron.

More screams erupted from the Mercedes as another battle ensued in the back seat, but they were nothing compared to the screams of the passenger as Rupert began to smash the iron down on the driver's head, again and again, and again. It only took three hits to render him unconscious, but still, he continued, and still the woman screamed and screamed and screamed, just watching in bewildered terror, unable to remove her seatbelt and try to help her husband or even to escape herself.

There was a loud crack accompanying the hollow thud on the seventh strike and an arc of blood sprayed, painting Rupert's face, then the ceiling of the car, then finally the crying, screaming, petrified woman.

The man was undoubtedly dead by now. *Dead. Dead. Dead.* But still, Rupert carried on, strike after strike after strike. More blood sprayed over him. *Mess. Mess. Mess. Mess and disorder. Disorder and Mess. Mess and disorder.*

The screams continued from the back of the Mercedes. The screams continued from the woman in the passenger seat and all Rupert wanted was a few minutes' silence to think, to get his thoughts straight. *Is that really too much to ask?*

Another section of skull caved. In some places, it was virtually flat, almost squashing into the road, but still ... still he could not bring himself to stop. Yes, it was messy. Very, very messy. But with the rhythm of the pounding against the driver's head, there was just the tiniest little bit of order. And order gave Rupert comfort. So he continued to pound and smash.

"Rupert."

He shot bolt upright as he felt a hand on his shoulder and swung around with the tyre iron ready to strike again. His face, arms and clothes were covered in blood. His white hair was no longer visible beneath the seemingly black goo that shone in the moonlight.

Screams still echoed up and down the road from the passenger seat and the rear seat of their own crashed vehicle as the engine of the Renault Clio idled. Rupert stared at his wife in the moonlight for a moment, almost as if he was looking at a stranger.

"Lavender," he eventually said, as if he'd only just remembered her name. He looked towards his clenched fist as blood drizzled down the long, heavy tool and over his skin. He turned to see there was nothing recognisable as a head on his victim now. There were only shoots of bone

and sinew sprouting from his neck like flowers from a vase. He brought his hand up to his temple, touching it gently as if it were some kind of reset button. "We must get back."

"Yes. It's most urgent. Most urgent that we get back, Rupert. I can feel it. I can feel it fighting to break loose."

"Yes," he said, trying his hardest to marshal his thoughts. He glanced at the body again and had no recollection of how it had got into such a state. The sound of a door clicking open made them both look up and it was only then that they realised the woman in the passenger seat had stopped screaming. She almost fell out of the car on the other side and scrambled to her feet.

"Get her!" Lavender hissed. Time was of the essence. No, worse than that. They were now on borrowed time. They could both feel the change in themselves since the crash and they could only guess it would be a hundred times more amplified for their offspring. They had been dependent on the tablets much longer. They required a higher dose.

Rupert burst into a sprint. His head was racing at a hundred thoughts a minute and, for the time being, anyway, his body was keeping up. The woman was already entering the forest by the time he'd reached the verge, but he possessed a steely determination as he gripped the tyre iron harder than ever.

"Where do you think you're going?" he asked in an almost animalistic growl. He didn't recognise the voice that came from his own lips as he grabbed his victim's hair.

She tried her hardest to continue running despite the drag. She rocked her head violently, trying to shake her pursuer free, but it was no good. "Let go of me. Let go of me," she cried hopelessly. "Let go of me," she pleaded one last time before letting out a scream of pain as he yanked her back to the road. They both emerged into the moonlight a moment later. By which time she had given up trying to run. She was like a beaten dog, stooped, allowing herself to be dragged by her long hair as if it were a leash.

"What do we do with her?" he asked, returning to Lavender, who was already bundling Amanda into the back of the Renault Clio, heralding another fanfare of pained screams. His wife straightened up and looked at the young woman. She wore a short black dress and it looked as if she and her companion had been either heading out or heading back from a night out.

“Well, we can’t very well leave her here, can we?” The woman looked down at the remains of her husband and started sobbing hopelessly. “Get rid of his body. Get her in the car. Let’s get home, do what we need to do, then you and Kevin can come back and sort out this mess,” she said, gesturing to the crashed Mercedes. “And let’s just hope nobody comes by in the interim.”

“B-but what about Ben and Oli and the other strangers?” His voice was panicked. The thoughts kept rushing. Fear, paranoia, dread, anger, confusion. All his feelings settled over him at the same time like a giant wet blanket that it was impossible to escape from beneath.

“I DON’T KNOW. I DON’T KNOW. I DON’T KNOW!” Lavender screamed, leaning forward, her face mere centimetres from his. “Questions, questions, questions and no answers. Questions. One after another, after another, after another. Questions. Ben, Oli, strangers, Ben, Oli, strangers, Ben, Oli, strangers.” It was as if her words were caught in a loop. “BEN, OLII, STRANGERS!” she screamed at the top of her voice and Rupert flinched a little.

“You’re fucking mad,” the young woman sobbed. “You’re both fucking mad.”

Lavender’s head shot towards her. “That is so rude. That is just so rude. You’ve only just met us. How could you possibly make an assertion like that?” She grabbed the tyre iron from her husband, who was still holding the woman by her hair, and then struck. “RUDE. RUDE. RUDE. RUDE. RUDE.” With each shouted word came another strike. The woman fell to the ground, her body convulsing and juddering. Lavender dropped to her knees beside her, continuing to unleash her fury. “DIDN’T YOUR PARENTS TEACH YOU ANYTHING?” she screamed, smashing and beating and cracking until the iron was just hitting tarmac. Lavender pulled back, flinging her weapon away like it was burning her. She jumped to her feet, her eyes wide.

“Lavender?” Rupert asked after a full minute had passed and still his wife remained frozen, just staring down at her victim as Amanda continued to scream and wail.

“I think we’d better go,” Lavender said. Her face, hair and upper body were slick with blood, just like her husband’s.

“Yes. Yes. I think that would be for the best.”

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 13

Mitzi skipped down the long underground hallway that led from the house to the small medical complex. The familiar sound of “Teddy Bears’ Picnic” made the smile on her face broaden a little more as she re-entered the operating theatre.

“Hi, kids, did you miss me?” she asked before letting out an unnerving, high-pitched laugh. She walked up to the two tables. “It seems that my staff have abandoned me.” She gently stroked Kayla’s head. “You are a pretty thing, aren’t you?” She bent over and kissed her.

“Puh. Puh. Puhh! Fuck off, freak,” Kayla cried, cringing, pulling away and twisting her head as much as she could with the constraints still in place.

Mitzi laughed and leaned back, looking at both her patients in turn. “Y’know. It occurred to me on the way down here that I’m free to do whatever I want now. I don’t need to impress anyone. I don’t need acceptance. I just want to be me. I just want to be and do and have all the things I want.” She turned to Ethan. “I wasn’t going to do your nosadictomy because it was what I wanted; I was going to do it because my parents expect results. They’ve always been very results oriented.” She shook her head. “Sad in a way. They’ve missed out on so much in life as a result.”

“Like having kids who aren’t complete fucking loons?” Ethan said.

Mitzi’s head jolted towards him and there was anger on her face for a few seconds, but it dissipated just as quickly. She stepped forward, clamping his cheeks between her hands and kissed him on the lips too. He struggled, just as Kayla had, and when Mitzi pulled back, there was an unfathomable expression on her face. “Y’see. It’s a bit of a madhouse up there tonight. All sorts of distractions taking place, and that gives me time down here with you. And that’s good. That’s a good thing because today is the first day of the rest of our lives and I want my life to be amazing. I want my life to be fantastic. I want to be able to have everything I’ve ever wanted and it dawned on me as I came down here that I could.”

“Let us go, you crazy, crazy bitch. Please let us go,” Ethan said, continuing to pull against his restraints.

“Y’see. In many ways, I’m just like anyone else.”

“I beg to fucking differ,” Kayla said in a shivering breath while trying her hardest to be brave at the same time.

“I want someone to share things with, to be with, to love, just like Mummy and Daddy. I know we haven’t got off to the best of starts. I can feel a lot of resentment in this room, but we can work on that.”

Ethan looked across at Kayla, who looked back at him. They were both crying silent tears as they realised their end was looming closer than ever. “Just block it out, Kay. Just don’t listen to anything.” He said the words, but it was impossible. The insane nurse had centre stage and “Teddy Bears’ Picnic” continued to play through the speakers. It was impossible to block any of it out.

“My problem is that I’m greedy,” Mitzi said.

“Seriously,” Kayla replied, “that is really the least of your fucking problems.”

Mitzi looked at her coldly for a moment and then smiled, walking over to the table and caressing her face. “Y’see. I like boys. But I like girls too. We’ve had a lot of both through here and girls are much, much better kissers.” She turned to look at Ethan. “Sorry, but it’s true.”

“How many people have you murdered? How many people have died on these tables?” he asked.

Mitzi straightened up. “Not every operation is a complete success, I’ll grant you that. But this one is going to be my crowning achievement.” She walked over to Ethan’s table and gently ran her fingers down his entire body before looking across at Kayla. “Just imagine having all the fun of this with your pretty head thrown into the bargain too. It would be perfect, beyond perfect. All the manliness of a man and all the gentleness of a woman rolled into one. All my desires satisfied at the same time.”

“What the fuck are you talking about?” Ethan asked.

Mitzi laid a hand on his chest and gently tweezed the growth of black hair between her fingers. “Don’t worry. This is going to work so well for you too. I mean, I can tell you like each other.”

“What the hell are you on about, you crazy bitch?” Kayla asked this time.

Mitzi giggled to herself. “Oh, my God, I kind of envy you in a way. You’ll be able to kiss whenever you want to.” Her eyes started dancing and she laughed now, clapping to herself. “Neither of you would ever feel lonely. You’d always have each other, and I’d have both of you.”

“I’ll ask again,” Ethan said. “WHAT THE FUCK ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT?”

Mitzi pulled away and walked across to the trolley, taking an object that she immediately placed behind her back before heading around to the other side of Kayla’s operating table. She finally revealed it like a magician unveiling the prestige. It was a butcher’s saw. It gleamed in the light of the room.

“I know. I know what you’re thinking. Really, I should be using a Gigli saw for an operation like this, and technically you’re right, but I’ve never been able to perfect the method and the last thing I want is to mess this up. I mean, if I don’t cut low enough, nothing will be level. You won’t be able to kiss when I attach her head to your shoulder and, frankly, that will look a little freakish too, and yes, that sounds shallow because it’s the person inside that counts and not just looks, but y’know, sue me for being shallow. If I’m going to go to all this effort, I don’t want to be looking at something that grosses me out when it comes to doing oomphy doompies in the bedroom.”

“Ethan! ETHAN!” Kayla screamed as a fresh flood of tears gushed. She stared at him, frozen in terror, waiting for the touch of the blade against her neck as he watched on.

“Oh, yeah. Look, I’m really sorry about this,” Mitzi said, pulling her patient’s face towards her. “Mummy and Daddy only left one syringe full of magic potion, and if everything goes to plan, your part in this should be over pretty quickly. Handsome’s going to have the hard part, so I think it’s only fair that we save it for him, yes?”

Kayla’s chest heaved as she continued to sob hopelessly. “Ple-ease.”

“Oh, don’t cry. Don’t cry,” Mitzi said, bending down and kissing her on the lips again. This time, there was no fight, there was no protest, there was no convulsion. “Mm. Salty. I’d better put some moisturiser on you when we’re done, otherwise your skin’s going to dry up like a teabag in the sun.” She paused for a second before placing the blade of the saw against Kayla’s neck, who had now turned back towards Ethan.

“It’s alright, Kay,” he said. “I’m here with you, girl. I’m here. And I’ll come and find you on the other side, when we’re back with all the people we’ve lost.”

“Oh, good grief,” Mitzi hissed. “I don’t know what’s wrong with me today.” They both turned to look at her as she withdrew the saw and marched back around the table to the trolley. She reached down and grabbed a pair of safety glasses, placing them on and returning to her position. “Please forgive me. I should be better prepared; that was most unprofessional.

“Let her go,” Ethan said. “I’ll stay here. I’ll do whatever you want. You can do whatever you want to me. But please let her go.”

“A gent. That’s what you are,” Mitzi said. “Don’t worry. She’s not leaving you. After tonight, you’ll be closer than ever. We’ll all be closer than ever.” She placed her right hand on Kayla’s chin and pressed the saw down on her neck with her left. She waited for a moment as “Teddy Bears’ Picnic” came to an end once more. Silence rang out through the speakers for just a few seconds before it started again. Mitzi smiled and her head started nodding in time with the music and then, finally, the blade began to move.

“NOOO! NOOO! NAARRGGHH! CHCLLLCCCLLL!” It was only seconds before the razor-sharp stainless steel teeth penetrated Kayla’s windpipe and her pleas were drowned out by the sound of her own blood entering the narrow tube.

Crimson suffering sprayed like a fountain of ink painting Mitzi’s face, glasses and clothes. She staggered back surprised by the sheer volume of warm liquid. It dribbled down her forehead and through the narrow gap between her skin and the glasses, blinding her momentarily until she removed them and wiped her eyes.

Ethan looked on in tormented dread and sadness as a red geyser continued to erupt. “Kayla.” He whispered her name as she choked and spluttered, desperate to take a breath that remained tantalisingly out of reach. Her entire frame started to shake as she drowned in her own fluid.

Mitzi let out a long, deep breath and looked across to her other patient. “This is harder than it looks, y’know,” she said, returning the saw blade to the gaping fissure in Kayla’s neck. She didn’t bother with the glasses this time. *Useless. Useless, useless, useless. What’s the point of protective*

glasses if they don't protect you from anything? More blood spewed over her face and hair as she dragged the blade back and forth, back and forth.

Finally, Kayla's body fell still, the red jet diminishing to a sporadic pump and then an oozing pulse as the last strands of tissue separated beneath the serrated steel.

"There," Mitzi said, grabbing hold of Kayla's hair and holding the head up like a rabbit in a butcher's shop window. The image flashed into her head and out again just as quickly. She hated butchers' shops. She hated meat. *So cruel. So terribly, terribly cruel.* She had been a vegetarian since she was a young girl. The thought of innocent animals suffering upset her. Upset her and made her angry. *So, so angry.* "Why? Why would somebody do it?"

"What?" Ethan asked, breaking out of his horrified vigil to see if there had been a eureka moment for the psychopath who'd just murdered his friend.

"Why would someone hurt an innocent animal?" she asked with genuine sadness on her face as she continued to hold Kayla's head up. "A burger, a sausage, a steak, a momentary taste sensation. Something between two slices of bread that lived and breathed and had a family. How? How could someone do such a thing?" A tear formed in the corner of her eye and ran down her cheek, cutting a path through the blood.

"What are you talking about?" he asked through his own stinging tears.

She shook her head. "It's not a day for sadness. It's a day for new beginnings. Shape up. Shape up, shape up, shape up. It's a day for new beginnings."

Ethan's head rolled and his eyes focused on the ceiling. "I'll see you soon, Kayla."



"You shouldn't be doing any of this, any of it at all. Mummy and Daddy are going to be so furious."

Razzle had always wondered about his parents' room. He had only been in a handful of times when he was much younger, but since then, it had remained locked and off limits. The secret closet did not just house the supply of pills but other things too. It was like a museum. There were meticulously kept scrapbooks featuring article after article on fatal recessive

genes, gene therapy, Huntington's disease and other subjects relevant to their family's conditions. And then he hit the motherload. Two scrapbooks of Polaroids charting the years of procedures he had carried out with the assistance of Nurse Mitzy Glitzy of course.

Bitch. Trying to upstage me like that. He was the one his parents doted on. He was the one who always impressed them with what he did in the operating room, not her. *NOT HER.* He had wanted to think of something clever, brilliant even. He had just needed a few minutes, but then she had come out with nosadictomy. *I could have thought of that. I would have thought of that if I'd just had a moment. I would have thought of something better. Ten times better. A hundred times better, but no. She spoke and they listened and she made me look like a fool.*

He took a breath. He loved his sister. After all, she was more like him than any of the others. She was like his shadow, always trying to emulate him. *And that's the greatest compliment anyone can give.* He loved her. Together they had come up with the plan to flush the tablets when an opportunity arose. They both felt it. They both felt the upsurge, the chemical short-circuitry in their brain heightening their senses, speeding up their thought processes, making everything more vibrant, more exciting. It was like they both sensed that without the medication they could become the people they were truly meant to be. *Mitzi understands that better than any of the others.*

It had all been fantasy though. Their parents had the tablets under lock and key. They manufactured fresh batches once in a while, and when they did, none of them were allowed in the medical facility. None of the children were allowed to see before or after. They weren't allowed to know what ingredients were used or anything about the tablets. Once manufactured, they were transported to what was essentially the walk-in safe where he was now standing.

They had spoken and planned, but it had all been play. It had all been play talk like when they were children before they had changed due to the treatment. Then, when Razzle had seen that shrunken window and discovered what secrets the Blob was privy to (that was what he and Mitzi called Kevin. It was their own personal joke. Either that or Blobby Boy) things had changed. The possibilities became infinitely more plausible. Things happened from time to time. Things happened that meant Mother and Father were distracted, and tonight, Mother and Father were distracted.

Strange. Sometimes they're Mummy and Daddy. Sometimes they're Mother and Father and sometimes they're Dr Lavender and Dr Rupert. A smile lit his face as he looked at a photo of himself, Nurse Mitzy Glitzy, Dr Rupert and Dr Lavender all standing proudly behind one of his creations. It was a foreign student over here on holiday. *What was his name? What was his name?*

"Karl."

"What?" Kevin asked.

Razzle looked up as if being woken from slumber. He'd forgotten Blobby Boy was even standing there. "Nothing," he said, returning to the photo album. He had been particularly proud of this one. Karl had pleaded and pleaded and pleaded to be let go. His English was exceptional, but the problem wasn't his English. If he'd begged in a hundred different languages, it wouldn't have mattered.

He gently touched the photo, moving from the patient to each of his colleagues before settling on the nurse. *I love you, Mitzi. But I hate you for what you did tonight.*

"We need to get out of here before Mummy and Daddy come back. It will be bad, but it will be even worse if we're still here."

Razzle looked up from the photo album. "You're pathetic." He almost spat the words. "You're a sad, pathetic fat blob who nobody likes. I'm not even convinced you're one of us. I think my real brother died at the hospital and our parents just scooped you up like some consolation prize, bundling us all together and making believe that you're part of the family."

Kevin breathed in deeply. He was used to being treated badly. He was used to being made to feel like crap. But no one had ever said anything so cruel. Normally, he would go into himself, hide away in his little control room, stuffing himself with pastries and chocolate bars, making himself feel better that way. Normally, though, he didn't feel like this. He didn't feel agitated in this way. He didn't feel like all his senses were heightened, almost like there was electricity pulsing through him. The pain from before was being moulded into something else now, as were these hateful words. It was almost as if he was a sculptor. He could imagine his hands around a piece of clay, creating something new, something better, something happier, something more positive than the sad thing he was ... he had been.

Something new. Something new. Something new.

He had moulded something new. Without realising it, he had formed a fist. Razzle's eyes were fixed firmly on his brother's face, gaining sustenance from his sadness.

He hasn't noticed. He hasn't noticed. No more. I'm not going to be the butt of people's jokes any longer. He lunged. Even though he was slow, lumbering, and a little off balance, Razzle stood frozen to the spot. It was the last thing he ever expected his pathetic, sad, ugly, fat, fat, fat brother ever to do, and even as it happened, he refused to believe Kevin would go through with it, but then the oversized fist that was more used to grabbing handfuls of sweets from a box of Cadbury's Celebrations than punching connected with Razzle's jaw.

The sheer weight of force behind it made his mouth open, spitting a large glob of saliva as his head spun. The photo album flew up from his hands as he went flailing into the shelves, knocking down one after another and causing album after album to spill. He crashed down with them. Leaves, photos and articles came splaying out of the pages on top of him and all he could do was lie there as if he'd just been struck by a wrecking ball.

His confusion and disbelief amplified when what felt like a ten-tonne weight flopped down on top of him, straddling him, removing any hope of him being able to get up.

Smash! Smash! Smash! Kevin was empowered by his success and now he was making up for so many years of abuse. Razzle's face was already dyed crimson, but with each vicious swipe more blood sprayed against the white veneer of the built-in fittings. "I," punch, "deserve," punch, "respect," punch. "I," punch, "deserve," punch, "respect," punch. He repeated it over and over and over until he stopped suddenly and stared down at his brother's bloody face. His eyes widened as he realised the battered and bleeding thing beneath him was unrecognisable as Doctor Razzle Dazzle. Ralph, his brother. His victim was perfectly still and he stared at his chest to see if it was still moving.

No. No. No. Mummy and Daddy will be so angry, so angry with me.

The prospect that he might have killed his brother brought him no sadness, no guilt. It was the prospect of his parents' reaction that sent a wave of fear and regret through him. He'd never raged like this. Never. His head was in a spin when, usually, he was the organised one, the sensible one, the watcher, the protector, he who saw all and knew all.

His brother's chest moved, ever so slightly, and the panic subsided. He reached out, grabbing the top of a chest of drawers for balance, then climbed to his feet, losing his footing and staggering before steadying himself. He looked in the mirror. His fist and sleeve were coated in his brother's blood. His pale face had flecks of red splattered across it. A jolt of fear ran through him once more before a smile formed. He was becoming the person he knew he was destined to be. He could feel the change, second by second. He looked down at his brother as he lay broken at his feet and the smile magnified.

Nobody will make fun of me or bully me ever again.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 14

It seemed to have been an age since any member of the quintet had last spoken. They were all lost in their own thoughts, desperately trying to make sense of how what should have been a fun trip with friends had taken such a horrific turn.

“Are you okay, Miss T?” Zack asked eventually.

“Apart from being stuck in the middle of nowhere, losing half my students, having a bunch of psychopaths hunting us and probably dying within the next six months, I’m fine, thank you, sweetheart.”

Zack and the others laughed. “You’ve always been my favourite teacher, Miss T. All the others are like just stuffed shirts or something, but you’ve always been a good laugh.”

“Well, what isn’t there to laugh about? Tonight’s a great way for me to bow out of teaching. They’ll talk about this for years to come when teachers have a bad day; it’ll be like, ‘Well, at least you didn’t pull a Claire Trent.’ My name will be synonymous with disaster in the education system.”

“That’s not true, Miss,” Natalie piped up. “None of this was your fault. That storm brought the bridge down. We were lucky to get out with our lives. None of that was on you. And then how could you possibly have known that there were those people, nutters, whatever the hell they were in the forest?”

“It doesn’t matter. You were all my responsibility and three of you are missing right now. I just pray to God they’re going to show up safe if we can ever find a signal and get help.”

“Nobody’s going to let you take the blame for this,” Millie said. “It’s obviously all Zack’s fault. He was the one who suggested we take the diversion.”

They laughed again. “Kayla suggested it—” He broke off. He still couldn’t believe she was missing, the first one to be taken. “Do you think we’re going to see them again, Miss?”

They carried on walking for a few seconds. The momentary good humour on a night that had been devoid of any levity was now gone again. “You, Javed, Natalie, Amanda, Ethan and Kayla are among the most intelligent and resourceful people I know. Look at what you all did when we were piecing together the set for *Look Back in Anger*. We’d already blown the budget, but that didn’t stop you. You borrowed, bartered your time for favours, and all worked non-stop to get that production off the ground.”

“Yeah, but there’s a bit of a difference between that and what’s going on tonight, isn’t there?”

“My point is you’re all fighters, Zack. You don’t give up when most other people would. That’s why I feel it in my bones that we’re going to see them all again. They just need to hang on until we can get a signal, get the police, and then this whole damn forest will light up like a Christmas tree.”

“I hope you’re right, Miss.”

“I’m your teacher. I’m always right.” *Jesus. I hope I’m right.* She hoped she was right more than she’d ever hoped for anything in her life. She still couldn’t believe they were in this situation. She still couldn’t fully believe that she wasn’t in a hospital bed somewhere, the tumour pressing down on her brain, causing this, the mother of all nightmares to play out in her head, highlighting every fear and insecurity she’d experienced.

“Light,” Javed announced, flicking off his torch to make sure it wasn’t some trick of a reflection. The others did the same and a tangible excitement built in the air as a thin sliver of artificial light shone through the trees.

“We must be near the edge of the woodland,” Millie said as they switched direction and sped up, flicking their torches on once more to make sure they didn’t trip.

They finally reached the tree line and relief swept over them all as the moon shone down on a Gothic mansion set in sprawling grounds. Electric light illuminated several of the windows, suggesting there was most definitely someone at home.

“Oh, thank God,” Claire said, reaching out and squeezing Millie’s hand. “Thank God. Thank God. Thank God.” They were still about a quarter of a mile away and even though the main courtyard was in view, their approach to the property would be from the side and they’d have to negotiate a field or two before they could get the help they so badly needed.

“Come on then,” Zack said. “What are we waiting for?”



A shivering breath left the back of Oli’s throat as he woke with a start. A recollection of what had happened came back to him, hazily at first but then with more and more clarity as each second passed. He tried to sit up, only then realising his hands and feet were bound.

I warned him. I WARNED HIM. He had warned his brother about going out in the werewolf costume. *Mummy and Daddy are going to be so angry. So, so angry.* They were already on edge when they’d assembled everyone together. Kevin, who saw all and knew all, had spotted the group, seemingly lost and on foot, ambling along the lane. *It should have been straightforward. It was meant to be straightforward. There and back and we’d all have prizes under our arms. There and back.* Tablet time hadn’t been too far away, but they were close enough to the house and it wouldn’t take long.

Oli knew for a fact that Mitzi and Razzle had already claimed their prizes. He could have taken his ten times over if he didn’t have to wait for his brother. Take his prize, finish off the others, and then all of them would have new toys to play with. Razzle and Mitzi were so wasteful. Their games would be over in a matter of hours. Ben rarely knew what to do with his. He usually just mimicked whatever Oli did. But Oli relished every minute.

There was something about putting the fear of hell and damnation into a person that lit his soul. Hearing their cries, their pleading, touching their tears, smelling their fear. Fifteen weeks was his record. Fifteen weeks he’d kept one alive. *Stupid. Stupid. Stupid.* It made him so angry when she had wrapped the chain around her neck and strangled herself to death with it rather than letting him have the pleasure.

It wasn’t that he didn’t enjoy killing. He loved it. It made him feel so alive, like a god. *A GOD.*

Having the power of life and death over someone was an affirming experience. But more than the actual killing, the fear.

He would not make the same mistake again. *I’ll find a different way to contain her.* Her. He’d already decided it would be a woman. And why not? Having control over a woman made him tingle. He’d never introduce her to his John Thomas. *Mummy and Daddy wouldn’t like that.* But the threat was

always there, and that fed the fear, and that fed the deliciousness of keeping someone captive for so long. Rather than them getting used to it, the threat built the fear up and up and up. *Will today be the day? Will today be the day?* they would ask over and over in their heads.

A smile crept onto Oli's face for a second as he thought about his last prize and then it was gone again just as quickly and the fury was back. He was tied up in the middle of the forest. Someone had removed his mask, his signature mask, his terrifying mask that he had laboured on for so long. He was alone. His head hurt. *It really hurts.*

It's all because of Ben.

Ben and Oli were close. They were the only ones who shared a bedroom, and for the most part, they were in tune. They loved horror, all horror, whether it was a 1930s Bela Lugosi flick or a modern-day Blumhouse production, they couldn't get enough. They were experts. They were students of fear, absorbing every frame that made them jump. Yes, they were close and they enjoyed each other's company. Ben loved Oli and Oli loved Ben. He did. He really loved him. But he hated him too. He really hated him.

He hated him for putting on that costume. He hated him for slowing him down. He hated him for spoiling their game and he really, really hated him for Oli being tied up. *It's his fault. IT'S HIS FAULT!* his brain screamed as he pulled and flexed against the restraints.

In fact, now he came to think about it, that wasn't the only reason his brain was screaming. His brain was screaming because something was happening inside, something different.

Is it because I got hit on the head?

I can't rule that out.

It was true. He couldn't. But this felt like something else. This felt like something new.

What time is it? He and Oli had a flair for the theatrical, and although instilling terror on this group of wanderers was one of the primary aims, he would never break curfew. That would be so, so bad. Disastrous even.

His hands were still bound, but he flexed his thigh as tightly as he could. He could feel the syringe there in his pocket. *The magic potion* as Mitzi called it. There were a lot of magic potions back at the house. Some had even been used on him before now. But this particular one was so fast

acting. A hand around the mouth, a prick, a couple of seconds and the recipient was out cold.

I should have acted sooner. The second Ben started lagging behind, I should have realised this wasn't going to work and I should have acted sooner, I should have acted sooner. "I should have acted sooner."

Other than grunts, this was the first thing to leave his lips since he'd awoken. His mind was starting to race as the strange sensation in his brain amplified. *I need to get out of here. I need to get back to the house. If these people have gotten away, that's bad for the family. I can't let the family down.*

Over the years, he and the others had helped a number of wanderers find their home. The stretch of road was a long one that cut through the forest. People only ever took it on their way to somewhere. There was nothing of historical significance in the area other than their home, which was well hidden away.

They had always been very careful about those they selected up until tonight. *Tonight might have been a mistake.*

The odd hiker going missing was nothing unusual. Hikers went missing all the time. Over eight hundred a year went missing in Scotland alone and, although most of them were found safe and well, there were those who were never discovered. A fall into a ravine. A fall off a mountaintop into dense undergrowth. A misstep in peatbog and a hundred more causes, all without foul play being involved, all plausible to the seasoned search-and-rescue veteran.

The police had only shown up at the house a couple of times making general enquiries as to whether the missing person had been seen. No suspicion had ever fallen on the family. After all, before their step into virtual hermitry, Dr Rupert and Dr Lavender had been internationally renowned and respected scientists.

But this. This might be a step too far.

They had all gathered around the monitors when Kevin had alerted them to this group. He had examined the footage as far as the cameras would allow and they just seemed to walk into view from nowhere. They had outdoor clothes on but by no means were dressed for hiking. Hunched over, fending off the elements, it was actually very difficult to determine much other than five of them had a definite female gait and shape. That's the thing Oli had noticed more than anything else. He liked the female

shape. He liked it a lot. It made him tingle when he was close to a woman. *But strictly no John Thomas. Strictly no John Thomas.* Maybe one day he could introduce John Thomas to one of his victims. Maybe one day his mother and father wouldn't be so strict about it. *Maybe ... maybe maybe that day will be today.*

Danger. Yes. This situation was dangerous. Dangerous for the family. *Think, Oli. Think.*

He stopped struggling against the restraints for a moment as he rewound to the scene before blacking out. Ben was already gone. *There were how many? One, two, three, four, five. FIVE. Mitzi got one. Razzle got one. Another must have escaped. There are six of them. Six of them somewhere and it's not a big stretch to think that one of them, just one of them, just one of them, might get away, might find help, might bring our entire world crashing down around us. Yes. Maybe if I can save the family, if I can save the family, if I can save the family, maybe I can do as I please. Maybe Mummy and Daddy will allow me full power over my decisions. Maybe.*

He concentrated. He was fairly certain his hands had been bound by his own shoelaces. He could feel the ends flicking against his skin as he writhed on the ground. *There. A rock.* It might even have been the rock that first struck him. Whether it was or wasn't it didn't matter as he got to work cutting through the cotton fabric.

I'm going to save the family. I'm going to save the family. Then I'll be able to do whatever I want to do.



"SHUT UP! SHUT UP! SHUT UP! I CAN'T HEAR MYSELF THINK," Lavender screamed, nearly causing Rupert to swerve. They'd finally reached the well-concealed track that led to their home. It was once in a far better state of repair. The only people who took it now were themselves and the odd delivery truck, but the overhanging branches from the trees and the crops of bushes encroaching further year on year meant that it was a lot narrower than it used to be, almost seeming impassible in the odd stretch to the uninitiated.

He gripped the steering wheel tightly. "I'm concentrating. Can't you see I'm concentrating? Don't yell like that." He looked in the mirror at his

wife's blood-covered face as slips of moonlight peeked through the branches.

"You're telling me not to scream? What about her?"

"LET ME GO! LET ME GO! I NEED A HOSPITAL!" Amanda's shouts and pleas had become like white noise to Rupert. It was his wife's much louder, far shriller voice that had cut through his focus. Everything was an effort at the moment. Just to keep his hands still, his mind on the road, his eyes in one direction. The longer he went without the medication the harder everything was going to become. There was nothing surer.

"You'll just have to deal with it, Lavender. You'll just have to deal with it. DO YOU THINK YOU CAN DEAL WITH IT?" he yawped, half-turning in his seat for a second before spinning back around to face the road.

"Deal with it, deal with it, deal with it," Lavender repeated, rocking back and forth a little. Without realising, she'd grabbed hold of Amanda's hair and was wringing it like a wet rag, causing more pain for the teenager. *Syringe.*

After seeing the video of Amanda running along the road, they had set off with the express purpose of drugging her and taking her back home. Under normal circumstances, there would have been no pause, no hesitation, no confusion in administering the drug in order to silence her. But these were not normal circumstances.

Lavender's head had never felt like this before. It was like a thousand electrical impulses were running through her brain every second, spreading doubt after doubt, fear after fear. Her eyes flicked from Amanda to Rupert to the road, to the branches caught in the headlights, to the dashboard, to Amanda to Rupert, to Rupert, to Rupert. *How dare he yell at me like that? How dare he?*

He was the love of her life. They had met as students and fallen head over heels. She never wanted anyone else. She loved him more than anyone. *How dare he shout at me?* But at that moment, she hated him too. Hated him with the heat of the sun, of ten suns. *I hate him so much.*

Her breathing became erratic as she repeated the words over and over in her head like a mantra. All the time Amanda was screaming louder as Lavender twisted and wrung her hair ever tighter. A grimace formed on Lavender's face, then a snarl, as her eyes bore holes into the back of her husband's head. *How dare he yell at me?*

The syringe. The thought flashed in her head again, and this time, before it was gone, she reached into her pocket and grabbed it, flicking off the protective top, sticking it into Amanda's neck and depressing the plunger all in one fluid movement.

One. Two.

Silence but for the sound of the engine and the whip of the low-hanging branches against the side windows.

I hate him. Lavender's eyes returned to the back of her husband's head. It had been against her advice that he let the children out to have some fun. *Or was it the other way around?* There was something about the group on the road that she didn't like. The odd hiker or even the odd pair of hikers was fine. But this? *This was rash, foolish, dangerous, irresponsible. Rash, dangerous, foolish.* Lavender's brow furrowed as the words repeated in her head. This wasn't normal. Her head was ordered like a library using the Dewey decimal system. There was a beauty to its structure and organisation. *Repeating, repeating, repeating.* Her head was too busy, her intellect too great to *repeat, repeat, repeat*, like some parrot with a tick.

What's happening to me? "What's happening to me?" *Did I say that or just think it?*

"It's happening to me too." Rupert brought the vehicle to a halt and pulled the handbrake on before swivelling in his seat. The tips of branches continued to brush against the car. "Are you alright? Are you alright, my darling?" he asked, reaching out and offering his hand.

She leaned forward, still with Amanda on her knee, and took it. "I'm frightened. I'm frightened, Rupert."

"Yes. I think ... I think a combination of stress and not taking our medication on time has had an adverse effect on our brain chemistry. I think —" He didn't, couldn't, finish the verbalisation of his thought. Instead, he let go of his wife's hand, turned to the road and set off again. "Tablets. Tablets. Tablets. We need to take our tablets and then we'll be fine. We'll be fine. Mark my words. We'll be fine." His voice shook and, over the sound of the engine, she could hear him starting to cry.

Lavender began to cry too. She wasn't sure why. Crying was something alien to her. Even when she was told she couldn't have children, she didn't cry. When the experimental fertility treatment was successful and she found out she was going to have quintuplets, she didn't cry. When she discovered that all her children possessed the same fatal recessive gene that would cut

their lives tragically short, she didn't cry. But she was crying now. She was crying in the back seat of a Renault Clio with a stranger in her lap and a myriad of confused thoughts bouncing around her head.

What's happening to me?



Kevin didn't know why, but all of a sudden, he felt hot. He'd left his unconscious brother in their parents' bedroom and was about to head back to his control room, his sanctuary, his domain, when he stopped on the landing. He brought his palm up to his forehead and wiped it. His hand glistened as he looked at it. He stood there, wondering if it was the violent outburst that had heated him up, made him sweat, and a moment's pause would help cool him down. He waited and waited, but, if anything, he felt like he was getting hotter, not cooler.

Strange.

The mansion was notoriously hard to heat, the hallways especially, and as far as he was aware, nobody had even lit a fire today.

Hot. Hot. Hot.

He pulled off his T-shirt, revealing rolls of pale, smooth flesh. His body looked pliable, like albino sausage meat that could be squeezed directly into a casing. His head was shaved. He'd done that. But the rest of him had always lacked hair, other than the odd disjointed tuft in his pubic region. He didn't understand why. Neither did his parents. When he had gone to school with his siblings, he was subjected to horrific torment in the showers after P.E. Back then, he wasn't obese like he was now. But the name of Tufty had stuck all the way through his teenage years.

The memories of those taunts came back to him now, dialling his anger up another few notches. He looked back in the direction he'd come from and thought about going back to his parents' bedroom to unleash another barrage of punches on his brother. He was one of the ones who used to taunt, used to join in with the other boys.

Tufty. Tufty. Tufty.

Then he went to school one Monday and it turned out there'd been a party at one of the pupil's houses while his parents had been away. From then on it wasn't just the boys who taunted him.

Tufty. Tufty. Tufty.

One of the happiest days of his life was when his mother began to homeschool them so they could begin more intensive treatment. At least he didn't have to suffer the cruel barbs from others then. But his own brother had been one of the guilty ones.

He should pay. He should pay.

So hot. Still too hot.

He untied the drawstring on his jogging pants and pulled them down. Then his giant underpants, too, followed by his socks and Crocs. He even pulled off the dressing from his head. Now he was completely naked, but still he felt hot; he felt like his blood was almost boiling. He started moving again, fury still bubbling as he thought about his old nickname.

“BEHOLD!” A shout came from behind and Kevin turned to see Ben at the far end of the long landing. “I am the Man Bat.” Ben ran towards his brother, coming to a stop just a couple of metres before reaching him. There they stood for a moment, one in the meticulously designed and built replica costume from a 1950s B-movie, the other stark naked, the rolls of fat on his stomach and upper legs disguising the odd, red sore that had developed.

The seconds ticked on until, finally, Kevin just turned and walked away leaving his clothes on the landing where they fell.

CHAPTER 15

Their excitement notched up another level as they saw the Renault Clio enter the expansive courtyard. Even though there had been lights on in the house, it was no guarantee that there was anybody at home, but now there most definitely was. They were still a couple of hundred metres away when the car pulled up outside the main entrance.

Tyres screeched and the gravel flew, suggesting the driver was erratic if not downright careless. The car door shot open and a figure climbed out and ran towards the main entrance. One of the back doors opened and a second figure did the same.

The quintet slowed a little but maintained their course. "There's something not right," Zack said. "There's something not right about this."

"Come on," Claire replied. "We've been through the mill tonight. Our heads are all over the place. Whatever their problems are, they're nothing like the ones we've got and all we need is to use a phone for a minute. We need to keep going. We're all out of choices."



Rupert burst through the front door and started towards the stairs but stopped suddenly as his wife came up behind him. They both felt it. Despite the turmoil in their own heads; despite the feeling that every cell in their brains was being jolted by a cattle prod, they both knew it.

"Something's wrong. Something's wrong. Something's wrong, wrong, wrong," Lavender said. She stood with her husband, their arms brushing, and they looked towards the giant double staircase. The same portraits lined the walls that always had. The undusted balustrades appeared just the same as when they had left, just the same as the day before and the day before and the day before that. The carpet, now a little threadbare in places, bore no difference to when they had last placed their feet on it. But it was a

feeling. A feeling that something had changed in between them leaving the house and returning.

They glanced at each other before heading up the stairs. Whatever the problem was, they still needed the pills. The pills were the answer to all the problems.

The pair finally reached the landing and the hackles on the backs of their necks stood to attention as they saw Kevin's clothes just lying there in a pile.

"That's not right. That's not right at all. That's not right. That's not right," Rupert said. It was as if his mind latched on to a thought and became fixated, unable to move on, unable to reason.

Their driving force was still getting to the medication, however. Regardless of what was happening to them, of what was going on in their heads, they understood that the pills were the only way they could stop feeling like this.

Lavender grabbed hold of her husband's arm. "Tablets. Come, must we go." She halted, her lip quivering. The words that had come out of her mouth were not the same ones she'd intended to say. "Get. Get. GET. GET. GEEETTT!" She burst out crying and Rupert placed his hand over hers.

They had been dependent on the medication for so long. Occasionally, they had needed to increase the dose, then a little more and a little more as the odd tick registered. The strength of what they took now was over twelve times more powerful than the one they had begun taking all those years ago, and, subsequently, missing a dose amplified and accelerated the symptoms massively.

Rupert understood what his wife was going through better than anyone. "Come," he said as they stepped over Kevin's clothes and continued to their bedroom.

Pounding feet from an adjacent hallway made them stop and Lavender's hands wrapped around her husband's arm as a costumed figure appeared on the landing, leaping onto the thick top rail of the bannister like a gymnast.

"BEHOLD! I am the Man Bat! I am he. I am the one." He flicked his head back and the pair of giant bat wings shot out. "Today, the world will know what fear is." He launched into the air and the two doctors watched in wide-eyed perplexion as their son seemed to fly gracefully for one, two seconds before upending and plummeting. They rushed to the bannister,

leaning over, watching as he dropped to the tiled floor below like a sack of rocks. There was an almighty thud and they stood in slack-jawed horror as they stared at Ben's body splayed on the chequered surface. His head had snapped back at a right angle. Whatever was left beneath the mask he wore was anyone's guess, but a crimson puddle the size of a child's paddling pool had already formed beneath him.

"NOOO! NOOO! NOOO! NOOO! NOOO!" Lavender's entire body spasmed with torment. Her screams were deafening, erupting like a tsunami siren from depths deep within. She remained clutching the handrail, her nails digging into the wood as, somehow, Rupert found the wherewithal to leave her, to run back down the stairs in the hope there was something he could do for his son, but knowing, in his heart, it was folly. "NOOO! NOOO! NOOO!"

"Ben. Ben, Ben, Ben, Ben, Ben," Rupert whispered with each step. He hit the ground floor, still running, dropping to his knees long before reaching his son then skidding the rest of the way on the pooling blood as if it was some macabre water slide. The warm ooze easily penetrated the thin cotton of his scrubs and the scent of coppery death lay heavy in the air as he beheld his child.

"NOOO! NOOO! NOOO!" Lavender's cries continued to repeat.

Rupert glanced up to see she hadn't moved from the spot. He turned back to his son. The sharp fangs they had warned him about so many times had locked inwards, stapling the mask to his upper lip. He reached out, trying to pull the moulded latex construction from his child's face, but to no avail. He got a better grip and yanked hard; this time, it did come free, the fangs tearing a lump of gory flesh with them.

A gasp left his mouth, inaudible to anyone but himself as his wife's screams continued to echo. Ben's head had cracked open like an easter egg. A jagged section of skull flapped down, revealing brain tissue beneath. It was impossible to see the expression of fear in his son's eyes as they were painted red like the rest of his face.

So much confusion was bounding through Rupert's mind, so many terrible and fantastic thoughts at the same time. So many real and impossible ones. He reached out with his two index fingers and started pushing against the visible section of his son's brain just like a paramedic would pump their hands in rhythm over someone's heart while giving CPR. It was ridiculous. It was crazy. All his training and experience told him that

his son was dead and nothing, nothing at all would bring him back, but there was another part of him that believed this was perfectly natural, perfectly plausible. There was a part of him that was convinced that he would be able to restart Ben's brain like a person's heart could restart.

"It's okay. It's okay, Lavender. I'll bring him back. I'll bring him back to us."



Mitzi stood back with a joyous smile on her face. *I wish they were here to see this. They should have been here to see this. If this was Razzle, they'd have been here. They'd have been here applauding.*

The smile was gone as quickly as it had appeared. One of her crowning achievements and she was the only one around to witness it.

"It's not fair." Her words were those of a little girl who wasn't allowed to play in her older siblings' football game. "It's not fair," she said again. "Not fair, not fair, not fair."

She stood back, folding her arms, and her bottom lip quivered a little. She turned back to her patient and the corners of her mouth curled upwards once more. "Nobody can take this away from me. I did this. I did it. Me, me, me, me, me."

She reached out, gently stroking Ethan's head. "Handsome. So handsome. You and I are going to be doing oomphy doompies all the time when you're better. And you, too, pretty girl." She reached over and stroked Kayla's head, which she had carefully sewn onto Ethan's shoulder. "We're all going to have the best times together. The absolute best times."

The music suddenly stopped and Mitzi turned toward the speakers then the mirror. "Who said you could turn the music off? Nobody said you could turn the music off. Kevin? KEVIN? BLOB! BLOB! TURN THE FUCKING MUSIC BACK ON NOW, YOU CUNTING, FUCK, FUCK, CUNT, FUCK, FUCK, FUUUCCKKK!" She was almost doubled over as she screamed towards the mirror. "TURN IT ON. I won't let you take away my moment. I won't. I won't. I WON'T!"

Her entire body shook with rage and she reached out, grabbing the scalpel from the instrument trolley and running towards the double doors.



The grand entrance doors to the mansion were still open a crack as the five of them entered the courtyard. The sound of a woman screaming made them all believe that a similar fate had befallen her as their friends and Zack sped up a couple of steps before skidding to a halt by the side of the Renault Clio. The doors were ajar and it only took him a couple of beats to recognise his friend's unconscious body in the back seat. The others came to an abrupt halt behind him and they all stared at Amanda. Claire took a tentative step forward, then another, placing her hand on the teenager's neck.

"She's breathing. She's still breathing."

"We need to get out of here. We need to get out of here now," Natalie said.

Claire pulled back and looked towards the open driver's side. "It's a push-button start, but you still need keys or a key fob to get it to work."

"What are you all talking about?" Zack asked. "We can't go anywhere without Kayla and Ethan. They could be in there."

"Zack, we don't know who or what is in there. There could be a dozen people for all we know, all as crazy as the ones we've already come across. I mean, listen, for Christ's sake. Does that sound normal to you?"

The fevered screams from beyond the doors continued to bleed out into the courtyard. "Sh-she could be in trouble. They might have found Amanda on the road and they might have brought her back here to...."

"To what, Zack?" Millie asked, taking over.

"It doesn't matter. Whatever the reason, it's a moot point, isn't it? We don't have the keys. We can't take the car. We're going to have to go in there. At the very least, there'll be a phone. We can call someone."

"Are you hearing what I'm hearing? Whatever's going on in there sounds like it belongs in the seventh level of hell. You want us to just head in and ask to use their phone?"

Zack reached around to the belt at the back of his jeans and pulled out the machete. "We're not going to ask anything. We're going to tell."

"Look at this," Javed said. The interior dome light was still on as a result of the doors remaining open and he had taken it upon himself to search the vehicle in the dim hope that he might find keys or something to help them. What he found, though, sent a shudder of fear through him. He revealed the tyre iron that he'd pulled out from under the driver's seat and

held it in the periphery of the internal light. The still-wet blood dripped onto the upholstery as he angled it from side to side.

“Oh shit! Oh fuck!” Millie cried. “Whose blood is that? Are these the people who took Kayla and Ethan?”

Silence hung between them for a moment as they all stood there staring at Javed’s discovery. “That fucking does it,” Zack said eventually. “That fucking does it right there. I’m going in. I’m going in and I’m going to fuck these freaks up.”



Razzle rolled onto his side. His eyes were still closed for the moment, but there was a sound somewhere in the distance that was demanding he wake. A sharp and sudden pain caused his lids to flick open and, for a few seconds, he didn’t know where he was. Then memories started to come back, one at a time. A few more seconds passed before he was all caught up.

Now there was something else he had to figure out. What was the sound? Slowly, his befuddled head kicked into gear.

“NOOO! NOOO! NOOO!”

He wasn’t sure how many times he’d heard the screamed word since he’d been dragged back to consciousness. It was a familiar cry. He’d heard many of his patients scream that word before he’d operated on them, but there was something different about this.

He finally pushed himself up from the floor and climbed to his feet. He looked at the surrounding mess and then raised his fingers to his face and head to discover that the bloody stains that decorated the carpet were what he’d contributed. He staggered a little at first as he placed one foot in front of the other in pursuit of the source of the noise.

He reached the outer door to his parents’ room and stepped onto the landing to see his mother leaning over the handrail of the bannister at the far end. She was the one screaming.

“Mummy. Mummy. MUMMY!” he called out, but she didn’t even raise her eyes. She was deaf to his words, deaf and blind to everything beyond her focus. He took two steps forward and looked down to see his brother dressed as the Man Bat, clearly dead in a massive pool of his own blood. Right by his side was his father, his two index fingers extended, prodding something in rhythm. From his angle of view, Razzle couldn’t make out

what and his grogginess prevented him from processing any emotional impact from the scene for the moment; so, instead, he started along the landing like a confused tourist at an exhibition. He paused by his mother as she continued to scream, still clearly not noticing him despite him being right next to her.

He carried on across the landing and down the stairs, one at a time, as slowly his senses started to return. *Ben's dead. Ben's dead. Ben's dead.*

In their earlier years, he, Ben, Oli and Mitzi had always been as thick as thieves. Closer siblings you'd struggle to find. There was an unbreakable bond between them, one that didn't exist with Kevin despite them having to pretend it did.

Ben was always so sweet. He was. He was the big dreamer. They were all intelligent and gifted in ways the school struggled to keep up with. Ben was an amazing artist, an incredible creator. Where Razzle and Mitzi gained their artistic freedom in the operating room, Ben was able to find his in clay and latex, wood and metal, creating monstrous masks and costumes from scratch as well as paying homage to classics and occasionally improving them with his own designs. He was a visionary in some ways, and although Razzle loved him, there had always been a part of him that was jealous of his abilities and that made him hate Ben too.

He continued slowly down the steps, his eyes focusing on his father, fascinated and confused by his actions in equal measure. He finally reached the ground floor and walked up to the edge of the crimson lake.

"Daddy? Daddy? Daddy?" Again, his words fell on deaf ears as his father just carried on. He took another step forward, his bare feet splashing in the still-warm blood. Finally, he was close enough to hear the mumbled words over the sound of his mother's screams.

"I'll bring him back. I'll bring him back to us. I'll bring him back. I'll bring him back to us."

Razzle watched for a moment as his father pumped his fingers in rhythm against the exposed section of his brother's brain. A smile curled up the corner of his lips. The smile turned to a grin; then a huff of laughter rose from his chest, then another and another, until he started guffawing uncontrollably. He started to stamp around in the puddle of blood, skidding a little, occasionally, and clapping his hands. "Bring him back. Bring him back," he said between hoots of laughter.

Rupert finally turned towards him, not halting his action but casting his eyes to his other son nonetheless. He watched as the blood splashed and splattered around Razzle's feet. He even felt some of it coat his cheeks and the ingrained expression of hurt and sadness that seemed to be permanently etched on his face finally cracked.

He turned back to Ben and watched as his two index fingers continued to pulse against the grey matter of his brain. Suddenly, the words he'd been saying, the words Razzle was now shouting in between bouts of hysterical laughter, seemed ridiculous. Hilarious even. He started laughing too. He was deaf to his wife's agonised screams as he looked at Razzle once more.

"Bring him back. Bring him back." Rupert joined in with his son's chant, rising to his feet and starting to stamp around in the pool of blood as well. "Bring him back. Bring him back," he laughed, looping arms with his son as they cavorted. "Bring him back. Bring him back. Bring him back."

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 16

Mitzi burst through the control room doors ready to kill. The scalpel was extended and she was seething. “TURN THE FUCKING MUSIC BACK ON!” she shouted at the top of her voice. “I SAID TUR—” The words faltered in her mouth as Kevin swivelled around in his chair. He was completely naked. “What—”

“Things are happening. Things are happening.”

“I can see your John Thomas,” was all Mitzi could think of saying. “Mummy told me none of you boys should ever show me your John Thomases and if you did, I had to tell her.”

“Things are happening. Things are happening,” he replied with more urgency this time.

Her extended hand wavered a moment as she remained completely taken aback by the grossness of what she was witnessing. “You should cover. You should cover up. You’re going to get into lots of trouble for this. Lots of trouble, Kevin.”

He jumped to his feet and Mitzi took a couple of steps back. She had always been closer to the other siblings, never Kevin. Even though he was her brother and she loved him, there was always something about him that repelled her; even before he put on all the weight. There was something unnatural about the way he looked at her. And despite her having a scalpel, she felt unnerved, threatened even, by his frame looming over her.

“Mitzi,” he said, pointing at the screens. “Something’s happening.”

Paranoia and panic rose in equal measure within Mitzi and she felt sure that his words were nothing more than a subterfuge to catch her off guard, but something in his expression forced her to glance towards the screens and her eyes froze on them for a second before turning back to him. Her hand tightened around the scalpel and she fidgeted from foot to foot, still not sure if it was some kind of trap, but then, as Kevin turned back to the monitors himself, she relaxed a little and finally exhaled.

She swallowed her revulsion for a moment. His massive, pale, flapping body jiggled in front of several of the monitors as he leaned forward and brought another set of images up, but then her focus returned to the screens.

“Who are those people?” she finally asked, staring towards a group next to an equally unfamiliar Renault Clio that had been left abandoned in the courtyard.

“Something’s happening,” he said again.

Mitzi, still a little tense, edged forward to get a clearer look. “That’s Oli’s machete. He’s got Oli’s machete. No, no, no. He can’t have Oli’s machete. He can’t have Oli’s machete. Oli’s the only one who can have Oli’s machete. That’s how we know it’s Oli’s because Oli has it. No, no, no.”

“We have to protect the family.”

These were words that her father had said on countless occasions. Everything he and Lavender did was to protect the family, nurture them. They were his words that Kevin used now, and despite their differences, despite the fact that she hated Kevin, *Hate*; despite the fact that he scared her more than a little too, he was right.

“The family’s everything.” She now found herself using her mother’s words. *The family is everything*. Yes. It was a complicated dynamic. Yes, they weren’t like normal families. *What is normal anyway?* But they were all they had. And yes, sometimes she hated all of them. *Hate. Hate. Hate*. But she couldn’t let harm come to them from outsiders. *No, no, no, no. The family is everything*.



Ethan lay on the table. For the moment, he couldn’t open his eyes. He wasn’t sure what the magic potion the mad woman had given him was, but it wasn’t like any anaesthetic he’d had before. It acted much faster. He felt like he did when he was first coming around after being taken from the forest. They’d obviously used the same stuff on him again.

He couldn’t move. He couldn’t feel anything. His body was numb. His senses were numb. Slowly, he started to take things in. *The music. Where was the music?*

It had played an almost constant accompaniment while he had been trapped in the operating theatre, but now it had gone off. With great effort,

he tried to open his eyes. It felt as though they had been welded shut, but he persevered, and eventually light surrounded him. His head was lolled to the side a little and he tried to move but couldn't. Then he remembered what he would see if he managed to look across towards the other operating table and felt a moment's gratitude.

Kayla. He still couldn't believe she was dead. He couldn't believe what the crazy woman had done. Even when she had raised the bone saw up to his friend's neck, he didn't think she'd go through with it; he didn't think she'd actually use it, but then it had begun.

Blood had sprayed on his face. Some had even gone in his mouth. Sadness and guilt overwhelmed him for a second as he realised he had swallowed her lifeblood, the thing that kept her alive. The thought was gone again just as quickly. Lots of strange thoughts were flashing into his head as he continued his groggy journey into wakefulness.

He forced his eyes open a little more and tried hard to pull against the restraints as he had been doing more or less since waking the last time. For the time being, however, he still had no control over his limbs and muscles. His eyelids were open and that it was all.

Then a chilling thought suddenly seized him and, despite his virtual paralysis, goosebumps rippled up and down his body.

If she put me out, if she gave me the anaesthetic, what did she do to me? Goosebumps formed on his goosebumps.

No. Jesus, no. No. Adrenaline began to surge through his system as his fear notched up a level, which he didn't actually believe was possible. His fingers started to twitch, then his hands. He could feel his heart pounding faster, then faster still. He could almost hear it.

Regardless of the fogginess he was feeling, he tried to focus and used every gram of strength he could muster to move his neck. At first, nothing happened. The twitching in his fingers had extended to his wrists, and he could feel his toes moving a little too now. But his neck wouldn't budge.

He held his breath and a growl of determination left the back of his throat as he slowly turned. Slowly, slowly, slowly. With each micro degree of movement more dread crept through him as a blurred object materialised in his field of vision. His cheek made contact with it, but his senses were still too dulled to feel the cold skin against his own warm flesh. But as his eyes finally focused on the contours of Kayla's decapitated head, his growl turned into a whimper.

He tried to shift, to pull back, and he managed to move ever so slightly, but her head moved too. *She did it. She attached Kayla's head to my body. The crazy bitch did it.* The whimper became something else. It started as a nasal drone but built in force and volume. Finally, it channelled into his mouth and then out of his lips. "Aagghh," quiet and muted at first. "Aagghh." Gradually, it grew into something else, then something else, until the sound exploded from his mouth with the force of a hundred guitar amps. "AAARRRGGGHHH! HELP ME! SOMEBODY FUCKING HELP ME! HELP ME! HELP ME!"



It became clear very quickly that Zack and Javed had no intention of going anywhere without trying to find the rest of their friends. One was armed with a machete, the other a tyre iron. They walked side by side towards the still-open main entrance doors as if they were gunfighters heading to the O.K. Corral.

Amanda was still out cold and as much as they didn't want to leave her, she was the lucky one at that moment. She didn't have to face what might lie beyond the doors.

Claire, Millie, and Natalie followed the two boys; none of them were sure of the wisdom of the decision to enter the house, but they did not know what else to do. Millie held the club Zack had discarded for his new weapon. The other two had searched around for anything else that could be used, but the only things they found were rocks on the ground.

"NOOO! NOOO! NOOO!" The woman's scream had not diminished in volume ever since it had begun and it seeped out through the crack in the door, the sound spreading in the courtyard like blue ink in water.

"What's the plan then?" Javed asked as they took up their positions on either side of the entrance, still not looking in and not allowing anyone inside to see them.

"To be honest, I didn't think I'd get this far without bricking it and running in the opposite direction," Zack replied.

"So it's not just me, then."

"Screw this," Claire said. "I'm dead anyway." She grabbed the tyre iron from Javed's hand and pushed the door open wider, leading the entry into the mansion.

She'd never been in a fight in her life, but, as she admitted, she was going to die, and there wasn't anything she wouldn't do for these kids, so why not go out in a blaze of glory?

She had her weapon raised, ready to deal with whatever she had to, but as she entered, her mouth dropped open and she just stood there as she watched two men, one older, one much younger, both dressed in scrubs, both with crimson-painted faces, their arms looped while they danced in the blood of a costumed figure who had clearly taken a fall from the landing above.

An older woman was leaning over the bannister on the upper floor screaming the word "no" over and over again. They were completely oblivious to Claire's entry and as she felt the others join her in the sprawling foyer, she sensed them sharing her horror and disbelief at the sight.

The seconds dragged on and on and still Claire and the rest of the small group remained unnoticed; still the woman howled and the men danced.

"What should we do?" she whispered.

The incessant screaming from the landing suddenly stopped and the interlopers all looked up. The two dancing figures came to a skidding halt in the pooling blood, too, and they raised their eyes as well.

"You did this. You did this to my baby," the woman said, pointing towards the doorway. "YOU DID THIS!" she growled and suddenly disappeared from view.

A tall side door to the foyer swung open and the naked Kevin carrying a double-barrelled shotgun burst through, closely followed by Mitzi, still in her stripper nurse outfit.

"What the fuck?" Zack asked before a deafening boom made the whole place shake.

"You got her. You got her, Kevin. The family. Got to protect the family," the nurse said excitedly as Millie staggered forward before falling to the ground.

Her four friends just looked on in horror, mesmerised by the insane play being acted out in front of them. It was only when the naked behemoth raised the shotgun again that Zack and Javed whipped into action. They turned, each grabbing the arm of one of their friends and running towards the gap in the still-open door.

BOOM! They were out in the cool night air before the sound of exploding wood raced to join them.

“Millie. We can’t leave Millie,” Claire said, allowing herself to be dragged along despite her brain protesting.

“Miss T. We’re all going to end up like Millie if we don’t get out of here.”

“Amanda. We can’t leave Amanda,” she replied as they ran past the Renault Clio back towards the shadowy fields. Two loud echoing clicks reverberated around the grounds and a dozen display lights lit the courtyard and surrounding lawns, casting their fleeing shadows across the grass.

BOOM! BOOM! Two more shotgun cracks rumbled and Natalie let out a small whimper of fear. “Don’t worry, Nat. Those things don’t have a great range.” He knew that first-hand. He knew that from his early days on the periphery of gangland. One of his friends had acquired a sawn-off shotgun. It was going cheaper than cheap. It was going free, in fact. It had been used in an armed robbery and he knew where it had been dumped. Zack even got to hold it, to pull the trigger. “The faster we run the less chance they have of hitting us.”

“Oh, shit. Oh shit,” Javed said as a tall figure loomed ahead in their direction of travel. “It’s the fucking psycho with the machete.”

“Yeah,” Zack said, releasing Claire’s arm. “Except I’ve got his machete now, haven’t I?”



Lavender’s head was like a 3D kaleidoscope. For the most part, confusion and heartache reigned, but there was one thought that remained clear, one thought that might help her husband, her children back to some kind of reality, however twisted that reality was.

The tablets.

She had left the landing and run to her bedroom as the repeated booms from the shotgun cracked behind her. Then she had stopped like a DVD on pause. Although the urgency of the situation demanded action and decisiveness above all else, she was unable to do anything but stare at the small secret enclave, which was obviously not so secret anymore. A broken drawer lay in pieces on the floor; empty packets and bottles suggested any

hope of finding the tablets that they so desperately needed right now was non-existent.

She finally broke her trance and took one step, then another in the hope that the compartment with the emergency supply was still intact, although knowing in her heart it wouldn't be. She bent down, looking into the gap where the drawer had been to see emptiness beyond the rear of the chest of drawers. Not a single pill remained. She followed the trail of packets to the adjoining bathroom and the telltale white powder on the toilet seat filled in any blanks that were left in the story.

"It's all over. It's all over." Tears filled her eyes and started running down her face as laughter rose deep from within. Her son lay dead and the family was under attack, but a huge, immeasurable relief filled her. No more pretending, no more being someone she wasn't. She could finally be herself. They could all finally be themselves.



Oli stood there, puffing out his chest. The group was closing in fast, but he wasn't scared. Why would he be scared of these mere mortals? He was something else entirely, a different breed. He didn't have his machete, but he had fashioned a snapped branch into a spear. He held it in both his hands and it empowered him.

His entire body pulsed as adrenaline surged through his veins. He had escaped the constraints they had used to bind him. He had found his mask that they had discarded like litter. He had then torn through the forest on the hunt once more. He was better than them. He was stronger than them. He could feel himself becoming the man he knew he was destined to be. *Tonight. Tonight.*

In the background, he could see figures at the door watching on as the group escaped.

There are only four of them now. They're running fast. They're the ones who're scared, not me. Not me. I'm never scared. Me and Ben are never scared of anything. Anger suddenly heated his blood at the thought of his brother.

This is his fault. Him and that costume. Him and that stupid costume. Always with the costumes.

I hate him. Idiot. He was the reason these people got the drop on me. He's the reason for everything bad. He. Him. Him, him, him. Never me. I'm just the one who has to mop up afterwards.

He allowed the anger to flow like blood itself, heating him, charging him like a battery. His fingers tightened around the spear as the group got closer. The sound of his breathing echoed in the confines of the mask. He'd felt it on the ground next to him when he'd finally escaped the restraints. He felt energised again when he put it on.

He loved everything about it, but he particularly loved the sound of his breathing. It made him feel strong, menacing, dark, powerful, like a god. In, out. In, out. In, out. *Not human. More than human.*

The escapees continued towards him rather than diverting. The ground lights shone from the perimeter of the lawns and they were nothing but silhouettes as they approached, but he had studied them for long enough in the glow of their phone lights. He had taken mental pictures of their faces, locking them away in the photo album of his mind. He knew which one he wanted as his pet. He'd make her last this time. No mistakes. If he was careful, really careful, he could keep her forever.

So much fun. So much fun.

The pounding feet became louder, jostling for attention with the sound of his own respiration. *They'll talk about this night forever. The night that group nearly got away from us. The night Oli saved the family.*

He smiled as the young black man, the one who had faced up to him, broke away from the others. He charged at Oli, but the smile only widened. *You don't know who I am. You don't understand what I am becoming.*

Oli stepped forward with breakneck speed, thrusting the spear towards his would-be attacker's chest. He felt it being pulled as his target sidestepped and grabbed the shaft of the weapon.

"Wah!" The sound was almost comical as it came out of his lips, not the sound of a powerful man or a god but the sound of a clumsy child. Anger flared in him as he stumbled forward, but it was only fleeting.

"Fucker," the voice of his assailant hissed.

The cold night air charged at his belly like an icy bull as he felt his beloved machete tear through his clothing, then his flesh, slicing deep into his gut before being twisted and dragged back out.

It took a few seconds for the pain to catch up with him, but when it did, it was as if he'd been harpooned by the devil's own trident. He let go of the

spear and brought his hands up to his middle as hot blood pumped through his entwined fingers.

His eyes filled with tears as he looked beyond his attacker to the open doorway in the distance. *Mummy. Daddy. How can this be happening?* He dropped to his knees then face down onto the soaking grass. *This wasn't meant to happen.* An image of Ben filled his head. *Your fault. This is your fault. YOUR FAULT. YOUR FAULT. I HATE YOU. I HATE YOU. I HATE—* Darkness.

"Jesus," Claire cried, staring down at the fallen figure as the blue moonlight caressed his outline. The machete had gone right through and a patch on his back glistened. "Is he dead?"

Zack kicked his victim's head. There was no response, no pained shout, nothing. "Pretty much."

"Jesus," she said again. "We need to get out of here. We need to get a signal. This is crazy. This is so crazy. We need to—"

"I'm going back to the house."

"What? No. You can't."

"Listen, Miss T. They've got Amanda down there and they've probably got the others too. They've fucking killed Millie, and if we go into those woods, it's only a matter of time before they find us. We don't know how many cameras they've got dotted around, but I'm pretty certain that's how they knew we were out on that road in the first place. Even if we do get a signal it could be too late for the others by that time. I'm going back and I'm going to see if I can fuck things up for them at the very least."

"What do you mean?"

"I mean give them something to think about beyond us."

"I'll come with you," Javed said, not really wanting to but feeling it was the right thing.

"Nah. I need you with Miss T and Nat."

"I'm coming with you then," Natalie said.

Zack thought for a moment. *She was pretty handy with those fucking rocks.* "Okay. But we need to go now. We need to go before they can get organised again," he said, staring towards the doorway as four silhouettes remained outside. "We'll head into the forest as if we're doing a runner then circle round. Javed," he said, turning to his friend. "Keep an eye out for cameras. Keep an eye out for those fuckers, too, in case this doesn't go how I want it to. Now, come on."

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 17

Kevin loaded two more shells and fired again, then again at the escaping figures. “You’re wasting them. You’re wasting them,” Mitzi said. “You can’t hit them from this distance.”

“That was Oli. That was Oli they killed,” Kevin said, breaking the shotgun and loading two more shells.

“We don’t know that,” Rupert replied.

“It was his mask.”

“There’s no possible way to tell from this distance.”

“We should go out and see.” They all turned to discover Lavender standing there. She’d changed out of her scrubs, washed her face and put on a black dress. It was clear she’d been crying. She’d painted a lipstick clown smile on her face to take attention away from the tear streaks and her sad eyes. The children didn’t respond to her strange appearance, but something jarred within Rupert.

A moment of clarity struck him and he turned towards the broken body of Ben. He looked at the red-streaked footprints tracing a line from the pooled blood to where he was now standing.

“The tablets. We must get the tablets.” The thought came to him like a lifeline being lowered into a ravine. *The tablets will make sense of this mess.*

“They’re gone. All gone,” Lavender said. “And I, for one, couldn’t be happier.” She burst out crying.

Losing control. I’m losing control, Rupert thought, looking over towards the body of his son once more then staring back out into the night at the shadowy figure that lay on the ground a few hundred feet away.

BOOM!

Another blast from the shotgun jolted him. “Kevin. Stop that. I need you to go back to the control room. I need you to—” *Focus. I can’t focus. Everything’s happening too quickly. I need clarity. I need clarity. I need—*

He reached out, grabbing his wife's hand and launching into a run towards the side door.

"We must go to Oli. We need to go to Oli," she protested.

Rupert did his best not to listen. His head was pounding as he tried to maintain his concentration despite a thousand thoughts, a thousand voices telling him otherwise. He ran down the steps, still grasping his wife's hand. There was friction. It was obvious she wanted to head in the other direction. She wanted to go to Oli, but this was the one last thing that might give them a chance.

Their whole world was collapsing around them. If he didn't act, if he couldn't escape the building cyclone of confusion taking over his thoughts, then it would all be over. They needed to capture or kill those people. If they got to an area with a phone signal, if they flagged down a passing vehicle, it would all be over.

All be over.

He continued to drag Lavender through the short underground tunnel, past the operating theatre, and past Kevin's control room to the lab. He burst through the doors and his heart lifted ever so slightly to see that all the equipment was as it should be. They could manufacture more pills, but that would take time, and that wasn't what he'd come here for. When they were designing the medication for their family, they had experimented with commercially available antipsychotics, ADHD meds, and even antidepressants. They had used them in cocktails to try to counter some of the more extreme symptoms that firstly their children and then they began to suffer. As time went on, they became less and less effective, but they were something. They were something and, right now, they had nothing. *Nothing. Nothing. Nothing.*

"We'll need to operate on Ben and Oli as quickly as possible," said Lavender. "I don't know why you've brought me down here. Time is of the essence." She stared at her husband and he stared back. The clown smile painted on her face was a reminder of just how close they both were to the point of no return. He could feel permanent withdrawal from any semblance of order knocking on the door to his head, ready to enter and take up residence at any moment.

"Knock. Knock. Knock."

"What did you say?" Lavender asked.

"Nothing." He regarded her with confusion.

“You said knock, knock, knock. Is it the start of a joke?” she asked excitedly, the sadness from a moment before vanishing in an instant.

He had no recollection of saying those words and that scared him even more. He looked down at his feet to see his pumps and the bottom of his scrubs covered in blood. *That’s my son’s blood. That’s Ben’s blood.* Another jolt of clarity through the ever-expanding cloud of confusion seized him and he opened the cabinet with the remaining meds, all now long past their use-by dates, but extreme situations called for extreme measures and his family had never been in a situation more extreme than this.

“Take these,” he ordered, tapping two pills out of one bottle, four out of another, pressing two more bright pink tablets out of a blister pack, another pair of capsules from a box.

“I don’t want to,” Lavender replied. “I want to hear your joke.”

“Take them, Lavender.”

She grabbed them in her hand. “No,” she replied, throwing them on the floor. “Not until I hear your joke. You started it, now you’ve got to finish it. Knock, knock, knock. I mean, it should be just knock, knock, but I’m not going to be pedantic, not over something like this.”

Rupert looked at the tablets in his own hand and threw them into his mouth, tipping his head back and wincing as one of them caught in the back of his throat. He tapped out some more for his wife. “Knock, knock, knock,” he finally said.

“Who’s there?” she asked, clapping and making the lipstick-painted smile on her face curve to new peaks.

“Our two dead children.”

“Our two dead children who?”

“Our two dead children who will have died for nothing if we don’t take control of this situation right now.”

The smile vanished from her face. “Well. I’m sorry, but I just don’t think that’s very funny. It’s actually in quite poor taste.”

“Take the tablets, Lavender.”

“I shan’t and you can’t make me,” she replied, turning her head away like a petulant child.

“Take them!”

“No.” She folded her arms.

“Take them,” he roared this time, forcing her back onto a nearby desk. Papers, stationery and trays went flying as she hit the hard surface with a

thud.

“Get off me. GET OFF ME!” she screamed as he held her down, forcing the fingers of his left hand into her mouth, levering her jaws wider as he emptied the contents of his right hand down her throat. She continued to fight, lashing out, but he held firm even when her fist made contact with his face. She sputtered as the pills rested in the back of her dry throat. She bit down hard, trapping the index and middle fingers of his left hand between her teeth.

“NAAAGGGHHH!” Rupert screamed in agony but kept his fingers there anyway, trying to physically push the tablets down his wife’s throat. He kept screaming and screaming, the volume of his pain edging up measurably by the second. Blood began to pour, trickling down the back of Lavender’s throat, lubricating the dry tablets.

She gagged as a reflex, then again, and the tablets were gone, but rather than releasing her husband, she bit down even harder, not realising the pain was helping him focus. It was taking his mind away from the plethora of confused thoughts and ideas spinning and twirling inside his brain like a tornado of psychosis.

Eventually, she coughed and her jaws unlocked for a second, releasing him. He pulled back his hand and beneath the thick layer of torn flesh, he could see bone. He staggered across to another cupboard, pulling it open, grabbing strips of gauze, ripping the plastic away with his teeth and wrapping them tightly around his bloody digits.

“I hate you. I HATE YOU!” Lavender cried, leaping back up from the desk. “You have no right. No right.”

Some of the pills were fast acting, some would take longer to begin working, but within a few minutes they would hopefully start feeling the effects. It was doubtful that either of them would be one hundred percent in charge of their minds or their emotions as a result, but they would be able to function with some level of reason. They would be able to form a plan to marshal the remainder of their children.

Notes. I need my notes. My notes will tell me what combinations used to work on them best. If we can get through tonight, we can make more of the proper meds, but it’s all about getting through tonight.

Lavender slumped down into a chair and started crying again. Rupert didn’t know if it was because of his actions or if it was down to the events of the evening, but he extended a bottle of water as a peace offering.

“Here,” he said. She stared at it for a moment. Blood had dribbled over her lips, making it seem as though the lipstick had extended in a line down to her chin. She eventually took the bottle, unscrewing the top and gulping several mouthfuls as more tears rolled down her cheeks.

“Ben and Oli,” she said.

“Yes.” His mind was still awash with a thousand thoughts, but those two names gave him another injection of focus.

“We need to—”

Everything went black.



Natalie and Zack staggered back from the electricity meter box as the basketball-sized rock they had used to smash the incoming connection dropped to the ground like a lead weight. Natalie had been more than a little nervous when Zack had suggested sabotaging the supply to the house. She had visions of getting electrocuted and their attempted rescue of their friends ending up as nothing more than a double suicide. But Zack had done this before. Well, not quite. He had been part of a gang that had pulled off a robbery in London and had done this.

There was an explosion of sparks and even a couple of flames before the lights all over the house flicked off. The two teenagers pulled back a little further. The smell of melted plastic was strong in the air, and even though Zack had been present when his former friends had done this, he wasn't particularly au fait with how it worked. He didn't know what could potentially happen, whether he would get electrocuted if he came into contact with anything inside the box. He didn't know much at all, really, and if this wasn't a full-on emergency, he wouldn't have even dreamed of trying something so off-the-charts dangerous. But this was an emergency. A big one. Lives were at stake ... literally.

“Okay,” Natalie said. “I think I might have just peed myself, but at least that worked.”

“Yeah. There was a part of me that thought those flames were going to catch for a second.”

“I thought you'd done this before.”

“Well, yeah. But I can't say I had any confidence in it working back then either. The guy who came up with the idea was a bit of a nutter. None

of us understood how he'd stayed alive as long as he had."

"You might have wanted to share that little nugget of information before I risked my life."

Zack shrugged. "We're still here, aren't we?"

"So, what now?"

"Now we try to find our friends."



"Look, I know you and Zack have got this whole big brother thing going on with me, thinking that you've got to protect me, but we don't have the luxury of hiding out in the woods just hoping things are going to turn out alright. They've just killed Millie," Claire said, her friend's name quivering a little in her throat. She hadn't had time to process the information. She hadn't had time to process much at all other than the fact that she was just about as scared as she'd ever been in her life.

The lights in the house and grounds had gone off just seconds before and although Zack hadn't made his plans known, if indeed he had any plans at all, there was little doubt it was he and Natalie who were responsible for the outage.

"I wasn't intending for us to hide out in the forest. I think we should try to get back to the road and—"

"And what, Javed? If they don't come after us, and that's a big if, it might take us an hour, two even, before we can get a signal or help. And right now, we think we're in a safe spot. We haven't seen any cameras, but we don't know. We don't know if—"

"Cameras or not, they haven't got any power. They'll need monitors to see what's on the cameras."

"Okay, say that's the case. Say we get out of the forest without getting stopped and make it back to the road. What do you think happens to Zack, Natalie and the others between now and us returning with help?"

The air left Javed's lungs in a long, deep sigh. He had wanted to go with Zack. He had wanted to find his friends. There was a part of him that was scared. He hadn't got Zack's dark past. He grew up in a nice house in a middle-class suburb. He'd only ever had a fight once in his life and that was with some racist little shit who'd tried picking on his sister. He'd won, but there was a world of difference between braying the crap out of some

bigoted coward and going up against a family of raving lunatics. “So, what do you think we should do?”

She was about to reply but stopped just as suddenly as the tall, rotund naked man with a shotgun appeared out of the double doors.



“What are you doing?” Mitzi asked as she followed Kevin out into the moonlight. She desperately wanted to get back to her project. Mitzi’s life had been a lonely one since giving up school.

She had always played second fiddle to her brothers, never having anything of her own, but now she did. She’d never be alone again. The handsome boy and the pretty girl would belong to her forever. And they weren’t friends right now, but that would change. Mitzi was likeable. *I’m likeable*. The teachers said so. It was even on her report card once.

Miranda is a likeable girl but really needs to try harder when it comes to expanding her social group and mixing with others.

I’m likeable. And I won’t need to mix with anyone now I’ve got those two.

Kevin stood there for a moment. The cool night air surrounded his body and he lifted his face to the sky, breathing in deeply. His blood was starting to cool rather than boil in his veins. The lights had gone out and now everybody would be looking to him. He was the one who fixed things. He was the one who’d have to speak to the power company in the morning. He was the one they would all depend upon to make this problem go away.

“I need to fire up the generator,” he said. “You come with me.”

“I don’t take orders from you, not you. After tonight, I don’t take orders from anyone, but especially not you.”

He spun around faster than she thought was possible for a person of his size. He grabbed her wrist and pushed her against the wall, pressing his clammy naked body against her. She let out a cry of revulsion as his flabby white breast pinned her face against the cold stone. His weight and strength were immeasurable at the side of hers. She flinched and tried to push him away, but it was impossible.

“You’ll do as I say. From now on, you will do exactly as I say.”

Mitzi continued to push and struggle, but it was no good. It was like she’d become trapped beneath a giant, sweaty albino elephant. “Get off me.

Get off me,” she sobbed. *I’ll never be free. I’ll never be free from people giving me orders. Mummy, Daddy, Razzle. At least the others are gone.* It was a sad admission to make, but she valued her freedom more than she valued the lives of her two brothers. She loved Ben and Oli. But they treated her like the others did sometimes and that made her hate them too. But not as much as she hated Kevin. She didn’t hate anyone as much as she hated Kevin.

I need to get back to the operating room and Charlie. She’d been thinking about this all night, but she’d finally decided Charlie was a good name for her creation. Charlie could be a boy’s name or a girl’s name, and they were both, so it was perfect. *When we’re friends, when they really get to know me, they’ll like me, and they won’t let anyone bully me or threaten me anymore.*

Kevin pulled back and Mitzi sunk down the wall a little before he grabbed her wrist. “Come on. We’re going to the generator shed.”

CHAPTER 18

The mansion seemed much bigger when they were up close to it than it had from back in the woods. It was only as they followed the perimeter of the building in the darkness that they realised how many rooms there were.

“If Ethan and Kayla are in there, it’s going to take us forever to find them. Especially in the dark,” Natalie said.

“Yeah. But we needed to knock the power out. With those cameras, they’d pick Javed and Miss T up, and that would be it,” Zack replied.

“Do you think we’re going to get out of this?”

“What, you and me?”

“All of us.”

“I dunno. They’ve already killed Millie and Amanda looks like she’s fucked up three ways from Sunday already. I....”

“You what?”

“I don’t know about Kayla and Ethan either. They could be dead already.”

There was a pause before Natalie spoke again. “So why not get out of here? We’ve cut the power; they can’t see us on the cameras anymore. Why not follow the road back out through the woods and just run as fast as we can, the two of us? We’re pretty fit. We can cover ground a lot faster if it’s just the two of us, and then we can get a signal and get help.”

“The same reason as before, Nat. I can’t leave Ethan and Kayla behind with these crazy bastards without knowing one way or the other. Now come on.”

They’d worked their way around to the left of the property, well away from the main entrance door and in a part of the building where no lights had been on before they cut the power. Zack took the rock that Natalie still clutched firmly and hammered it against a small window. There was a loud tinkling of glass and they both jumped back as jagged shards pirouetted in

the moonlight and fell to the ground. He cleared the rest of the frame using the rock then handed it back to her.

The sill was roughly neck height and he let out a grunt of effort as he pulled himself up. There was a thud as he landed on the other side, and a second later, he was extending his hand out of the gap to help Natalie. She took it gratefully, and once she was inside, they both stood taking in their surroundings, getting used to the dark interior.

“Looks like an office or something,” Natalie said, retrieving her phone and flicking the torch on. There was a computer on a desk and several framed photos next to it. She panned the torch from one to the next. The first was of five babies, all dressed alike, all sleeping side by side. The next was of toddlers, all looking equally cute, playing on a lawn. Then five schoolchildren, five teenagers, five adults. With each picture, a transformation seemed to take place. The differences between them – height, demeanour, and skin tone – seemed more noticeable, more exaggerated.

Zack pulled the machete from his belt and held it tightly in his fist. “Listen,” he said, nudging his friend to get her attention. “This place is probably going to be a maze, but remember your way back to this office. If anything happens to me. Run. Run and don’t look back.”

She nodded. “This is really mad, y’know that.”

“Tell me something that hasn’t been tonight.”

Natalie clutched the rock in her hand and gulped. “Let’s do this.”



When the lights had gone out, a crushing weight of sadness had suddenly fallen over Razzle. While Kevin and Mitzi headed towards the backup generator and his parents were God only knew where, he had climbed the staircase.

The blue glow from outside still lit the foyer and it provided him with enough illumination to trace his way up the steps. His hand slid over the smooth mahogany bannister as he ascended.

He couldn’t ever remember feeling this morose before and he wasn’t quite sure what had prompted it now. He left the landing and walked down the black hallway, reaching out, letting his fingers touch the walls until he reached the open door of his brothers’ room. *Ben and Oli. Oli and Ben.*

A few minutes before, he had been dancing in Ben's blood. Not because he was happy he was dead but because ... *I don't know why*. The truth was Razzle didn't know why he did a lot of the things he did, and at this moment, he felt less in charge of his emotions and actions than he ever had.

Normally, he would have taken his pills by now, they all would. Normally, his head would be experiencing minimal confusion, for him anyway. His mood would be level, as level as his moods ever got, and he would have some degree of focus for whichever task he was undertaking at the time.

There's something not right.

He brought his hand up to his face, where Kevin had hit him multiple times. He felt the bulges and cuts beneath his fingertips. *I fucking hate Kevin.*

But that isn't it. That's not what's causing this.

The entire room was bathed in moonlight and he remained in the entrance for a moment.

Razzle walked up to Ben's bed and sat down beside the werewolf head that was positioned at the foot of the mattress. He placed his hand on it, stroking it as if he was stroking a beloved pet.

Ben and Oli were obsessed with horror movies. Throughout their teenage years, they had always enjoyed them, but when the siblings were all withdrawn from school to be taught at home, they had all thrown themselves into their interests, making up for holes in their social lives. All apart from Kevin. He never really had friends to lose in the first place.

I hate that fat, fat, fat, fat, stupid, fat— He stopped in mid-thought, realising his anger was making his head throb.

Why do I feel so sad? Getting rid of the pills should have been my crowning achievement. Why am I so sad?

"Because you miss us?"

He turned to see Ben sitting down beside him. "Yes."

"We're brothers. We always got on with our thing, and you always got on with your thing, but that didn't stop us being brothers."

"Does it hurt being dead?"

Ben shrugged. "Not really."

"I thought getting rid of the tablets would help me stop feeling like a prisoner. But now...." He put his hand up to his head. "I feel like there's

something really, really wrong up there and I don't know how to stop it." His voice was undulating more with each sentence he spoke.

"The tablets were never the thing that made you a prisoner."

"What did then?"

"You."

"What do you mean?"

He felt the mattress dip on the other side and turned to see Oli sitting there. Blood pumped from the stomach wound where the machete had been driven through him. "You envied us. You envied our freedom, but the freedom was always there for you to take too. You became a prisoner to your own quest for approval. You desperately wanted Mummy and Daddy to be proud of you for following in their footsteps, but that quest was nothing more than four stone walls and a barred window. You're not a surgeon, Ralph. No matter how much you dress up like one." He gestured towards the blood-soaked scrubs he was wearing.

"Yeah," Ben chimed in and Razzle turned his gaze to his other brother. This time, Ben's head was cocked back at a right angle; his face was almost flat, covered in blood that dripped over the quilt. "I know you were jealous about the idea Mitzi came up with, but, y'know, a nosadictomy isn't a real thing or a normal thing. Don't get me wrong; in that crazy, fucked-up brain through a cheese grater head of yours, it probably is. Just like wearing a werewolf mask and howling at the moon is real and normal to me, or wearing the skin of a past victim and walking around with a machete is real and normal to Oli. But it's not something that other people would tend to do."

Razzle's head drooped further. "My whole life's been a lie. I've been trying to make other people happy and it's never been what I wanted."

"What did you want?"

"I wanted to...." He put his hand up to his head. "I don't know. I don't know what I wanted. I don't know what I want. I'm alone. I'm completely alone. They all laugh at me. They think I'm a joke."

"Who?"

"All of them. Mummy, Daddy, Mitzi, Kevin." He said the last name through gritted teeth. "Especially Kevin."

"So, what are you going to do about it?" Ben asked.

"What can I do?"

“It’s not too late. You got rid of those tablets because you wanted to stop feeling like a prisoner. You still have that power. You have the power to do whatever you want to do. *Whatever* you want to do.”

“What should I do?” He stood up, suddenly a little more energised, the sadness dissipating as the prospect of a new beginning came into reach.

“You should do whatever you want to do, whatever you feel like doing.”

Razzle’s eyes immediately focused on a display case in the corner. It was one of Ben’s most prized possessions, the costume worn by the actress Julia Picard for the movie *Busy Lizzie*, where the ghost of Lizzie Borden had been summoned back from the dead to reap revenge for.... *I don’t remember. I don’t remember what the film was about. I don’t know if I even watched it. I just remember loving that dress when I saw it.*

He walked up to the glass case. There was an axe on a stand, obviously not the one that was used in the movie, but it was vintage, nonetheless, and it was real, and more importantly sharp. Ben was meticulous about how he looked after his collection. *Obsessive in fact.* But Razzle could relate to obsessive. He got it.

The seconds ticked by and then the minutes as he stared at the costume. He looked back at the bed, but his brothers were no longer there. A smile lit his face again. He understood now. He understood why he had struggled for happiness, true happiness. He understood why getting rid of the tablets hadn’t had the effect he had hoped for. He understood it all.

He needed to become the person he wanted to be, not the person others expected him to be. He needed complete freedom to do whatever he had to in order to develop and to flourish.

He tipped his head, looking at the costume in the glass case as it hung on the mannequin. He slipped off his trousers then pulled off his top. His naked, moonlit reflection smiled back, but he looked beyond it to the dress. He extended his neck towards the neck of the dress and now he could see himself wearing it.

Ben’s words echoed in his head. “You should do whatever you want to do, whatever you feel like doing.”

“Yes. Yes.”



Mitzi continued to be dragged along by Kevin. His grasp was like a manacle around her wrist, and despite her efforts to shake free, she couldn't.

"I need to get back to the operating room," she protested, trying to sound like every bit of the medical professional she believed herself to be.

"NO!" Kevin growled, stopping dead and dragging her towards him. His face was just inches away from hers, the only things stopping them from touching were his height and his protruding naked belly. "No!" He hissed this time. "Things are going to change."

"Get off me. You're hurting me." She tried to shake her wrist free, but he squeezed even tighter.

"I know you all make fun of me, laugh at me, talk behind my back. I know. I know. I know." He spoke through gritted teeth. His warm breath, stinking with the remnants of a day's milkshakes, pastries, pasties and more besides, glossed her skin like a moist paintbrush dipped in foulness. It mixed with the staunch, sweaty odour from his armpits and body folds, almost causing her to throw up, but at that moment, she felt something other than revulsion and hatred for her brother. She felt fear.

"You're hurting me," she whimpered, trying to pull loose once more.

"Good," he hissed back. "It's nothing for how much you've hurt me." His voice sounded different to the Kevin she knew. It was visceral, angry, hate filled. "Things are going to change. Things are going to change. Mummy and Daddy have had their chance. They've had their chance and Ben and Oli are dead, and the strangers are on the run, and I'm going to have to sort this out like I always sort everything, everything, everything, EVERYTHING out."

She flinched as his shouted words hit her like a blast from a hairdryer. "I'm telling Mummy and Daddy," she whimpered like a small child.

"Mummy and Daddy aren't running things anymore. I'm in charge. I'm in charge now."

He turned and carried on towards the generator shed, keeping his hand wrapped around Mitzi's wrist like a vice.



"Are you okay, Miss T?" Javed asked as they reached the edge of the courtyard. The oversized naked man and the woman dressed as a stripper

nurse had disappeared from view some minutes before and now they had a straight run towards the open door if they wanted it, but both of them hovered in the shadows afforded by one of the waist-high hedges lining the sprawling parking area.

“Listen,” Claire replied, “I’ve been thinking. It was the man who was driving. He’s going to have the keys. He’s the one we need to find, need to get to. If we get the keys, that’s game over. We can get out of here and get help.”

“What about the others?”

“We have to be realistic about this. I don’t know what we’ve stumbled on here, but it’s a universe away from normal. We’ve seen a few of these people; we’ve really got no idea how many there are. I mean, it’s a big place,” she said as they both observed the vast mansion from their crouched position. “If we go in with a view of finding Kayla and Ethan when we don’t really even know if they’re here, it’s going to end badly. If we go in with a view of finding that bloke and getting the car keys, then at least that’s an achievable goal and Millie might not have died for....” Her words trailed off and she tried her hardest not to cry. That’s really all she wanted to do, but the enormity of the events of the evening had seemingly put corks in her lacrimal glands for the moment.

Javed squeezed her arm. “Whatever you say, Miss T.”

“Y’know, Javed. I think considering what’s happened tonight, considering we’re in a fight for our lives, for our friends’ lives, you can probably just call me Claire.”

A small laugh escaped the teenager’s mouth. “You’ll always be Miss T to us. To me, to Zack, to Nat, Kayla, Ethan, Amanda. You’re the one who made school something special, who gave us all something that no other teacher ever could. Claire doesn’t fit. Yeah, you’re our friend, you’re one of us, but you’re Miss T, too. You’re the one we’re always going to remember when we think back to our time at school. You’re the one who was always there for us.”

Claire gulped. “That’s really lovely of you to say. But my guess is, in twenty years’ time, when you’re thinking back to your school days, it’s probably tonight that flashes up in your memory rather than our drama group.”

Javed chuckled. “Yeah. I think you could be right there.”

“So, what do you think?”

Javed looked to the Renault Clio and then beyond to the open front doors. “We find the guy, we get the keys, we raise the alarm, and then we come back here as fast as we can to try to help where we can.”

Claire nodded. “Yeah.”

“I’m in.”

She took his hand, squeezing it, and clenched her fist even tighter around the tyre iron in the other. “Right, let’s go.” Her headache, her illness, her diagnosis were all forgotten for the time being. Only one thing mattered, getting those keys. The keys were the answer to everything, to getting help, to saving her friends, to putting these maniacs so far out of reach that they couldn’t hurt any more people.

The pair kept low as they ran across the gravel, trying their hardest to remain light on their feet, deliberate, not scuffing their shoes against the surface, just in case there was anyone in earshot who might hunt for the source of the sounds.

Forty metres.

We’re doing this. We’re really doing this. It’s going to work.

Thirty metres.

By this time tomorrow, these bastards will be behind bars. Kayla and Ethan will be back with their families and I’ll be so drunk off my arse that I won’t even be able to remember my own name.

Twenty metres.

There was an echoing clank and a loud hum revved before all the lights flicked back on.

Claire and Javed skidded to a stop, still a good distance from the entrance. They were frozen like prison escapees caught in a spotlight, just waiting for the firing to start or the guards to rush them.

The seconds ticked by one by one. “I think....” Javed began; then he stopped himself as he glanced around the grounds. “I think a generator’s kicked in or something. I don’t think they know we’re here yet.”

Claire glanced around too. There was no sign of the obese, naked man with the shotgun or the woman in the nurse’s outfit. There were no signs of the men and the woman they had seen in scrubs. There was just light and, beyond it, darkness.

“Come on,” Claire finally said. “Before somebody does see us.” They continued as fast as they could towards the door.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 19

When the lights had died, Rupert had gone fumbling around in the dark for lanterns. He'd found two in a cupboard under the sink and the bright LEDs had allowed him to sit an eerie vigil with his wife for a few moments.

She had finally stopped struggling, stopped fighting, and once the tablets had been administered, she'd sat up on the desk with her legs dangling over the side. She stayed like that, her lipstick clown smile an unnerving paradox to the malevolence in her gaze. The line of blood dripping down from her mouth, extending over her chin, glimmered in the bright glow and Rupert, for all the confusion short-circuiting his head, didn't just feel ill at ease but positively terrified.

Even when the generator had kicked in and the lights had come back on, the icy hatred in Lavender's glare did not thaw. She just remained there staring at her husband, her head bowed a little, her expression all the more sinister for it as her eyes angled up to behold him.

"Look. I'm sorry," he said, wrapping a bandage around the already bloody gauze. "I'm sorry I had to do that." He hoped the tablets would work on both of them. He felt like a man falling off a cliff and grabbing hold of a jutting tuft of grass in the hope that it would save him.

The twice-daily medication had been the one thing that had stopped his family going off the edge. Yes, they weren't like other families. They were unorthodox, a little eccentric, and some may even say cold when it came to their treatment of others. But there was a difference between that and this. There was a difference between the patriarch and the matriarch helping to marshal their psychological quirks and those of their children and complete and utter bedlam.

Among the tablets he'd taken and he'd administered to his wife were two strong and fast-acting sedatives. In their heightened emotional state, it

would not send them to sleep, but, as was happening now, it would slow them down a little, slow their thoughts, maybe even help them succumb to logic a little more.

He continued to stand there watching his wife watching him and an involuntary shudder ran through him. *What if it doesn't work? What if it's too late? No. Can't be too late. Already working. I can feel it. I can feel it working.*

His mind was still full of shouting voices, strobing lights and humming cables. It was anything but ordered, but the very fact that he still had the wherewithal to try to gain some small amount of control told him that not all was lost.

Fresh tears suddenly started streaming down Lavender's face and Rupert wasn't sure if it was pent-up fury finally manifesting itself or sadness. A sharp, pained intake of breath suggested the latter as the dam broke fully and her body began to shake.

"It's alright. It's alright. We'll ... we'll manage this. Somehow, we'll manage this." He walked across to her, extending his arms, and she slowly slid off the table, taking a tentative step towards him before leaping through the air.

He fell back, taken completely by surprise. His head banged hard against the tiled floor and everything went fuzzy for just a second, but then she was on top of him, literally. She started screaming like a banshee as she straddled his frame, clamping his slight figure between her thighs. The noise wasn't like any sound he'd heard come from her mouth or any mouth for that matter. It soared and troughed with no pattern. One second, she sounded like a soprano hitting high C; the next, a Mongolian throat singer achieving a note so low it made the air around them vibrate.

He lay there in shock, unable to respond to the attack but knowing he would have to if he was going to save what was left of his family. His mind was still awash, a mess, a giant ball of yarn with no beginning and no end, just a mass of confusion. But he was trying. He was trying to start making sense of everything, trying to get a great grasp.

He started to shift beneath her and Lavender's thumbs shot up to his eyes. She dug them in, pushing, pushing, pushing, harder and further and harder and further. He tried to clench his lids shut tight; he tried to fend her off.

“Please, Lavender. Please,” he begged. He held on to her arms, but it was no good. She reared up, gaining even more momentum as she pushed down in a second wave.

Finally, the terrifying sounds erupting from her mouth ended, giving way to exaggerated breathing. He continued to fight and writhe, but he couldn’t shake her off. “I HATE YOU!” she screamed. “I HATE YOU! I HATE YOU!”

POP!

POP!

Rupert fell still on the floor. His fingers unfurled from his wife’s arms and his body went limp. “But I love you,” Lavender continued, talking, not shouting. “I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you.”

She stopped. Not sure why. Not sure of anything really. It was as if she was a passenger on the ride that was her body. A 3D virtual experience that was so realistic she could almost smell the blood.

She relaxed a little, pulling back and withdrawing her thumbs from the grisly sockets that had once housed her husband’s eyes. She looked down at him in confusion, not quite understanding what was happening. Not quite understanding why he wasn’t playing anymore.

“Rupert? Rupert?” She spoke as if trying to wake him from a nap, not equating the gaping holes where his eyes once were with the lack of response. “Rupert? Rupert, wake up.”

She lifted her hands to look at them and it was only when she saw gristle coating her thumbs and fibrous sinew jammed beneath her nails that she started to understand.

She looked back down at him in a state of pure panic and grabbed hold of his scrubs tightly, pulling, shaking and twisting. “Rupert. Rupert. This isn’t funny. You’re scaring me. You’re scaring me, Rupert. Rupert. Rupert.”

Minutes had passed since the administering of the tablets and she could feel a numbness spreading in her head, like a hose dousing a giant fire. It wouldn’t kill the heat totally, but it would end the immediate danger of it fanning elsewhere. She looked around the lab with only the vaguest recollection of how she had got there, only the vaguest understanding of why she had gotten so angry with her husband in the first place. “I’m sorry. I’m sorry I lost my temper, Rupert, but I’d really like you to wake up now. Wake up, Rupert. Wake up. Wake up. WAKE UP! WAKE UP! WAKE UP!”



When the lights came back on, Zack and Natalie froze. They were in a long hallway, and until that moment, they had been edging their way along slowly. The only light had been gifted through open doors, allowing the moon's glow to seep into the corridor. Miss T had taken them on another school trip the previous year. They had gone to London to see a performance of *Othello* at the National Theatre and on the way back, they had visited a stately home. This place possessed some of that grandeur.

It was a lot more than a McMansion. It had gravitas, history and a disquieting eeriness to it. They stopped dead as a figure moved into their field of vision.

"What the fuck?" Natalie asked in something less than a whisper. Her hand clenched tighter around the rock in her hand. But then the figure continued, crossing the hallway and disappearing out of view. "Tell me that wasn't a bloke in a dress with an axe."

"Um..." Even Zack, who had seen a lot more than the rest of the group combined, remained speechless for a second. "I really wish I could."

"What the fuck's going on?"

"I'm no expert, Nat. But I think these people might have a few mental health issues."

She couldn't help but snigger. "You're wasted with this whole acting thing. You should seriously think about going into psychiatry."

"And deal with mad fuckers like this? No thanks."

"Well, I'm no expert, either, but I'm pretty certain everyone who goes to a psychiatrist doesn't walk around in vintage dresses looking to murder people with an axe."

Zack shrugged. "Not a risk I'm willing to take."

She shrugged too. "Given the events of the night so far, I suppose that's fair enough."

They carried on, slowly, coming to a complete stop at the intersection where they'd seen the axe-wielding figure cross. Zack grasped the machete tightly as he shuffled up to the corner and peeked around. "It's all clear."

"What are we doing exactly?"

"We're looking for Kayla and Ethan."

"Yeah. I figured that. But we must have gone past half a dozen closed doors already and we've not bothered looking inside. What's to say we

haven't walked right past the room they were in?"

"It's possible. But none of those rooms had lights on. Even when the power was off, I'm pretty certain they'd have had candles or lanterns or something." He pointed to the gap at the bottom of one of the doors where a slip of moonlight leached onto the hallway floor. "I've got a feeling that wherever they are, and whoever they're with, they're not going to be in the dark. From everything I've seen so far, these people seem to like an audience."

Natalie looked at her companion for a moment before replying. "Actually, that's pretty smart."

"I'm looking forward to the day somebody says that and there isn't surprise in their voice."

"Yeah, I wouldn't hold your breath for that one."

They both smiled before turning back to the task ahead. They knew the flippancy and joke making were just masks to disguise how terrified they both were. Anything could happen. It already had and they were in just as much danger, if not more, than their friends. There was a very real possibility that the lunatics who were running around the forest, running around these very hallways, might have already killed their fellow students, so putting themselves in harm's way like this was bordering on suicidal. But at the same time, neither of them was prepared to turn their backs on Ethan or Kayla. They were all from very different backgrounds, but the drama group, and more specifically Miss T, had brought them together.

In their own social groups, the six of them would never have crossed paths, but in class, then out of class, a bond had formed through a mutual passion that had been ignited in them. They were close. Closer than classmates, more than players on a stage, they were like a second family, especially to Zack.

He took a breath. "Okay," he said. "Let's go find our guys."



Claire and Javed had been heading towards the door when the crunch of gravel announced the imminent arrival of who they could only guess. They came to a sudden stop, crouching down behind the Clio, hoping whoever was coming hadn't caught a glimpse of them before they ducked.

“I’m warning you. You’d better let me go, Kevin. Or ... or there’ll be trouble. Big, big, bloody, bastard, fucking trouble.”

It was a woman’s voice, but the agitated nature and unnatural and disjointed use of the profanity made her sound childlike. The gravel scuffed and Javed risked raising his head for a few seconds. He watched as the two figures disappeared through the entrance then dipped down once more.

“It was that massive naked bloke and the stripper nurse. I don’t know what’s going on with that, but I don’t think she’s a prisoner.”

“Whatever the relationship, if she’s getting dragged around by a huge naked man when she doesn’t want to be, it can’t be that healthy.”

“True that.”

“So, we leave it a minute and then go in after them?”

“No.”

“What do you mean no?”

“I’ve been thinking.”

“Okay.”

“Power’s better for them than it is for us. They’ve got cameras in the forest. Who’s to say they don’t have a load around here too. I mean, they could be pointing at us right this minute.”

“This isn’t in any way motivational if that’s what you’re trying to do, Javed.”

“No, Miss T, what I’m saying is we should go find the generator and prang it up, break it. I think our chances are better if they’re in the dark just as much as us.”

“I really don’t like that idea. This place is scary enough without—”

“Miss T, I’m doing this. Stay here with Amanda, but I’m doing this. For Natalie, for Zack, for the others.”

Claire let out a long breath. She peeked inside the car to see Amanda still out cold. “I don’t like this plan. But then again, I don’t like any of the other options either. Come on,” she said and the pair started running across the courtyard, staying low but casting long, conspicuous shadows.



Kevin burst through the control room doors still holding on to Mitzi’s wrist. “Let go of me. Let go.” Her cries were becoming more pathetic by

the minute. It was impossible to wriggle free and regardless of what she said, he continued to ignore her.

“Sit there,” he growled, finally relinquishing his grip and almost throwing her into one of the chairs at the long desk. He placed the shotgun down and typed his password into the first then the second laptop. All the display monitors were currently blue. He’d have to restart the programme to get the cameras back online.

He placed both hands up to his head and grimaced. *It feels like my brain’s going to explode.*

“What’s wrong?” Mitzi asked. “Does your head hurt, Kevin? Does it hurt? Does it hurt? Good. Good. I hope it falls off. I hope your head falls off and you die. I hope you die. DIE. DIE. DIE.”

“Shut up. Shut up,” he growled, unleashing a back-handed hit.

Mitzi screamed, sliding from the chair onto the floor. She held her face while her brother walked back over to the laptops and flopped down.

A whimper left Mitzi’s mouth. “We all hate you, Kevin. All of us. When we were younger and it was our bedtime, me and the others used to get up and carry on playing. We never came for you though. None of us wanted to play with you. We always hated you. Always. We wished you’d run away or die. We hated, hated, hated you. We hated your guts. We hated your face. You made us so sick. Sick, sick, sick. And we’d laugh about you while we played. We’d laugh and laugh and laugh and it was all the funnier because you had no idea.”

Kevin jumped back up to his feet, his chair rolling across the room, clattering against the wall. He bounded towards her and she crab walked backwards into a corner. “I said shut up,” he growled again, reaching down and grabbing her by the scruff of her neck.

She tried her hardest to remain in position, but his strength was too great and she felt herself being lifted as if she was hooked to a crane. “You’ll show me respect. They’ll all show me respect after today. I’ll be the man of the house after today.”

“Wh-what are you talking about? What do you mean the man of the house?”

“You’ll see. You’ll see a lot of things.” He dragged her over to the chair by his and plonked her down. “You’ll all see. You’ll all see who I really am.” He got back to work at the laptop, the expression of anger still painting his features.

All the screens flashed before returning to the camera views they'd displayed before the power cut. He sat back a little, the anger washing away as a self-satisfied smirk appeared on his face. His eyes were suddenly drawn to two figures sprinting towards the generator shed.

"No. No. No, no, no." The smile was gone in an instant and he jumped to his feet once more, grabbing the shotgun and a handful of shells from the box on the shelf.

Mitzi leapt to her feet, seizing the weapon and trying to pull it away from him, but his grasp was rock solid and he shoved her. She went flailing to the floor and landed heavily. "You have no right. You have—"

"Shut up," he spat. "I need to take care of them and then I'll be back. I'll be back and I'll show you everything I've wanted to show you for so long."

Another frightened whimper left Mitzi's mouth as her colossal, naked brother marched out of the room with the broken shotgun over his arm.

CHAPTER 20

Mitzi stayed put for a few seconds until she was sure Kevin was far enough down the corridor not to hear her creep out; then she climbed to her feet. She went to the door and opened it ever so slightly then peeked like a child entering a room she wasn't meant to go into.

When she was sure the coast was clear, she slipped out into the operating theatre next door. "You're awake," she said excitedly, the fear and confusion from before vanishing in an instant as she ran across to the table to where Ethan had shouted himself hoarse. Now he just sobbed quietly, unable to believe what was happening, what had happened.

Mitzi ran a comforting hand over his head as he turned towards her with tear-filled eyes. "What have you done?" was all he could whisper.

"It's alright, Charlie. It's alright. It's going to be a shock for you at first, but trust me. It's going to be better for all of us in the end."

He sniffed. "My name's not Charlie, you crazy bitch."

Mitzi unleashed a heavy slap. "Now, I know you're upset, but that's no reason for name calling. I don't know what I've done to deserve such disrespect, but I won't have it. Do you understand me?"

Ethan started laughing through his tears. Kayla's head had been ever-present since he'd woken properly. Not just in the physical sense. It loomed on his shoulder like a big, heavy football and even when he turned away, he could feel her cold skin on the back of his head. "You're mad. You're all absolutely barking mad."

She slapped him again. "Stop it. Stop it," she said. "Otherwise, there'll be no oomphy doompies; there'll be no nothing. I'll carry on working and you'll end up in the furnace like all the others."

He shook his head despairingly. "How many have there been?"

Mitzi shook her head. "That doesn't matter. What matters is that I chose you, Charlie. I didn't think I was going to, but I did. I realised that you were perfect. You were what I've been looking for all this time."

“Just kill me. Please, just kill me,” he said quietly before starting to sob.

She stroked his head. “Don’t cry. Don’t cry.” She bent down and kissed him on the forehead. “I love you, Charlie, and even though you’re probably feeling confused right now, I know that one day you’ll love me. We’re going to be together forever. It’s going to be perfect.” There was an unhinged smile on her face and her eyes were distant like those of a mesmerised child.

She’s serious. She believes this. She believes this is all fucking normal, that Kayla’s head isn’t going to rot on my shoulders; that I’m not going to get sepsis and die.

The lights suddenly went off and the room fell dark. “Oh, that’s bad. That’s bad, Charlie. That’s bad, bad, bad. He’s going to be angry. Kevin’s going to be very, very angry. Your friends have already caused a lot of trouble tonight. A lot of, lot of, lot of trouble. Poor Oli. What did he ever do to them? Stay here. I’m going to get a lantern.”

My friends? Holy shit. They’re here. They’ve somehow managed to find me. They’re trying to save me. Shit! They don’t have any clue who they’re up against. I need to try to help in some way. I need to—

There was a click and a bright LED lantern flicked on from the other side of the room. It travelled across like a floating ghost, his eyes finally adjusting and noticing the mad smile of his captor once more.

“But don’t worry. I know you’re not your friends and your friends aren’t you. You’ve been in here all the time and that’s going to be my argument. When Mummy, Daddy and Razzle come back and see what I’ve done, they’ll go mad. They’ll go mad because we were meant to share. Razzle and I were meant to have one each and they’ll say I got greedy and they’ll say that I misbehaved, and they’ll try to punish me, but I’ll explain. I’ll explain to them that it’s love and you don’t control who you fall in love with.”

She placed the lantern down and disappeared from view for a moment as he continued to stare towards it. He heard shuffling feet and felt a tug on his shoulder. He turned to see the mad nurse leaning over, kissing Kayla’s cold, dead lips. A shudder ran through him. His body shook despite the restraints as he beheld his friend’s head.

The nurse withdrew and giggled a little. “Your tongue’s cold,” she said, stroking Kayla’s hair in the same way she had stroked Ethan’s.

“Mitzi. Is that what I heard them calling you?”

The nurse looked surprised and she walked back around to the other side of the table. “This is a hallowed room. In here, you need to refer to me as Nurse Mitzy Glitzy.” She ran a finger playfully over his chest. “But when we’re out of here, yes, you can call me Mitzi, Charlie. I’d like that. I’d like to fall asleep to the sound of you saying my name over and over again.” She smiled, a beaming smile that made her look like a little girl and not the soulless murderer that she was.

Ethan was scared, scared for a lot of reasons. He was scared that he’d die on this table. He was scared that if he didn’t, then he’d end up with some horrible infection as a result of the operation and suffer a drawn-out, painful death as a result. He was scared that his friends would be butchered or join him there. The list went on and on. And as unfathomable as so many facets of this night were, the one thing he was sure of at that moment was the crazy nurse didn’t want to hurt him. She believed fully that they were going to be together, that she was in love with him, and that had to be something. *I need to use this. I need to use this, somehow, to help the others.*

“How long will I be in here?”

“Um ... I don’t know. Mummy and Daddy will have to look at you. I’ve never kept anyone before now. None of them were special like you, Charlie. I don’t know what it was. Something just came over me and I knew you were the one.”

“I-I’m scared they’ll kill me. I’m scared they’ll be so angry that they’ll kill me just to teach you a lesson.”

An expression of fear flashed on Mitzi’s face. “No. They wouldn’t do that. They wouldn’t dare. This is love. This is love, Charlie.”

“I don’t think they’ll understand.”

She grabbed hold of his hand. “I won’t let anything happen to you. I promise. I promise we’ll be together forever.”



Even when the lights had come back on, Lavender had not switched the lanterns off. She had remained in position, straddling her husband, staring down at the empty holes where his eyes used to be, crying uncontrollably. Even though the main lights had gone off once more, she remained

unmoved. She had no interest in what was going on outside that room, only what had gone on inside.

“It’s alright. It’s alright,” she eventually said, wiping her tears away. “We’ll have you back in shape in no time. It’s probably just something that’s going around.”

She climbed to her feet, grabbed one of the lanterns and headed to the door. She walked past the control room and straight into the operating theatre.

“You can’t take him. He’s mine. I won’t let you take him,” Mitzi declared, racing to the foot of the table and putting herself in between Ethan and her mother.

“Don’t mind me,” Lavender said, completely oblivious to the headless corpse on one table and the two-headed figure on the other. Oblivious to her daughter too. She walked over to a corner where a wheelchair stood folded. She extended the crossbars, flattening the seat, and started wheeling it out again. “Your father’s feeling a little under the weather.”

She barged the double doors open again, disappearing with the chair and lantern. “Still on the floor?” she asked, as she re-entered the lab. “I can tell you’re going to milk this for all it’s worth. Men. Honestly. What are you like?” She chuckled to herself as she placed the lantern down and put the brakes on the chair by the side of her husband. She shuffled her hands beneath his armpits and hoisted him up. His body immediately slumped. She lifted him again and fastened the restraining belt around his waist. That had been something Kevin had fitted.

Such a clever boy.

Many of the patients who had used the wheelchair were unable to remain upright of their own volition, so the belt had been a huge time saver.

“There,” she said, standing back with her hands on her hips. “I know. We wouldn’t want to scare the children, would we? I’ll be back in a minute.” She grabbed the lantern and disappeared out of the door once more.



“You guys never cease to amaze me,” Claire said as she followed Javed back around the giant property. “Where did you learn to do that?”

“Well, I didn’t really, Miss T. It was just obvious that pipe was the fuel line. So, if there’s no fuel, there’s no generator,” he replied over his shoulder in a hushed tone. He had taken the tyre iron back, using it to smash the assembly around the pipe, and now he walked with it ready in case they came across any of the psychopaths from the house.

“I wouldn’t have had a clue.”

“It’s pretty straight—”

BOOM!

Claire staggered back as bone, brain, blood and flesh exploded over her face. More still splattered on the ground around her. Javed’s body stayed upright for a second. In the light of the moon, there was no sign of anything above his neck. It was as if it had just vanished. But it hadn’t vanished. It was on her and all around her. She could taste him on her lips, smell him in her nostrils. Some of the bone had drilled into her face, causing wounds of her own, but the pain was the last thing on her mind. She was used to pain. Pain that would make the toughest gangland bosses cry.

Javed.

His body finally dropped, the tyre iron ringing on the gravel as it left his hand. Claire stood there frozen, beholding her fallen friend for just a beat before raising her eyes to the naked behemoth who had murdered him. In that split second, there was a tiny part of Claire that thought about staying put and letting the bastard who’d killed her student, her friend, kill her too. Then an almost biblical level of rage gripped her. She dived to the ground as the second shot exploded.

The lumbering beast shuffled from foot to foot, not seeming to register any pain as the gravel dug into his bare soles. He broke the shotgun, emptying the spent shell casings. Two more dropped to the ground through his thick sausage fingers and he huffed deeply as he bent over to pick them up. He wasn’t wearing a stitch. He had nowhere to store more shells, so Claire understood that these final two must be the last, but all it would need was one. One could finish her off.

She scrambled. She knew it was not just the rain from earlier that wetted her fingers. Some of it was warm. Some of it was Javed. *Sweet Javed.*

Her hand finally came to rest on the tyre iron and gravel flew up behind her as she rose, launching into a run at the same time. Kevin straightened up

at that very instant. His awkward, pudgy fingers fumbled one, then another shell into the weapon before closing it.

Anger sizzled in his blood. He was angry at everyone and everything. His sister's words had ignited a fuse that would lead to an explosion nobody would be prepared for.

We never came for you though. None of us wanted to play with you. We always hated you. Always. We wished you'd run away or die. We hated, hated, hated you. We hated your guts. We hated your face. You made us so sick. Sick, sick, sick. And we'd laugh about you while we played. We'd laugh and laugh and laugh and it was all the funnier because you had no idea.

It was true. He did have no idea. His mother and father had shielded him from much, telling him he was special in his own way, telling him that he saw all and knew all. *It was a lie. I saw nothing. I knew nothing. They lied. They lied, they lied. They lied.*

A shuddering sob left his mouth as his finger closed around the trigger. The sob turned to a gasp. The confusion firing a thousand thoughts across his brain had caused him to miss a beat. It was like frame-lapse photography. She was a few feet away; then she was on him.

She flew through the darkness like a night demon.

Crack!

"Owww!" The exclamation struggled out of his mouth as he dropped the shotgun and staggered back. He brought his hand up and felt the huge gash on his forehead. "Owww!" he cried out again.

Claire landed heavily, rolling once, twice before jumping back to her feet. She sprang at him again, swiping hard with the tyre iron and this time striking him on the back of the head. He collapsed, splaying out. A rivulet opened in the back of his head, blood oozing as he lay there motionless.

She didn't know if he was dead, and then a thought occurred to her. There were so many Hollywood movies where someone would walk away from the monster after tackling them, never bothering to make sure they were dead, never checking for a pulse. Sometimes, they were actually dead, only to come back to life. The events of the evening had played out like a horror film up to this moment, but she was in charge now. She was the director and she was going to make sure this particular antagonist was written out of the script for good.

Claire looked across towards Javed's headless body then back to the downed figure. She sniffed, holding back her tears.

Need to be strong.

She wanted to cry so badly. For Millie, for Javed, for herself, but now more than ever, she realised that she could still play a part in helping her other students. She walked up to her victim, raised the tyre iron and swung down.

Crack!

Again.

Crack!

Again.

Crack!

Again.

Thump!

The rear of the skull completely gave way and the iron sank into the spongy contents therein. Still she did not stop, raising her weapon again and again, each time bringing it down with more and more force until it became like hitting a giant jelly with a rolling pin. Slivers of brain and other viscous tissue splashed her face as she continued. She was hypnotised by the gory spectacle, unable to break the trance until, finally, she smashed through to the other side and the iron hammered down on gravel and dirt. The echoing clang it made vibrated up her arm and she stopped.

She exhaled deeply, dropping her head for a moment before wearily climbing to her feet. Beneath the blood and bone and tissue that painted her features she had broken into a sweat. Beads appeared here and there, cutting through the grisly mask. She breathed in copper. She tasted that and more besides in her mouth.

Suddenly, she bent over, throwing up the contents of her stomach. Throwing up the burger, fries and milkshake she'd had at the services, throwing up the noodles she'd had for lunch. It shot out of her mouth like a water cannon, filling the hollow chasm of her victim's head then overflowing, seeping over the sides of what remained of the skull.

She lingered there a second after she was done then wiped her mouth, picked up the shotgun and headed towards the house.



“Mother. Mother, where are you going?” Razzle stood in the foyer, bathing in the moonlight from the open door. He had hoped for a reaction, surprise, glee, anger, something from his mother when she saw him in the Lizzy Borden outfit, but instead, there was nothing.

She walked right by him with the lantern raised and to the staircase. “Your father’s not well. We’re all going to have to pull our weight around here to make up for it. I’m going to get a blanket for his knees.”

Razzle stood there, his erect axe drooping a little in disappointment. He craved attention. He always had. There was a reason Dr Razzle Dazzle was the star performer in the operating room.

He watched as his mother disappeared up the stairs and onto the landing and then turned to the side door of the foyer and headed into the darkness towards it. “Let’s see who else is in here,” he said to himself, the smile back on his face.



“The more I see of these people the more I wonder how the fuck they’ve all lived as long as they have,” Zack whispered. He and Natalie had entered the foyer at roughly the same moment that the Lizzy Borden wannabe and his mother appeared. They had both been convinced they would be seen as they ducked down behind a statue at the rear of the large foyer, but the shadows had given them refuge, and such was the level of complete insanity of the two figures that they were pretty much unaware of anything going on around them.

“Where now?”

“Well, that psycho went through the side door like he was expecting to find somebody, didn’t he?”

“Um. Yeah.”

“That’s probably where we should go.”

“Even though we’ve got no idea what could be waiting for us. There might be a hundred of these lunatics for all we know.”

“Yeah. And there could be Ethan and Kayla too.”

“I’m so scared, Zack. I thought I knew what being scared was, but I didn’t.”

“Yeah. I’m scared too. But I don’t think I’d be able to live with myself if I got out of here and later found out that there was something I could

have done.”

“No. Me neither.”

“Come on.”

He took her hand and the pair started across the large chessboard floor then came to a sudden halt once more as a silhouette appeared in the doorway.

“Oh fuck. Oh fuck!” Natalie said, getting ready to turn and run.

“Miss T?”

“Zack? Natalie?”

“Miss T,” Natalie said, running towards her. She stopped as she saw the gory residue on the sides of her face and in her hair glisten in the white light. “What ... what happened?” It was only then that she noticed the shotgun over her arm.

“Javed’s dead.”

“What?” Zack asked. “No. No. No, he can’t be.”

“We came down here to help. He disabled the generator and then the huge one shot him.”

“Not Javed. Where is he?”

“I saw it with my own eyes. He’s dead, Zack. He’s not coming back. I killed the man who did it. And now I’m going to kill the rest of them.”

“You know how to use one of those things, Miss T?”

She looked down at the shotgun. “It can’t be that hard.”

“Give it here, Miss,” he said, reaching out. He broke it as if it was something he’d done a hundred times before and removed the shells, examining them in the moonlight before reloading. “This’ll take care of two of them. We saw one of them go in there,” he said, pointing to the side door. “Another went upstairs. There’s something seriously fucked up with these people.”

“Yeah. I’ve pretty much figured that out.”

“Here you go, Nat,” he said, handing the machete to his friend. “You might want to hold on to that rock as well. You’re pretty wicked with those things.”

The three of them regarded one another for just a few seconds before starting towards the door.

CHAPTER 21

The theatre door burst open and Razzle was hardly bathed in the light from the lanterns but it beat the virtual darkness he'd been in as he navigated the outside corridor. He stepped inside, relishing the attention as Mitzi was taken by surprise.

She stood in front of the bed, blocking his view. "Wh-what are you doing in Ben's costume?"

"It's mine now," he said, his undulating voice back to maximum weirdness. "Everything's mine now." He laughed a strange, piercing laugh and stepped closer, rolling the axe a little in his hands, making the blade catch the light.

"Don't come any further," she said, splaying her arms and hands like a child, trying to block out what lay beyond her.

"What are you hiding?"

"It's none of your concern."

"I say everything, but everything is my concern now." The demented smile on his face stretched to new peaks for the briefest fragment of a moment before his eyes were drawn to the headless body on the neighbouring table. "What have you done? What have you done?"

"I ... I had every right. I had every right, Ralph. I'm a person too. An important one. I'm just as important as you. Just as important. I've always had to play second fiddle, assisting and assisting and assisting. Well, no more. No more. I'm my own person and I should be respected as my own person. I'm not a child. I'm not a child anymore. I'm a woman. And I should be treated as a grown-up adult woman."

"You bitch. How dare you? How dare you? She was mine." He took a stride towards his sister and she shuffled back, knocking into the table and inadvertently stumbling.

Razzle stopped dead as his eyes came to rest on his sister's creation. "I'm warning you. Stay away from him. From both of us," Mitzi cried.

“You ruined both of them for your own selfish pleasure. I hate you. I hate you. I HATE YOU!” He brought the axe higher, taking another step towards her.

“Get back. Get back,” Mitzi said, grabbing a scalpel and holding it up in front of her as if that was some kind of deterrent.

“They’ve always preferred you. Their little daughter could never do any wrong. They’d let you get away with this if it was up to them. Both of them would let you get away with it. But not me. Not me. You have to pay. You have to pay. They’ve always preferred you. They’ve humoured me, but they’ve always preferred you.”

Mitzi’s hand was shaking. “I’m warning you. Don’t—”

“Take your clothes off,” Razzle demanded coldly as if the solution to all his frustrations, the cure for his anger, had been in front of him all along.

Mitzi’s mouth dropped open. “I-I will not,” she said, sniffing in her fear, trying to hold her head up.

Ethan watched on silently in horror. He didn’t know which one was more unhinged.

“Take your clothes off or I’ll kill him.”

Mitzi glanced nervously towards Ethan before turning back to her brother. “K-kill him then. He means nothing to me.”

Razzle walked around to the other side of the table and raised the axe. “You’re the boss.”

“Noo! Noo. Don’t!” Mitzi pleaded, starting to unbutton her uniform.

Razzle laughed. “I knew it. I’ve seen that look in your eyes before. The look where you’ve got a little too attached to your patient.”

“Shut up,” Mitzi sobbed, taking off her dress and cap. She threw them at her brother and he caught them in his left hand, keeping the axe raised above Ethan with the other.

“All of them.”

“I shall not.”

“All your clothes or he dies.”

Mitzi gulped. “Mummy and Daddy are going to—”

“They don’t call the shots around here anymore. I’m in charge now.”

“You’re in charge. Kevin’s in charge. Everybody’s in charge apart from Mitzi.”

“Come on, hurry up. My arm’s getting tired.”

“Please don’t do this,” Ethan said. Despite his own fear; despite hating them both and wanting nothing but to get out, the prospect of the madman dressed as Lizzy Borden committing some horrific violation of his sister made him feel sick to his stomach.

“Tell your pet to shut up or I’ll leave it with just one head and it won’t be the talking one.”

Mitzi took off her pants and bra and threw them at her brother then folded her arms across her chest and clenched her upper thighs together as hard as she could.

She sobbed as she looked down at Ethan. “My knight. You’re a brave knight standing up for your maiden.”

“Why they didn’t abort you I’ll never know,” Razzle said, picking the underwear up off the floor and taking it over to the corner.



The corridor wasn’t completely black as they had feared. At the far end, an internal window to what looked like some kind of lab was lit and a similar source of light cracked from beneath another door a little before it.

The three friends searched out the shadows in case one of the crazies was lurking somewhere. Their movement was slow and deliberate. They were all scared.

“I really don’t like this,” Natalie whispered.

“We’re not meant to like it. It is what it is,” Zack replied.

“If we head into one of these rooms and there are a load of them, more than we can handle I mean, I want you both to run,” Claire said. “I’ll create a diversion for as long as I can, but I want you to run.”

“Nah. Screw that, Miss T. We’re all sticking tog—”

“Listen to me.” She stopped, forcing them to halt too and focus on her silhouette in the dark corridor.

“I haven’t got long left. You guys have your whole lives ahead of you and they’re going to be amazing. They’re going to be lives most can only dream of. You don’t see it because you’re young, but this group is special. You’re talented, intelligent and resourceful and you’ve got such big hearts. Being your teacher has been the crowning achievement of my career and I’m so, so proud of you.”

Natalie gulped. “You’re going to make me cry again.”

Claire reached out and squeezed her hand. “Don’t cry. Just promise me that you’ll get out of here and get help for the others if we’re outmatched when we face these bastards. Promise me,” she repeated, releasing Natalie’s arm and squeezing Zack’s.

“Okay, Miss T. I promise.”



“Holy. Fucking. Shit.” Ethan could only gawp as the man he’d heard his captor call both Ralph and Razzle came back into view. It was clear that he hadn’t made Mitzi strip to abuse her. He’d made her strip so he could put on her clothes. He stumbled a little in the high heels as he paraded up and down, black tights and all. For the time being, he’d left the axe somewhere else. It wasn’t in his hands, anyway, and up until this moment, that had been Ethan’s primary focus, but all he could do now was watch as Razzle paraded by the side of the bed in the stripper nurse outfit that Mitzi had been wearing.

“It came to me in a flash,” he said, turning towards his sister. “They won’t miss you when they’ve got me.” He gestured to his attire. “They’ll call me Razzle Glitzy. No. No. That sounds stupid. Mitzi Dazzle. Yes. Yes, I like that. Mitzi Dazzle.”

“You can’t. YOU CAN’T” Mitzi screamed, leaning forward to throw more force behind her words. “I’m Mitzi. You can’t be Mitzi. It’s my name.”

“Not any more, Miranda. I’m going to be everything our parents want. When you’re gone, they’ll forget about you before they even close the coffin lid.”

“No. NOOO! Take it back. I’m Mitzi. I’ve always been Mitzi. Me.”

“No,” Razzle replied. “I’m Mitzi now. I just wanted you to see. I wanted you to see me before I got rid of you. I wanted you to know that nobody will miss you. Nobody will spare a second thought for you because they’ll have me.” He was being one hundred percent serious and Ethan suddenly realised that he was dead unless Mitzi did something.

“Mitzi,” he whispered as Razzle resumed his walk towards the doors on an imaginary catwalk before swinging around to make the return journey. “The axe.”

Razzle didn't hear the words, but the flash of action as Mitzi started running towards the corner told him everything he needed to. He launched into a run too, forgetting he was wearing high heels. He twisted his ankle, stumbling to the ground. He let out a high-pitched scream as he landed on the floor. His head smashed against the tiles and he was dazed for a second, but as he gathered himself, he saw his naked sister standing over him.

HATE! She brought the axe up, around and down in one fluid movement. Razzle put his arm up in defence, but the blade crashed straight through his forehead. His eyes widened and his jaw dropped as the rest of his body convulsed. She withdrew the axe and blood sprayed from the open wound. She raised her weapon again as Razzle's body fell flat, still juddering, and this time, the axe chopped through her brother's rib cage, rendering him still.

Hate him. She brought the blade up and down again and again, cutting off part of one arm, slicing through his stomach, chopping off a foot. Again and again. She could not bring herself to stop. *So much hate. So much hate. A long, long, long time in coming.*

When she did finally end the onslaught, she was out of breath and covered in blood from head to toe. She slipped a little on the deep red slick as she walked back over to the operating table. She started giggling and reached out, stroking Ethan's head. "We're a good team. The best team," she said excitedly, her bright white teeth contrasting sharply with her crimson face and body.

The double doors burst open again and three figures stood at the entrance for a brief moment, trying to make sense of what they were seeing. A snarl appeared on Mitzi's face and she started towards them, raising the axe as she moved.

BOOM! Her legs left the floor as she flew back. A giant hole opened in her chest and the axe went scuttling over the tiles.

The echo of the report reverberated around the room for a few seconds before silence reigned.

"Oh fuck!" Zack said, his eyes finally focusing on Ethan.

Natalie ran to him, skidding on the sea of blood. She took his hand, and as much as she wanted to look him in the eyes, all she could focus on was Kayla's lifeless head stitched to his shoulder.

"These people are monsters," Claire said. She and Zack edged into the theatre but still remained on high alert.

“We need to get out of here,” Ethan replied. “There are at least two more.”

“That’s a problem, bud. We don’t know how many more there are,” Zack said.

The sound of a door to an adjacent room opening and closing made him and Claire swing around. “Oh shit,” Claire hissed as they waited and waited, expecting the theatre doors to open any second. When they didn’t, they edged towards them, finally peeking out.

They could see shadows on the wall through the lab window and they advanced cautiously, letting the theatre doors fall closed behind them. They looked in through the window to see a woman in a black dress placing a woollen blanket over the knees of a man in a wheelchair. As she stood once more, it became clear the blanket was redundant. There were bloody holes where his eyes had once been and if it wasn’t for the restraint around his waist, he would have undoubtedly fallen out.

“That was the driver,” Zack said. “That’s the guy who’ll have the keys.”

Other than being dead and eyeless, he looked exactly the same as he had on exiting the car and they could both only hope that he would still have the keys on him. They watched a moment longer as the woman reached into her pocket and retrieved a pair of novelty children’s sunglasses, which she squeezed onto the man’s head, hiding the gaping chasms.

“On any other day this would seem odd.”

“Yeah,” Zack replied, opening the door and heading into the lab. Claire followed and even when both of them were inside, the woman did not raise her head to look. She hummed “Teddy Bears’ Picnic” as she shuffled the man a little further back in the chair. Finally, she straightened up, grabbed one of the lanterns and walked around to the other side taking the handles of the chair.

“He’s not feeling himself today. You’ll have to come back another time.”

“We need the keys,” Zack said, not aiming the shotgun but holding it in the woman’s general direction.

“Keys, what keys?” she asked irritably.

“The car keys,” Zack replied.

“Ah. You must be the valeters. Well, I need to apologise. It was left in quite a mess,” she said with a chuckle as she reached into her husband’s trouser pocket. She flung the keys across to Claire. “You can see yourselves out. Now you’ll have to excuse me. I need to get this one to bed.” Zack aimed the shotgun and Claire placed her hand over it, pushing it down as the woman wheeled the chair towards the door and out.

“She doesn’t seem like a threat,” she said, beating Zack to asking the question.

“Sure. She seemed perfectly fucking normal to me. I remember my nan putting a pair of kids’ sunglasses on my grandad when we had his viewing.”

“Come on. Let’s just get out of here.” They were about to go when Zack grabbed Claire’s arm. “What? What is it?”

“Over there.” He nodded to an old-fashioned-looking phone next to a socket on one of the countertops. “Do you think it’ll work without any power?”

“That’s old-school. My parents had one of those. They don’t have displays or anything. They shouldn’t need power.”

Zack walked across and picked it up, placing the receiver to his ear. A look of pure excitement lit his face. “There’s a tone. There’s a tone, Miss T.”

Claire walked across and grabbed it out of his hand. She dialled nine, nine, nine and then waited. Her mouth fell open in anticipation as the operator responded. “Police. We need the police. And an ambulance. More than one. We’ll need lots of police. People have been murdered. There are others injured, badly injured.” She waited. “My name’s Claire Trent. I don’t know. I don’t know where we are.”

“Miss T,” Zack said, picking up a medical equipment catalogue still in its cellophane.

“We’re at Keller House, Vesper Drive, near Helstrom. Okay,” she said, her face lighting up a little. “Okay. She wants me to stay on the line. They’re coming, Zack. Help’s coming.”

EPILOGUE

It had been a sombre evening for many reasons but a happy one too. Eight months after the events of that terrible night, Amanda, Natalie, Ethan and Zack had put on five more performances of *Look Back in Anger* to sell-out crowds at John Douglas High School. They'd had to use two students from the year below for a couple of the smaller parts in the absence of the sadly departed Javed and Kayla. Amanda had needed a stick as her leg was still not back to normal and Ethan was on all sorts of tablets to combat infection after infection after his surgery, but they were not a detriment to his acting.

Whether it was the performance or what had now become their infamous back story, each night was buzzing and this, the final performance, ended with a ten-minute standing ovation. Newspaper cameras flashed as the now legendary Claire Trent, Miss T, was brought onto the stage. She had survived longer than the doctors predicted. She had fought and battled, but this night heralded her last night as the drama teacher, her last night at the school, and it was only right that she took the applause too.

It was Mr Moggs himself who wheeled her chair onto the stage and it was Mr Moggs who said a few words when the applause finally ended. He talked about her as an educator, as a person, and as someone who had changed so many people's lives.

"And it's with all that in mind," he continued, "that we're having this little celebration."

Claire's movement was limited in the wheelchair. The pain had become so acute that sometimes her face spasmed and all sorts of other tics manifested. So, as a veiled display was quietly rolled out behind her, she didn't notice it. Instead, she focused on a group of teacher friends appearing from stage right with a tray of glasses and several bottles of champagne.

The booze and glasses were placed down on a table that had been part of the set until a few minutes before. The bottles were opened one after the

other. The drinks were poured and the glasses handed out before Mr Moggs carried on.

“Now, as I was saying, this is a celebration. We’ve all mourned plenty during these last few months, and with good cause. But tonight,” he said, placing his hand on Claire’s shoulder, we’re here to toast this wonderful lady. Someone who I’m proud to call a friend and someone who is going to be missed by this administration, by this school, by these pupils, more than she will ever possibly know.

“A few months back, when Zack, Natalie, Amanda and Ethan came to me with the proposal for another performance of *Look Back in Anger*, they pitched two more ideas as well. The first was that all the profits would go to Cancer Research in the hope of finding a solution for future sufferers—to which I agreed and we’ll be sending a cheque off first thing in the morning.”

The audience erupted into applause and Claire started crying. She didn’t know about this. She brought a tissue up to her eyes and dabbed them as, row by row, the audience stood once more, their eyes all focusing on her. When the theatre had fallen quiet again, Moggs continued.

“And the other idea,” he said, nodding to Claire’s friends who were positioned behind the wheelchair, “was this.”

They manoeuvred the wheelchair around so Claire could see the veiled surprise. Zack and Natalie were at one end and Ethan and Amanda were at the other. “Ladies and gentlemen,” Moggs said, “I’m proud to announce that from this day forward, John Douglas High School Theatre will be known as the Claire Trent Theatre.”

The four students whipped back the cover to reveal a beautifully crafted sign and Claire immediately descended into more floods of tears. Her body shook with emotion and her four students, the students she’d shared the horror of that fateful night with, the students who would forever be a part of her and she a part of them, stepped forward to join her.

The applause was deafening as they each went to hug her and hold her one last time on the stage. Emotion overcame them too as, one by one, they realised that it was all coming to an end. This thing, this group that had got them through the best times and the absolute worst times was losing their matriarch.

Zack cried more than anyone as he held her and she held him. Cameras flashed and flashed and flashed. The five of them stayed glued to one

another's sides for the remainder of the night, but it was only a few minutes before the caretaker wanted to lock everything up that they got to be alone together.

"Well," Claire said, her voice strained from all the crying. "You never fail to embarrass me, do you?"

They all laughed. "Sorry, Miss T. It seemed like too good an opportunity to pass up."

She reached out, taking his hand. "I want you all to promise me something."

"Course," Natalie said. "Anything."

"I've been where you are. I know what it's like when you leave high school. You say you'll stay in touch with people, but, over time, you drift apart. I want you to promise me that you won't."

"We won't, Miss T," Ethan said.

"We won't, Miss," Amanda agreed.

"You don't have to worry," Zack said. "This is my crew now. This is my gang. There are a lot of similarities between this one and the one I used to be in. We're close, sure. We have a laugh together. We get on. But in my old crew, we always said we'd die for one another. And that's something, that is. Saying you'll die for somebody. But there's something bigger than that. And that's what I've realised, thanks to you guys. Living for one another is the greatest bond you can offer."

Natalie reached out and took Zack's hand before he continued. "I promise, Miss T. I'm going to live for my crew. I'm going to keep us together. I'm going to be there when any of them need me. You don't have to worry."

He let go of Natalie's hand and knelt down in front of Claire, taking hers instead. Tears filled both their eyes. "You can have a rest now. I've got it from here."

The End

OceanofPDF.com

For exclusive content and the latest news, join my mailing list. Claim a free book too. All you need to do is click the link:

<https://dl.bookfunnel.com/1v9xdaxx77>

[OceanofPDF.com](https://oceanofpdf.com)

Acknowledgements

Tina had a special part to play in this one. Not only did she come up with the cover concept, but she managed to keep me grounded during the writing process, which was no small accomplishment. This book is as much hers as mine.

A big thank you for the continued support from the amazing gang across in the fan club on Facebook (now called Christopher Artinian's Safe Haven). You rock!

Massive thanks to my brilliant editor, Ken. His help and guidance are priceless. And a huge thank you to the wonderful Christian Bentulan for another fantastic cover.

And, last but not least, thank you to you for buying this book. Your continued support makes every difference.

OceanofPDF.com

A note from the author

I really hope you enjoyed this book and would be very grateful if you took a minute to leave a review on Amazon and Goodreads.

If you would like to stay informed about what I'm doing, including current writing projects, and all the latest news and release information; these are the places to go:

Subscribe to the newsletter at

<https://landing.mailerlite.com/webforms/landing/i6q8k8>

Join the fan club on Facebook

<https://www.facebook.com/groups/127693634504226/>

Christopher Artinian author page

<https://www.facebook.com/safehaventrilogy/>

Buy exclusive and signed books and merchandise and stay up to date:

<https://www.christopherartinian.com/>

Follow me on YouTube:

https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCfJymx31VvzttB_Q-x5otYg

Follow me on Instagram:

<https://bit.ly/34ZUoOc>

Follow me on Amazon

<https://amzn.to/2I1lU6>

Follow me on Goodreads

<https://bit.ly/2P7iDzX>

Other books by Christopher Artinian:

Safe Haven: Rise of the RAMs <https://mybook.to/RiseoftheRAMs>

Safe Haven: Realm of the Raiders <https://mybook.to/SafeHavenRealm>

Safe Haven: Reap of the Righteous <https://mybook.to/SafeHavenReap>

Safe Haven: Ice <https://mybook.to/SafeHavenIce>

Safe Haven: Vengeance <https://mybook.to/SafeHavenVengeance>

Safe Haven: Is This the End of Everything? <https://bit.ly/3RHfFWg>

Safe Haven: Neverland (Part 1)

<https://mybook.to/SafeHavenNeverland1>

Safe Haven: Doomsday <https://mybook.to/SafeHavenDoomsday>

Safe Haven: Neverland (Part 2)

<https://mybook.to/SafeHavenNeverland2>

Safe Haven: Raining Blood (Part 1)

<https://mybook.to/RainingBloodpt1>

Safe Haven: Hope Street <https://mybook.to/SafeHavenHopeStreet>

Safe Haven: No Hope in Hell <https://mybook.to/SafeHaven11>

Safe Haven – War Zone <https://mybook.to/SafeHavenWarZone>

Before Safe Haven: Lucy <https://mybook.to/BSHLucy>

Before Safe Haven: Alex <https://mybook.to/BSHAlex>

Before Safe Haven: Mike <https://mybook.to/BSHMike>

Before Safe Haven: Jules: <https://mybook.to/BSHJules>

The End of Everything: Book 1 <https://mybook.to/EofE1>

The End of Everything: Book 2 <https://mybook.to/EofE2>

The End of Everything: Book 3 <https://mybook.to/EofE3>

The End of Everything: Book 4 <https://mybook.to/EndofEverything4>

The End of Everything: Book 5 <https://mybook.to/EofE4>

The End of Everything: Book 6 <https://mybook.to/EofE6>

The End of Everything: Book 7 <https://mybook.to/EofE7>

The End of Everything: Book 8 <https://mybook.to/EofE8>

The End of Everything: Book 9 <https://mybook.to/EofE9>

The End of Everything: Book 10: <https://mybook.to/EofE10>

The End of Everything: Book 11: <https://mybook.to/EofE11>

The End of Everything: Book 12: <https://mybook.to/EofE12>

The End of Everything: Book 13: <https://mybook.to/EofE13>

The End of Everything: Book 14: <https://mybook.to/EofE14>

Relentless: <https://mybook.to/RelentlessBk1>

Relentless 2: <https://mybook.to/RelentlessBk2>

Relentless 3: <https://mybook.to/RelentlessBk3>

The Burning Tree: Book 1 – Salvation <https://mybook.to/BurningTree1>

The Burning Tree: Book 2 – Rebirth <https://mybook.to/BTRebirth>

The Burning Tree: Book 3 – Infinity <https://mybook.to/BTInfinity>

The Burning Tree: Book 4 – Anarchy

<https://mybook.to/BurningTreeAnarchy>

The Burning Tree: Book 5 – Redemption

<https://mybook.to/TheBurningTree5>

The Burning Tree: Book 6 – Power (Part 1)

<https://mybook.to/BTPower1>

The Burning Tree: Book 7 – Power (Part 2)

<https://mybook.to/BTPower2>

Night of the Demons <https://mybook.to/NightoftheDemons>

The Devil's Face <https://mybook.to/FaceotD>

Anthologies featuring short stories by Christopher Artinian

Undead Worlds: A Reanimated Writers Anthology

Featuring: Before Safe Haven: Losing the Battle by Christopher Artinian

Tales from Zombie Road: The Long-Haul Anthology

Featuring: Condemned by Christopher Artinian

Treasured Chests: A Zombie Anthology for Breast Cancer Care

Featuring: Last Light by Christopher Artinian

Trick or Treat Thrillers (Best Paranormal 2018)

Featuring: The Akkadian Vessel.

OceanofPDF.com

Christopher Artinian

Christopher Artinian was born and raised in Leeds, West Yorkshire. Wanting to escape life in a big city and concentrate more on working to live than living to work, he and his family moved to the Outer Hebrides in the north-west of Scotland in 2004, where he now works as a full-time author.

Chris is a huge music fan, a cinephile, an avid reader and a supporter of Yorkshire County Cricket Club. When he's not sitting in front of his laptop living out his next post-apocalyptic/dystopian/horror adventure, he will be passionately immersed in one of his other interests.